

WinFixIT

User Manual

- **Checks Compatibility of any PC to run Windows 11,**
- **Installs it,** bypassing its usual TPM requirements, if needed,
- **Installs Office** and any other Apps Loaded on USB,
- **Debloats Windows 11** from unwanted Apps and Settings,
- **Library** of curated off-line and on-line reference material, Utilities and Software Tools,
- **Extensible** add your own Apps, Menus and Options, simply by adding files and folders to the USB. 😊



Table of Contents

INTRODUCTION	6
Running the System	6
From Within Windows	6
From the USB Stick Alone	6
Introduction Screen	8
The Main Menu	9
Starting From the USB Alone	10
WITHOUT Windows on Your PC	10
WITH Windows on Your PC – WITHOUT a Compatibility Check	11
WITH Windows on Your PC – WITH a Check ALREADY COMPLETED ..	11
CHECKING COMPATIBILITY	12
Compatibility Results	12
Choose FULL or BYPASS Install	13
Printing Compatibility Checker Results	13
INSTALLATION OPTIONS	14
Backup Advice	15
INSTALLING from within Windows	15
Without a preliminary Compatibility Check.....	16
INSTALLING from WinPE	16
Technical Note	16
INSTALLING MICROSOFT WINDOWS 11	17
Installing Windows 11 – without a Microsoft Account.....	18
Windows 11 HOME	18
Windows 11 PRO	18
Traditional User Interface	19
Select language settings.....	19
Select keyboard settings	19
Select setup option	19
Product key.....	20
Select Image	20
Applicable notices and licence terms.....	20
Select location to install Windows 11	21
Ready to Install.....	21
Installing Windows 11	21
New User Interface	22
Technical Note	22
Install Windows 11	22
Get updates, drivers and	23
Applicable notices and licence terms.....	23
Ready to Install.....	24
Choose what to keep.....	24
Ready to Install	24

Installing Windows 11	25
Installation Complete	26
DeBloating Windows 11	26
Groups and Options.....	27
Resetting your Options	28
Buttons at the Bottom of the Form	29
Currently Available Options	30
Groups with Somewhat Different Behaviour	32
Microsoft Accounts.....	32
Select Default Browser	32
Tidy the Start Menu & Simplify the Taskbar	32
PERFORM Selected Options	33
The Task Log	33
Stopping a Run.....	33
PRO Version Only Options	34
OPEN Library	35
Hyperlinks	35
Selecting Options.....	35
LIBRARY Contents	37
LIBRARY Update Menu	38
Appendix A - Booting from a USB	39
Insert the USB Drive	39
Restart the Computer	39
UEFI V's BIOS.....	39
Getting into the UEFI or BIOS	40
Example BIOSs	41
Asus.....	41
Gigabyte.....	43
An Earlier Boot Menu	46
Using System Recovery.....	47
Choose an option.....	47
Use a Device	47
On2it-WinFixIT - INTRODUCTION	48

Appendix B - Installing Windows 11	49
42% Installing Caution.....	49
Choose Your Country or Region.....	50
Choose your Keyboard	50
Name Your Device	50
How would you like to set up this device?	51
Unlock your Microsoft experience.....	51
Let's add your Microsoft account	52
Choose a way to sign in	52
Verify your Phone Number / Enter password	53
Use your face to sign in	53
Now set up a PIN	53
Choose privacy settings for your device	54
Getting the latest features and security updates	55
Welcome Back.....	55
Let's customise your experience.....	55
Use your phone from your PC.....	56
Your Microsoft account and phone are now linked	56
Always have access to your recent browsing data	56
Did you know.....	56
YOU'RE IN	57
Appendix C - DeBloater Groups & Options	59
Major Windows Features.....	59
Remove Microsoft 365	59
Remove OneDrive	59
Remove Microsoft Teams.....	60
Turn BitLocker OFF	61
KEEP CoPilot	61
KEEP Recall	62
Microsoft Accounts	63
Create and Sign in with a Local Account	63
Remove Microsoft Account entirely	63
Remove Unwanted Apps.....	64
Remove Outlook for Windows	64
Remove Xbox.....	64
KEEP Solitaire	65
Select Default Browser	65
Microsoft Edge SELECTED	66
INSTALL Google Chrome.....	66
INSTALL Firefox	66
INSTALL Brave	67
INSTALL Opera	67

Tidy the Start Menu.....	68
Remove Microsoft 365 PIN from the Start Menu	68
Remove Xbox PIN from the Start Menu	68
KEEP Solitaire pinned to Start Menu	68
Remove LinkedIn PIN from the Start Menu.....	68
KEEP Outlook pinned to Start Menu	69
KEEP File Explorer pinned to Start Menu	69
KEEP Calculator pinned to Start Menu	69
KEEP Notepad pinned to Start Menu	69
KEEP Snipping Tool pinned to Start Menu.....	69
KEEP Photos pinned to Start Menu	70
Simplify the Taskbar	70
KEEP Search Box, ON the Taskbar.....	70
KEEP CoPilot, ON the Taskbar.....	71
KEEP File Manager, ON the Taskbar.....	71
KEEP Edge, ON the Taskbar.....	71
KEEP Outlook, ON the Taskbar	71
Remove Microsoft Store, FROM the Taskbar	72
Keep the Desktop Clean	72
KEEP Recycle Bin, ON the Desktop	72
Remove Edge, FROM the Desktop.....	72
Privacy & Telemetry	72
Remove Advertising ID	72
Remove Tailored Experiences.....	72
Remove Inking and Typing Personalisation	73
Remove Location Tracking	73
Remove Activity History	73
Remove Feedback Frequency.....	73
Remove Diagnostic Data Upload	74
Remove Cloud Content Suggestions.....	74
Remove Web Search in Start Menu.....	74
KEEP SmartScreen Filter	75
Remove Microsoft Edge Telemetry	75
Remove Customer Experience Improvement Program	75
Performance Acceleration.....	75
ENABLE Low Latency Profile (LLP)	76
ENABLE Scheduler Responsiveness Mode.....	76
ENABLE Reduced Background Task Latency	76
Performance Acceleration.....	76
DISABLE Transparency Effects.....	76
DISABLE Window Animations.....	76
Background Services.....	77
Remove Widgets Service	77
Remove Xbox Game Bar Service.....	77
Remove Xbox Live Auth Manager.....	77
Remove Xbox Accessory Management Service.....	77
Remove Game DVR and Capture Service	78
Remove OneDrive Auto-Start	78
KEEP Windows Spotlight Service	78

KEEP Windows Search Service 78

Remove Suggested Actions Service 78

System Experience 79

 Remove Tips and Suggestions 79

 Remove Lock Screen Spotlight 79

 Remove Start Menu Recommendations 79

 Remove Suggested Apps 79

 Remove Suggested Content in Settings 79

 Remove Automatic App Launching 80

 Remove Suggested Actions 80

 Remove AutoPlay 80

 KEEP Snap Assist..... 80

 KEEP Clipboard History..... 81

 Remove Nearby Sharing..... 81

Security and Network..... 81

 Remove IPv6..... 81

 Remove Fast Startup 81

 Remove Hibernation 82

Windows Update..... 82

 Set Active Hours 82

 DISABLE Automatic Driver Updates 82

 DISABLE Delivery Optimisation 83

File Explorer 83

 SHOW File Extensions 83

 Remove Hidden Files..... 84

 Remove Frequent Folders 84

 Remove Recent Files 84

Notifications 84

 Remove Notification Badges 84

 Remove Notification Sounds..... 85

Appendix D - Updating the LIBRARY Menu Error! Bookmark not defined.

Menu Creation Rules.....Error! Bookmark not defined.

How To – Update the LIBRARY MenuError! Bookmark not defined.

 Create a New Sub-FolderError! Bookmark not defined.

 Folder Order Determines Menu Order ...Error! Bookmark not defined.

 Required Files Inside Each Sub-FolderError! Bookmark not defined.

 Menu “Introduction.txt” and “Option Description.txt” Files.....Error!

Bookmark not defined.

 Using Colour CodesError! Bookmark not defined.

 Start.bat — How WinFixIT Launches InstallersError! Bookmark not defined.

Testing Your New ProductError! Bookmark not defined.

 Common Mistakes.....Error! Bookmark not defined.

File and Folder Structure.....Error! Bookmark not defined.

The Install\Windows FolderError! Bookmark not defined.

INTRODUCTION

Once you've got WinFixIT, you should not need this manual.

As WinFixIT explains everything* incrementally, as you go along – exactly when you need to know it, without you having to ask for HELP.

This 'User Manual' is primarily intended for people who do not have access to a copy of the system, so that they can evaluate what it does – before they have a copy.

It does not matter whether your PC has Windows already installed or not. If your machine has no Operating System installed, you can set your machine's BIOS to boot from your USB Drive -

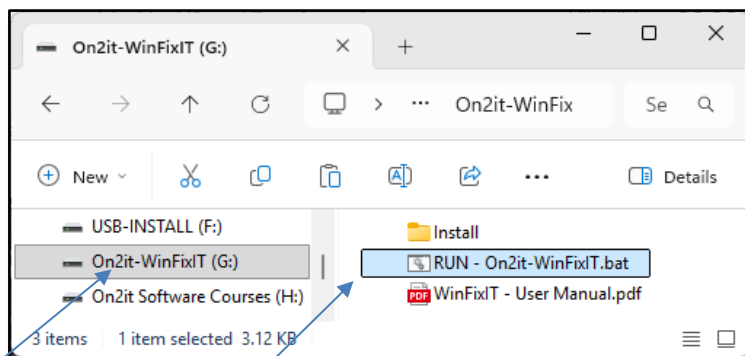
see [Appendix A – Booting from a USB](#).

When you re-start your machine, a copy of WinPE* will be loaded for you, and start running WinFixIT.

Running the System

From Within Windows

To run the system from within a full copy of Windows (any version will do), the way you start **WinFixIT** is exactly the same.



On the USB, in partition **On2it-WinFixIT**, a file called **RUN - On2it-WinFixIT.bat** will start WinFixIT. Simply double-click the file.

This will display the **User Account Control** Dialog. This is a security feature built into Windows that protects your PC from unauthorised changes.

WinFixIT requests these elevated privileges because many of the tasks it performs — such as installing software, modifying system settings, and accessing protected folders — require Administrator rights. Without them, Windows would block these operations.

So, simply click **Yes**.



This will then display the **Introduction Screen**.

From the USB Stick Alone

You can also run WinFixIT from just the USB alone – whether or not you have Windows on your PC. To do so, you will need to:

- **Boot from the USB**, see [Appendix A - Booting from a USB](#)

This will take you straight into the Introduction Screen below

* An exception might be if you want to modify or extend its [LIBRARY](#). This is a multi-level, user-editable and infinitely-extensible Dynamic Menu System, driven entirely by the files and folders on the USB. As, understanding how it works, so simply, will definitely assist you in modifying or extending it. Obviously, we've given full working examples. 😊

* **WinPE is a lightweight, stripped-down version of Windows** used mainly for installing, repairing, or recovering full Windows systems. It boots independently from USB, DVD, or a network and provides just enough Windows functionality to run setup tools, imaging utilities, diagnostics, and recovery operations.

Introduction Screen

We won't duplicate what it says, here, as it is hopefully, self-explanatory.

```
=====
                        On2it-WinFixIT - INTRODUCTION
=====
On2it-WinFixIT operates in these main phases:

CHECK Compatibility checks the ability of your PC to run Windows 11,
whether it has an OS loaded or not.

It advises you whether your machine is capable of a:
- FULL Install if it is fully compatible, and passes all the tests.
- BYPASS Install if your hardware is capable of running Windows 11,
  but does not have all the security features that Microsoft likes to insist on.
  This enables you to still install Windows 11 on older but capable machines.

INSTALL Windows then gives you the choice of your available options.

Once Windows is installed on your PC, whether installed from this USB or not,
you will also be able to:

    DEBLOAT Windows 11 itself, from much of the software that Microsoft insists on installing
    along with Windows 11. You can either accept all of our default advice, or since you
    will receive FULL advice on each option, you can choose options that are right for YOU.

    READ User Manual – if you want to. But since the whole system explains itself as you go,
    you really shouldn't need to. It's there if you need it.

    OPEN Library to:
    - INSTALL Apps pre-loaded by us or ones you've added yourself,
    - READ Reference material – both off-line and on-line,
    - USE Utilities and Downloadable Software,
    - ADD your own Apps, Menus and Options, simply by adding files and folders to the USB.

Press ANY Key to continue...
```

This Introduction Screen will be displayed only once.

When you **Press ANY Key to continue**, what you will then see depends upon whether you started from:

- within Windows, or
- from the USB stick alone:
 - WITHOUT Windows on your PC, or
 - WITH Windows on Your PC
 - WITHOUT a Compatibility Check done yet
 - WITH a Compatibility Check already done

The next screen gives you appropriate advice and options – depending on where to started from.

The Main Menu

If you started from within Windows, you will see:

Simply Enter **CHECK**, **INSTALL**, **DEBLOAT**, **READ**, **OPEN** or **exit** to tell the system what you want to do next, and press <Enter>. It is NOT case-sensitive. (If you booted from your USB, then only the first two options above, will be available. You can run the remainder, after you have installed Windows.)

When you have done, whatever you set out to do, you will be returned here to make you next choice.

If you enter **CHECK** and press the <Enter>Key, you will end up at the Compatibility Checker:

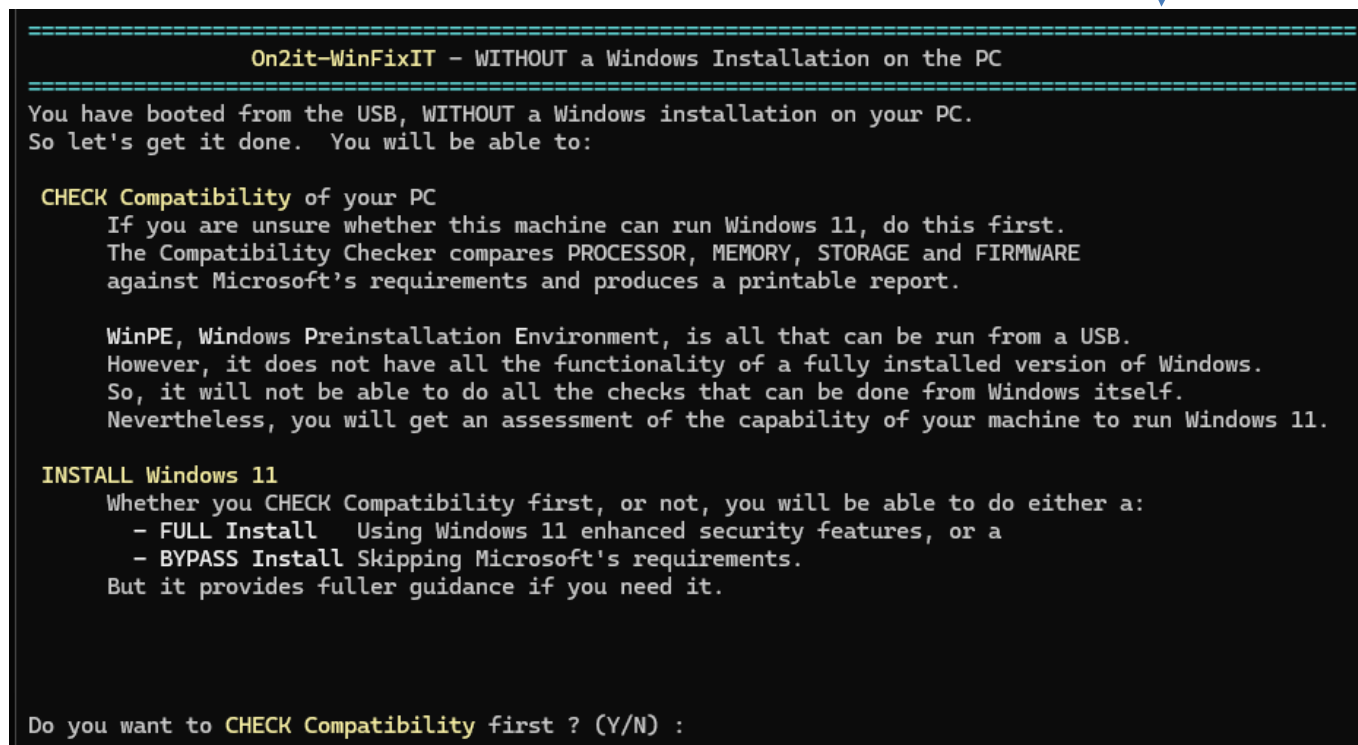
Starting From the USB Alone

If you started from the USB alone you will NOT see the MAIN-MENU, above.

You WILL see the INTRODUCTION, which tells you what the system does. Then you will see

WITHOUT Windows on Your PC

If you don't have Windows on your Machine, you will see:

A screenshot of a terminal window with a black background and green text. The text is as follows:

```
=====
On2it-WinFixIT - WITHOUT a Windows Installation on the PC
=====

You have booted from the USB, WITHOUT a Windows installation on your PC.
So let's get it done. You will be able to:

CHECK Compatibility of your PC
If you are unsure whether this machine can run Windows 11, do this first.
The Compatibility Checker compares PROCESSOR, MEMORY, STORAGE and FIRMWARE
against Microsoft's requirements and produces a printable report.

WinPE, Windows Preinstallation Environment, is all that can be run from a USB.
However, it does not have all the functionality of a fully installed version of Windows.
So, it will not be able to do all the checks that can be done from Windows itself.
Nevertheless, you will get an assessment of the capability of your machine to run Windows 11.

INSTALL Windows 11
Whether you CHECK Compatibility first, or not, you will be able to do either a:
- FULL Install Using Windows 11 enhanced security features, or a
- BYPASS Install Skipping Microsoft's requirements.
But it provides fuller guidance if you need it.

Do you want to CHECK Compatibility first ? (Y/N) :
```

If you answer NO, you will be asked:

A screenshot of a terminal window with a black background and green text. The text is:

```
Do you want to INSTALL Windows 11 ? (Y/N) :
```

Depending on your answers you will be taken to the Compatibility Checker or the Installer, as appropriate.

The other options only become available AFTER you have installed Windows 11 and restarted WinFixIT

[From Within Windows](#) 😊

WITH Windows on Your PC – WITHOUT a Compatibility Check

If you have a full version of Windows on your PC, but have booted from the USB, WITHOUT a Compatibility Check having been done yet, you will be advised:

```
=====
On2it-WinFixIT - WITHOUT a Compatibility Check in Windows
=====
You have booted from the USB, whilst you have an installation of Windows on your PC, without
first having run the Windows11 Compatibility Checker under Windows - or NOT made a choice, if you did
.

Only if the Compatibility Checker has the services of a full operating system, can it produce
fully comprehensive results.

If you run it from the Windows Installation environment, WinPE, which is all that is available
when you boot from a USB, the Checker will NOT be able to produce fully comprehensive results.

You are strongly advised therefore to NOT run the Windows11-Compatibility Checker right NOW.
You should:
- Abandon this run.
- Restart Windows on your PC, and
- Re-run On2it-WinFixIT.bat on the USB, from Windows.

Would you prefer to run the Compatibility Checker from Windows? (Y/N) :
```

If you answer NO to the above question, you will be warned:

```
You realise, that if you run the Compatibility Checker right NOW, it WILL produce
inconclusive results. So, you will ALWAYS be advised to run a 'BYPASS Install' - to be safe.

If you want to be really sure whether your machine will be able to take a 'FULL Install'
of Windows, you should answer "N" to the next question.

Are you ABSOLUTELY SURE you want to run the Compatibility Checker NOW? (Y/N) :
```

If you answer YES to the above, then you will be taken to the Compatibility Checker.

If you answer NO the run will be terminated with:

WITH Windows on Your PC – WITH a Check ALREADY COMPLETED

You will see:

```
=====
On2it-WinFixIT - Compatibility Check ALREADY COMPLETED in Windows
=====
Congratulations - You have successfully re-booted from the USB

When you ran the Windows11-CompatibilityChecker in Windows, you had the options of:
- FULL Install,
- BYPASS Install.
You chose a BYPASS Install.

Do you wish to proceed with a BYPASS Install? (Y/N) : |
```

The question asked will reflect your previous choice. 😊

If you answer YES you will see your Installation Options. You will get an option to change your mind, even at this late stage.

CHECKING COMPATIBILITY

If you enter **CHECK** and press the <Enter>Key, you will see on the bottom of the screen:

```
Please ENTER (CHECK/INSTALL/POST/READ) or EXIT :CHECK
Windows11 Computer Compatibility Results for - BRIANS-PC
=====
PROCESSOR : [PASSED]
MEMORY    : [PASSED]
STORAGE   : [PASSED]
FIRMWARE  : [WARNING]...
Press <Enter> to continue ...
```

This tells me that the Processor, Memory and Storage on my machine are all OK. But there is a **[WARNING]** about my FIRMWARE. *These Results are there, only to convince you the PC is busy and it's actually, doing something! It's a bit more informative than just a row of dots. It's not too slow, anyway.* 😊

To see a more detailed report Press <Enter> to continue ... When you do, you will see your Compatibility Results:

Compatibility Results

This gives you the results of the test. Your results will of course differ.

Windows 11 Requirements are shown in yellow:

[PASSED] indicates your machine has passed a specific test.

[WARNING] on ANY test, indicates that you will not be able to perform a FULL install that makes use of all of Windows 11's new security features.

[FAILED] on ANY test, indicates that your machine CANNOT run Windows 11.

Pale Grey text gives you more information about the results of each test.

```
Windows11 Computer Compatibility Results for - BRIANS-PC
=====
PROCESSOR: CPU: AMD Ryzen 5 5600G with Radeon Graphics [6 cores 3.9 GHz]
           Minimum requirements are x64 architecture - 2 cores 1.0 GHz Processor.
[PASSED] - This CPU meets Windows 11 requirements.

MEMORY:    Windows 11 has minimum requirement of only 4GB
[PASSED] - This PC has 15 GB of RAM.

STORAGE:   Official Requirement is a minimum of 64 GB on the System Drive.
           But to be realistic you need at least 500 GB for most working machines.
[PASSED] - System Drive Capacity 496 GB Free Space 368 GB
           Largest single drive 932 GB
           Total storage all drives 2819 GB

FIRMWARE:  A FULL Install of Windows 11 requires UEFI firmware with Secure Boot enabled,
           TPM 2.0, and a system disk using the GPT partition style.
           - A BYPASS Install circumvents these requirements -- see advice below.
[PASSED] Partition style is GPT.
[PASSED] Secure Boot is enabled.
[PASSED] TPM 2.0 detected.
[WARNING] Legacy BIOS detected.
           Windows 11 requires UEFI firmware for a FULL Install.
           You will HAVE to use a BYPASS Install.

Would you like to print the above Results? (Y/N) :
```

Choose **FULL** or **BYPASS** Install

For the above Results you would see at the bottom of the screen:

```
Your ONLY Installation Option is:
BYPASS Install
  This can be used to install Windows 11 on older machines that are capable of running
  Windows 11 that do not have the security enhancements necessary for a FULL install.
  Since you have some [WARNING]s above a FULL Install, is not an option.
  Please ENTER (BYPASS/) :
```

If Your PC meets all requirements for Windows 11, you would see:

```
Your PC meets all requirements for Windows 11.
So, BOTH installation options are possible:
FULL Install
  Your machine is fully capable of running Windows 11, including all the additional
  security features it enables. This should be your PREFERRED OPTION.
BYPASS Install
  This is normally used to install Windows 11 on older machines that are capable of running it,
  but lack the security enhancements required for a FULL INSTALL.
  On YOUR machine, it is unnecessary to select this option.
  Particularly because, according to Microsoft, it could lead to future problems.
  Please ENTER (FULL/BYPASS/) :
```

If you get one or more tests **[FAILED]** you would see:

```
SORRY. Your machine does not meet the minimum hardware requirements to run Windows 11.
You will either have to:
- Upgrade your hardware to overcome the issues that were [FAILED] above.
- Buy a new computer.
- Continue using what you have.
  Please ENTER ( ) :
```

If you run the Compatibility Checker under WinPE, it will not be able to perform ALL checks required. So, you will receive **[WARNING]s**, simply because those checks could not be done. In which case, you will see both installation options:

```
Your Installation Options are:
FULL Install
  Your machine MIGHT be fully capable of running Windows 11, as ALL the [WARNING]s were
  about things that could not be checked. But, if you choose a Full Install, it could fail.
  If it fails the Installer will simply stop, and you will have wasted your time, that's all.
BYPASS Install
  This can be used to install Windows 11 on older machines that are capable of running Windows 11,
  but which do not have the security enhancements necessary for a FULL Install.
  Since ALL the [WARNING]s were about things that could not be checked, this is your SAFE option.
  But, of course, you will not have Windows 11 enhanced security features.
  And, according to Microsoft, it could lead to future problems.
  However, if you are confident that your Machine DOES have ALL the features
  that could not be checked, then you might get away with a FULL Install.
  Please ENTER (FULL/BYPASS/) :
```

Then, depending on the options presented you can enter, **FULL**, **BYPASS** or simply press <enter> to take you back to the MAIN-MENU.

Printing Compatibility Checker Results

Before going further, you will then see:

If you want a printed copy of the Results, just say **Y**. You will note that they include the PC name. So, if you have several machines to do, you will know which set of results, is for which machine.

If there is no printer attached, the results will still be on the **On2it-WinFixIT** Partition, in:

\Logs\Win11-CompatibilityChecker-Results.txt

You can, of course, Print to PDF, if you want to.'

INSTALLATION OPTIONS

It does not matter whether you ran **COMPATIBILITY Checking** first and chose a **BYPASS** or **FULL** Install, or chose **INSTALL** on the **MAIN MENU**, you will see:

```
=====
                        On2it-WinFixIT - INSTALLATION OPTIONS
=====
When installing Windows 11 using On2it-WinFixIT, you have two distinct paths
depending on how you start the installer:

Installing from within Windows
If you're currently running Windows and launch On2it-WinFixIT from your desktop:
- You can choose to keep your existing files, apps, and settings.
- This is ideal if your system is working well and you simply
  want to refresh or repair Windows.
- You'll be guided through options like:
  - Keep everything (files, apps, settings)
  - Keep personal files only
  - Wipe everything and start fresh

Installing by booting from USB
If you restart your computer and boot directly from the USB stick:
- You'll enter a special lightweight mode called the
  Windows Preinstallation Environment, or WinPE.
- WinPE is designed for clean installs and recovery ONLY.
  It doesn't load a full Windows system.
- In this mode, you can only perform a full clean install.
  All files, apps, and settings will be erased.

WHICH SHOULD YOU CHOOSE?
- If your system is working and you want flexibility - Start from Windows
- If your system is damaged or you want a clean slate - Boot from USB

On2it-WinFixIT will guide you through the correct steps based on how you started.
You'll always be shown clear choices before anything is installed.

Press ANY Key to continue...
```

This gives you guidance.

- **Installing from within Windows**, or
- **Installing by booting from USB**, and
- **WHICH SHOULD YOU CHOOSE.**

Simply **Press ANY Key to continue.**

Backup Advice

You will then receive the following advice:

```
=====
                        BEFORE YOU BEGIN - BACKUP YOUR DATA!
=====

Before installing Windows 11 - whether you're keeping your files or starting fresh,
it is strongly recommended that you create a backup of anything important.

Even if you choose to keep your files and apps:
- Mistakes can happen.
- Power interruptions, disk errors, or unexpected issues during installation may result in data loss.

If you choose a full clean install:
- All files, apps, and settings will be permanently erased.
- There is no undo once the process begins.

WHAT TO BACK UP:
- Documents, photos, and personal files
- Emails, browser bookmarks, and saved passwords
- Any app data or configuration files
- Anything stored on the Desktop or Downloads folder

You can use an external USB drive, cloud storage, or a network location - whatever suits your setup.

On2it-WinFixIT will not begin installation until you confirm your choice,
but it cannot recover lost data. Taking a backup now ensures peace of mind later.

Press ANY Key to continue...
```

It is GOOD advice. We HIGHLY RECOMMEND you follow it.

You might get away with it, but on the other hand 😞

Simply Press ANY Key to continue . . .

INSTALLING from within Windows

If you have started On2it-WinFixIT from within a full Windows environment (not necessarily Windows 11), you will see:

```
=====
                        On2it-WinFixIT - INSTALLING from within Windows
=====

You have started On2it-WinFixIT from within a full Windows environment.
This gives you the widest range of installation choices:
- Keep everything, preserves your files, apps, and settings.
- Keep personal files only, removes apps and resets settings.
- Wipe everything, performs a full clean install, removing all files, apps, and settings.

Even from within Windows, you can choose a full clean install if you want a fresh start.

Before proceeding, it is strongly recommended that you BACKUP ANY IMPORTANT DATA!
For, even if you choose to keep files, unexpected issues can still cause data loss.

PLEASE NOTE: The software on this USB can only be activated with Activation IDs purchased from:
shop.winandoffice.com/australia/

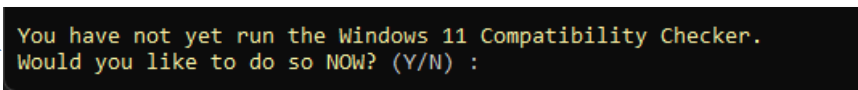
You have already Compatibility Checked this PC and chosen to do a 'FULL Install'.
Would you like to do a 'FULL Install' right NOW? (Y/N) :
```

If You have already Compatibility Checked this PC, it will know what choice you made, and simply ask whether you want to do it right now?

Without a preliminary Compatibility Check

If You have not yet run the Windows 11 Compatibility Checker

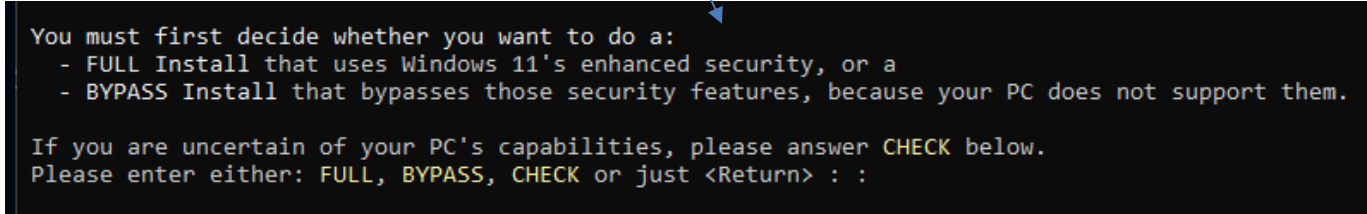
you will see:



```
You have not yet run the Windows 11 Compatibility Checker.  
Would you like to do so NOW? (Y/N) :
```

If you answer **Y** to **Would you like to do so now?** you will be taken to the Compatibility Checker.

If you answer **N**, you will see, on the bottom of the screen:



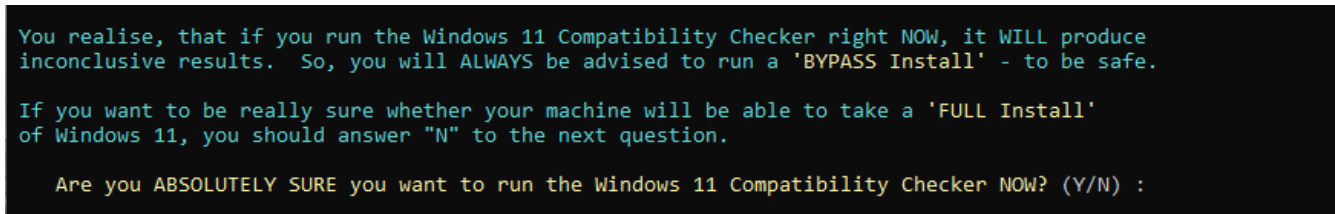
```
You must first decide whether you want to do a:  
- FULL Install that uses Windows 11's enhanced security, or a  
- BYPASS Install that bypasses those security features, because your PC does not support them.  
  
If you are uncertain of your PC's capabilities, please answer CHECK below.  
Please enter either: FULL, BYPASS, CHECK or just <Return> : :
```

Please enter either: **FULL**, **BYPASS**, **CHECK** or just press **<Return>** :

- **FULL** takes you to do a FULL Install,
- **BYPASS** enables you to do a **BYPASS** Install,
- **CHECK** obviously takes you to the Compatibility Checker, and
- **<Return>** or **<enter>** takes you back to the Main-Menu.

INSTALLING from WinPE

INSTALLING from WinPE, is a little different, as WinPE does not have all the functionality that the Compatibility Checker, needs. So, it cannot perform all the checks, it would like.



```
You realise, that if you run the Windows 11 Compatibility Checker right NOW, it WILL produce  
inconclusive results. So, you will ALWAYS be advised to run a 'BYPASS Install' - to be safe.  
  
If you want to be really sure whether your machine will be able to take a 'FULL Install'  
of Windows 11, you should answer "N" to the next question.  
  
Are you ABSOLUTELY SURE you want to run the Windows 11 Compatibility Checker NOW? (Y/N) :
```

Technical Note

When you choose a FULL Install, the System will install from:

On2IT-WinFixIT\INSTALL\Windows\FULL Install.ISO

So, if you don't want to use the ISO that is already on the USB, you can simply replace **FULL Install.ISO** with your own Windows ISO, and that will be installed in its place.

Similarly, if you replaced:

On2IT-WinFixIT\INSTALL\Windows\BYPASS Install.ISO

with your own Bypass ISO created with Rufus, then that ISO will be installed in its place.

INSTALLING MICROSOFT WINDOWS 11

This is the point where **Microsoft's own Windows Installer** takes over.

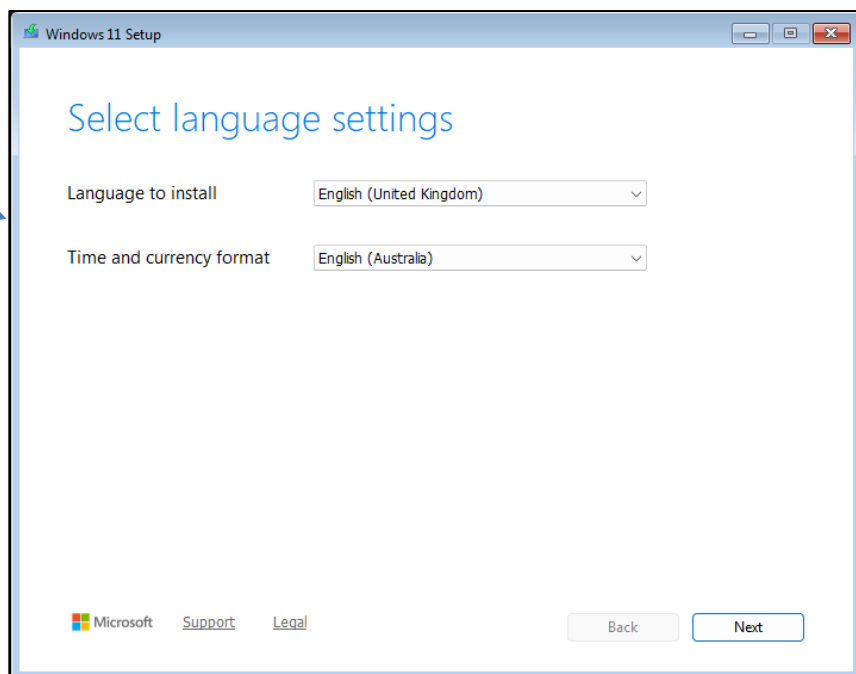
However, you may encounter either one of two introductions to the actual installation process dependent upon:

- where you obtained your installation files from,
- whether you have elected to start your install from:
 - within Windows, or
 - a totally clean install from a USB.

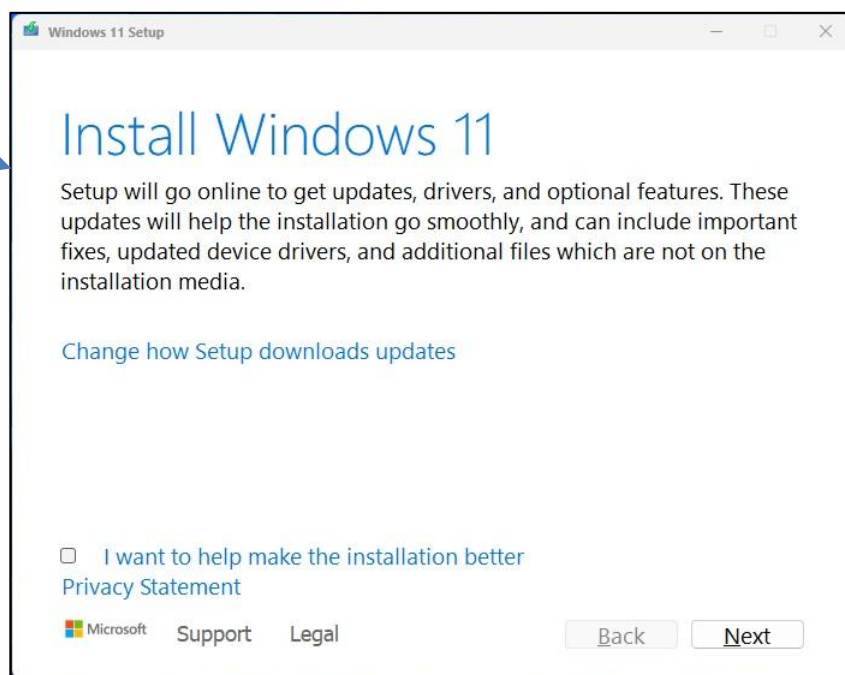
We will differentiate them by calling them the:

- **Traditional User Interface**, and the
- **New User Interface**.

Fortunately, it is very easy to tell them apart. If it looks like this, it's the **Traditional User Interface**.



If it looks like this, then you've got the **New User Interface**



Unfortunately, the questions they ask are somewhat different. The New User Interface, is somewhat simpler and easier to use. But it has been carefully crafted by Microsoft to get YOU to select the options THEY want you to make. So, we have to cover BOTH – after the next section.

Installing Windows 11 – without a Microsoft Account

Before we get into the details of each User Interface, it would be useful to discuss this subject, as many people are very concerned, some might say *paranoid*, about this subject.

The truth of the matter is that, if you want a mechanism to share data between your devices, you need something to join them together. You have to be able to prove that you are you, on BOTH devices. THAT is the basic functionality of your Microsoft Account. To quote from the advice given in the WinFixIT DeBloater, the pros and cons are:

Pros:

- Maximum privacy: no Microsoft Account linked to this PC.
- No cloud tie-ins or subscription prompts.

Cons:

Without a Microsoft Account you will not be able to:

- Synchronise your settings, preferences, and desktop across multiple PCs
- Use Microsoft Link to use your Mobile from your PC
- Transfer settings from your old PC to a new one
- Use Find My Device to locate a lost or stolen PC remotely
- Use Microsoft Store to download or purchase apps
- Access OneDrive cloud storage automatically
- Use Xbox Game Pass or Xbox Live features
- Recover your account if you forget your password, unless you have recovery questions on this PC

But despite what people say to the contrary you CAN still setup Windows 11 without a Microsoft Account. Your options depend on which version you intend to use. How you can do it depend upon which version of Windows 11 you are installing:

Windows 11 HOME

Microsoft have recently removed this option during Setup. You must complete Setup with a Microsoft Account, then remove it afterwards using WinFixIT's DeBloater.

Windows 11 PRO

During Setup

Either:

- Do not choose 'Set up for personal use'. Select **Set up for work or school** then click **Domain join instead** — this creates a local account without a Microsoft account. OR:
- Make sure you are NOT connected to the Internet, either wirelessly or by Ethernet cable. This will cause Windows Setup to ask you to select a wireless network. When it does so:
 - Press **<shift>+F10**. This will display a Command Prompt Window.
 - Enter **oobe\bypassnro** After you press **<enter>** the machine restarts and offers **I don't have internet** on the network screen, leading to a local account option.

After Installation

Run WinFixIT's DeBloater to either:

- Create and Sign in with a Local Account, or
- Remove Microsoft Account entirely.

The alternative routes described above are not illustrated in the User Interface walkthroughs below, as they would only complicate the normal flow. The simplest and *always available solution* — regardless of which version of Windows 11 you have installed — is to **use WinFixIT's DeBloater afterwards**. 😊

Traditional User Interface

If you have installed from the WinFixIT USB, you should not see the traditional interface – unless the ISOs on the USB, have been replaced.

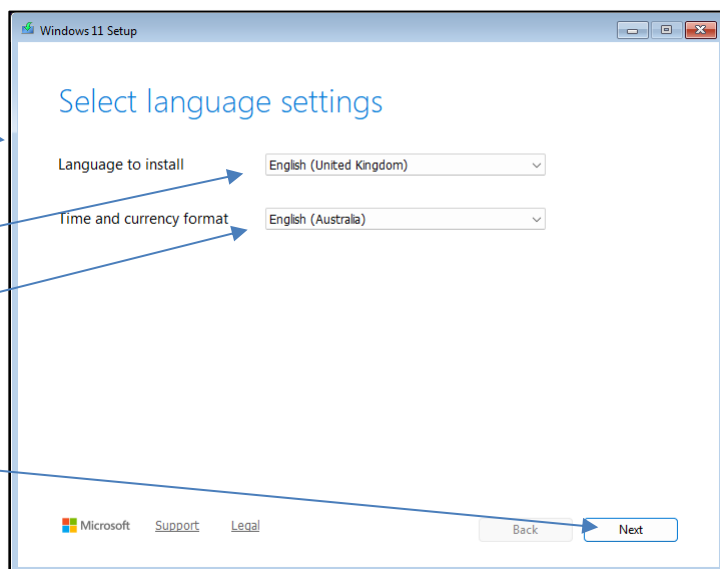
The first page of the Traditional User Interface looks like **this**.

Select language settings

Simply select the:

- **Language to install**, and the
- **Time and Currency format**.

Then click **Next**.

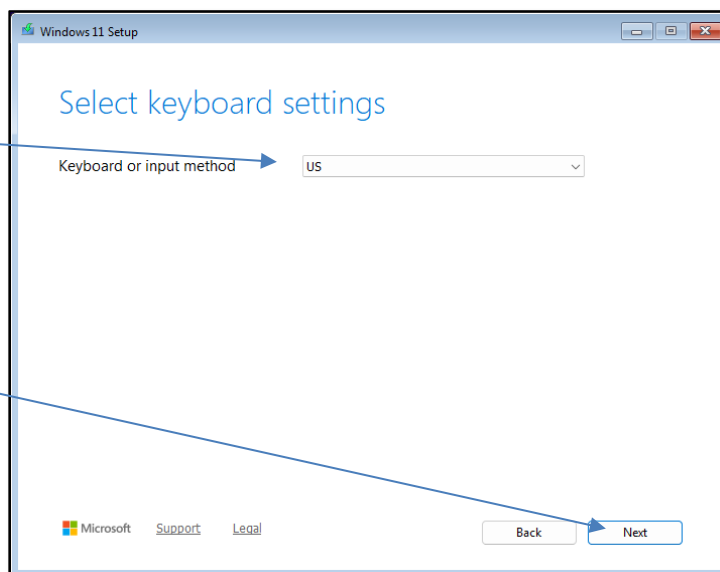


Select keyboard settings

Select **Keyboard or input method**.

The correct choice for Australia and New Zealand is **US**.

Click **Next**.



Select setup option

This is where you select whether want to:

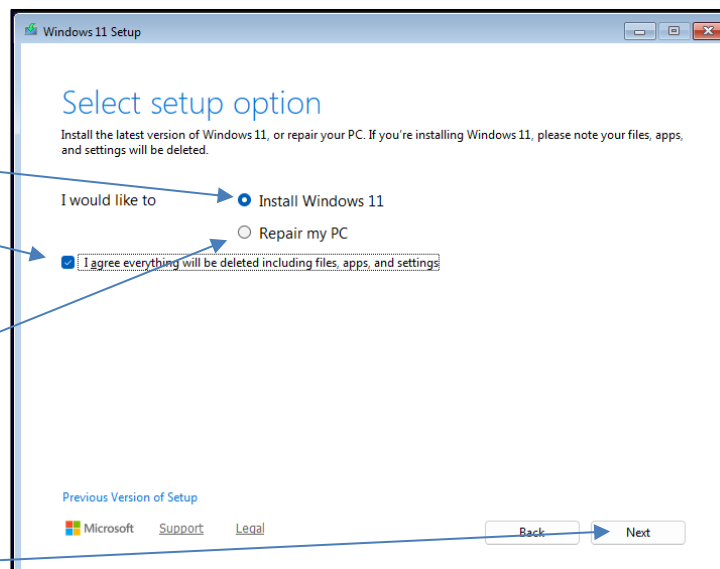
- **Install Windows 11**, and
- **I agree everything will be deleted including files, apps and settings.**

The **Next** Button will not be enabled unless you Tick, I agree!

Alternatively, you can select:

- **Repair my PC**

Once you have selected, Click **Next**.



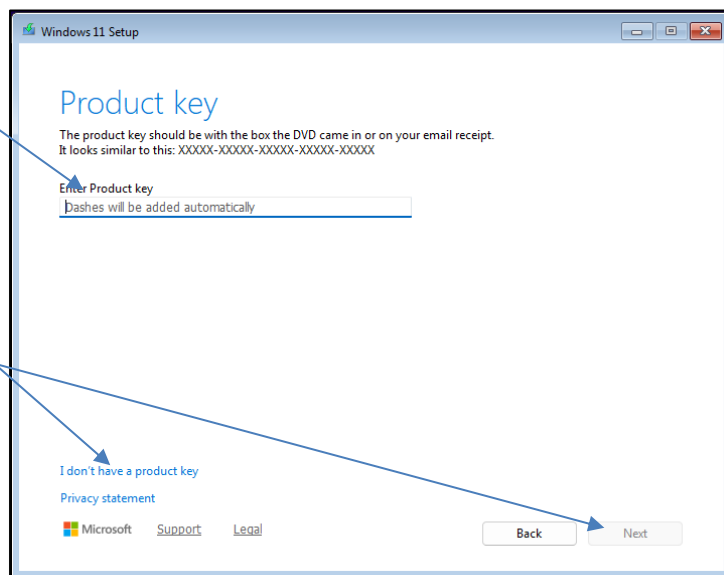
Product key

If you have one you can **Enter Product key** now.

If you don't Click **I don't have a product key** and click **Next**. (It will have been enabled for you.)

If you don't have a product key, Windows 11 will still run OK. The consequences of not registering your copy are:

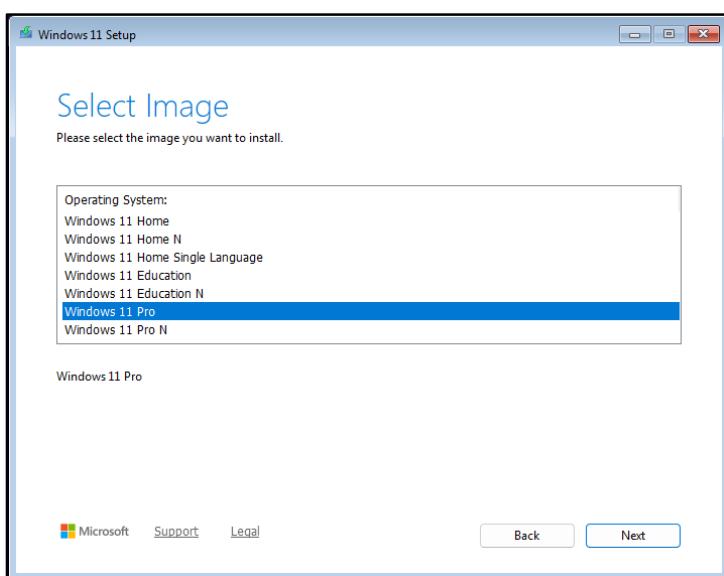
- You cannot personalise the desktop (wallpaper, colours locked)
- An "Activate Windows" watermark appears in the bottom-right corner
- Some settings pages show activation prompts



Select Image

This is where you select which version of Windows 11, you wish to run.

We strongly recommend **Windows 11 Pro**. There is very little difference in cost, between it and Windows HOME, if you are buying a Cheap CD Key on-line. (See WinFixIT's LIBRARY for several alternatives.)

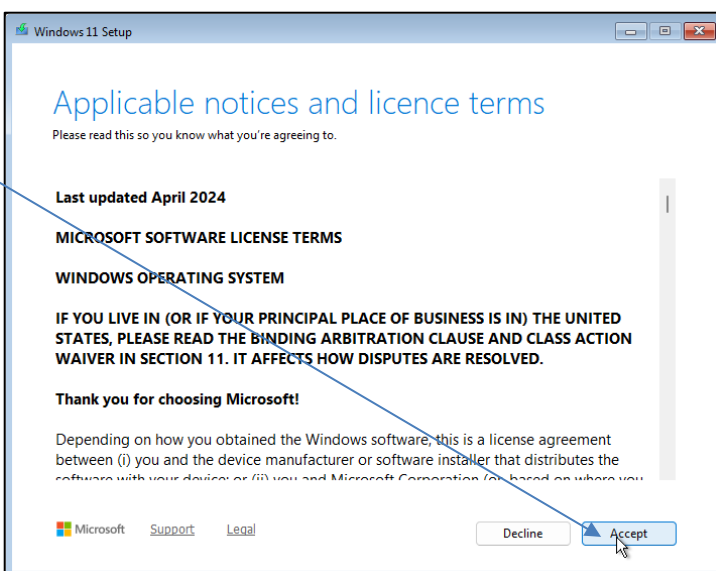


Applicable notices and licence terms

If you want to read them.

(I don't know anyone who does.)

If you want to used Windows 11 Click **Accept**.



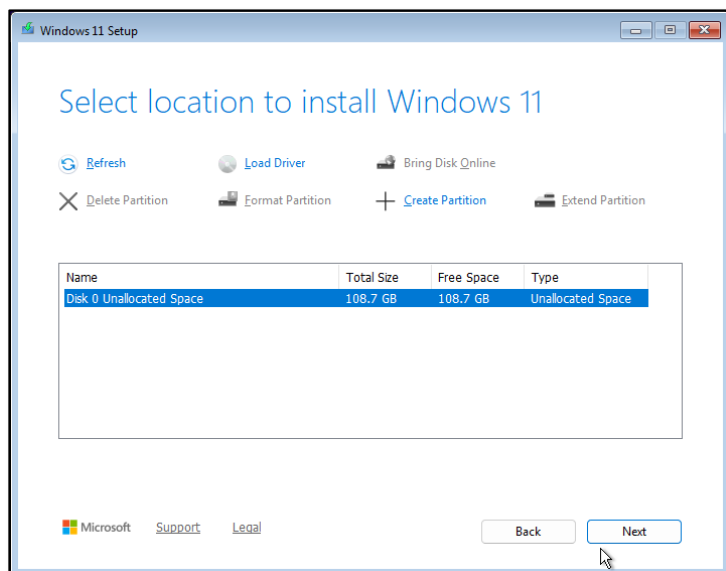
Select location to install Windows 11

This screen is the one most likely to put ‘the fear of God’ into new Users, as it looks pretty technical. For *if you know what you are doing* you can:

- **Refresh** the view of your drives,
- **Load Drivers** for your devices,
- **Bring Disk Online**,
- **Create Partitions**,
- **Extend Partitions**,
- **Format Partitions**, or
- **Delete Partitions**.

The good news is **you don’t have to**.

The system will have selected Unallocated Space on your System drive. So, all you have to do is Click **Next**.

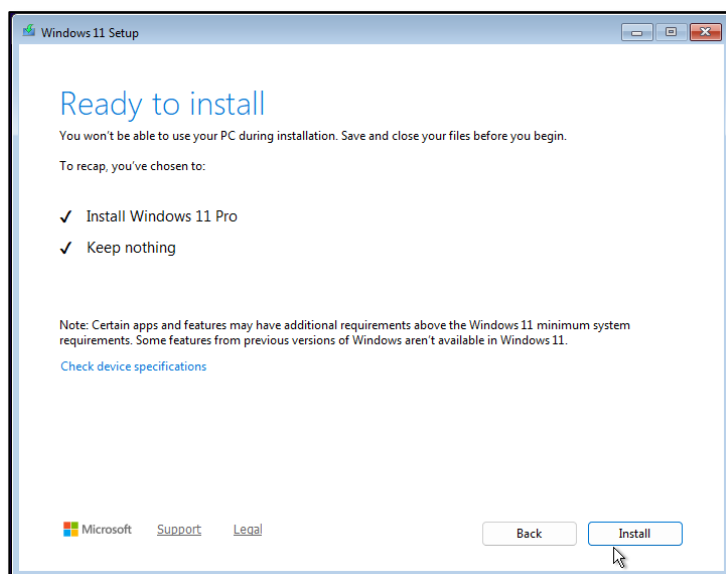


In the New User Interface, Microsoft have dropped this screen, entirely. 😊

Ready to Install

This is a final reminder of what you are about to do. Up until this point no changes have been made to your machine.

When ready ‘to light the blue touch paper’ Click **Install**.



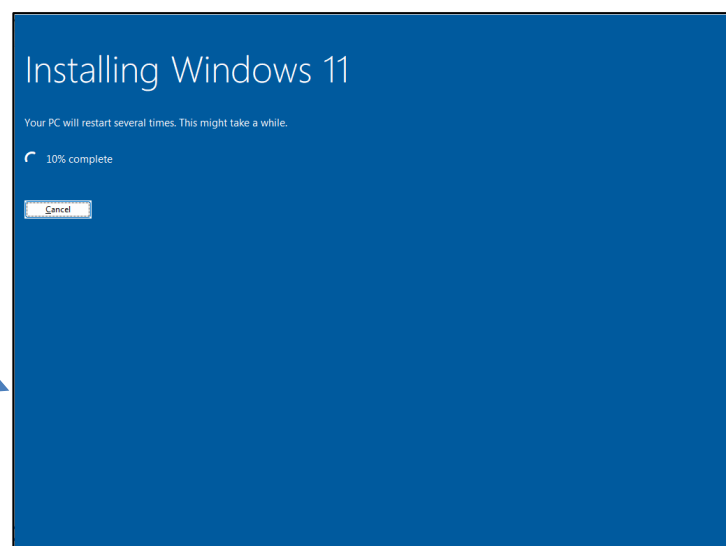
When you do you will see:

Installing Windows 11

From this point on both the:

- **Traditional User Interface**, and the
- **New User Interface**.

are the same. So, you can skip forward until you see **this screen** again.



New User Interface

THIS USED TO BE RELATIVELY STRAIGHT-FORWARD. IT NO-LONGER IS.

Even if you have installed Windows multiple times in the past **PAY ATTENTION.**

Microsoft have recently ‘enhanced’ the installer to try and make it almost impossible to do a BYPASS Install, or install from files on your PC – *unless you know how*. [This section tells you how](#).

It’s easy, but unless you know how, you will end up downloading Windows 11 from Microsoft’s servers – and you will not get a **BYPASS Install**, even if that is what you selected in WinFixIT!

What you will get is nearly an hour’s delay, whilst Microsoft insist you download their copy of the files that you may already have on your PC or USB.

The ‘enhanced’ installer will also default to an:

- UPGRADE install, which keeps your files, apps and settings.

So, if you want to do a:

- DATA ONLY install that keeps only your personal files, but remove all your apps and resets your settings; or a
- CLEAN Install that wipes everything – files, apps and settings

Then you have to know where to select those options during installation

Technical Note

This section is here to convince those that ‘THINK they know how’, to read on – to get the details!

The installer used to have two Command line switches:

- **/DynamicUpdate disable** This used to tell the installer not to download installation files from Microsoft’s Servers. It no-longer does. It gives you access to a prompt, that if you select it, it enables you to install from local setup files, or a local ISO on a USB, perhaps. But if you skip past the initial prompt it will download from Microsoft’s servers, anyway – *NASTY!*
- **/auto** used to enable you to specify UPGRADE, DATA ONLY or CLEAN. This switch no-longer has any effect on the installer. You now have to make this choice during the install. It now defaults to UPGRADE. So, read on...

Install Windows 11

After you choose your installation type in On2it-WinFixIT, the Microsoft Windows Installer will start. (You may see a brief “Setup is starting” message. This is normal.)

This is the first Install Windows 11 screen.

If you don’t want to do a BYPASS Install, and are willing to wait 50 minutes whilst it downloads from Microsoft’s Servers, by all means just click Next. It is designed to encourage everyone to do just that. **Thereby achieving their nefarious objective.**

Provided the installer was invoked with a **/DynamicUpdate** Switch, you will see **Change how setup downloads updates**.

(Don’t worry WinFixIT adds the switch for you automatically.)



If you want to:

- **install from local files**
on your PC or USB, and/or
- **avoid an interminable delay,**

you MUST click :

Change how setup downloads updates

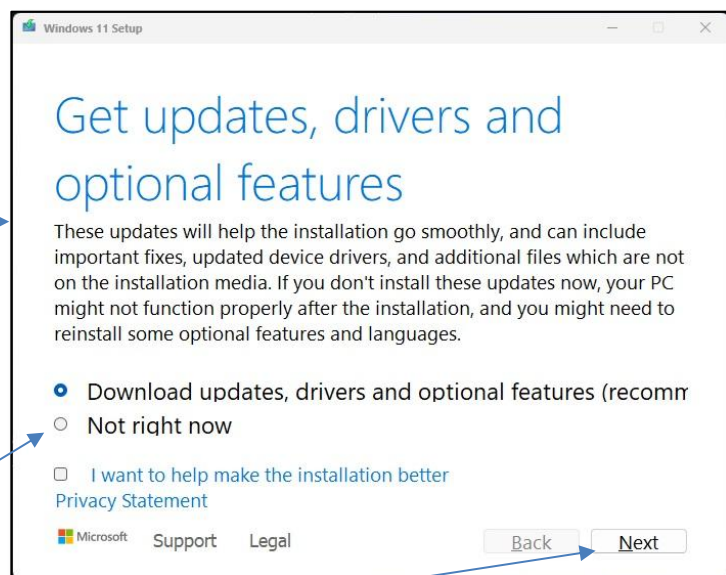
Provided you do, you will **see**:

Get updates, drivers and

You can see that Microsoft's default option is still to download updates from their Servers. Their text almost dares anyone to select **Not right now**.

This is exactly what you must do if you want to use your local installation files – if only to save time!

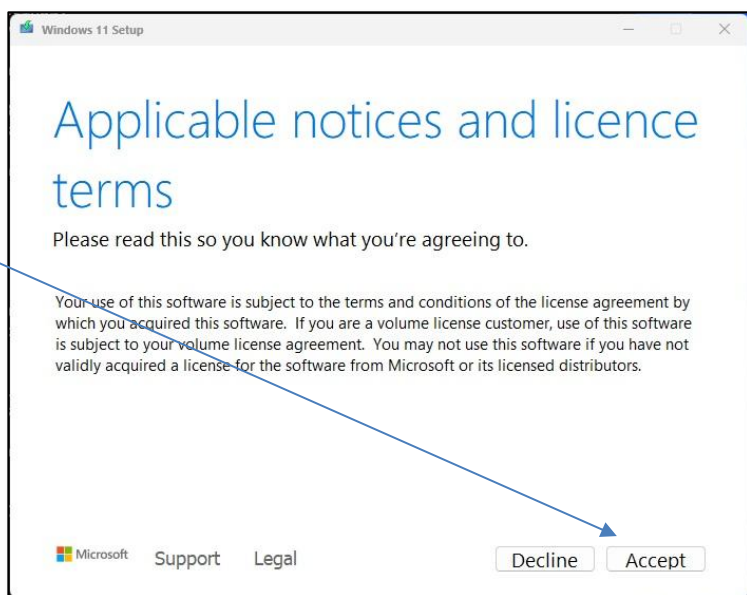
So, select **Not right now** and click **Next**.



Applicable notices and licence terms

Is the next page you will see.

If you want to use Windows, you don't have a choice - click **Accept**.



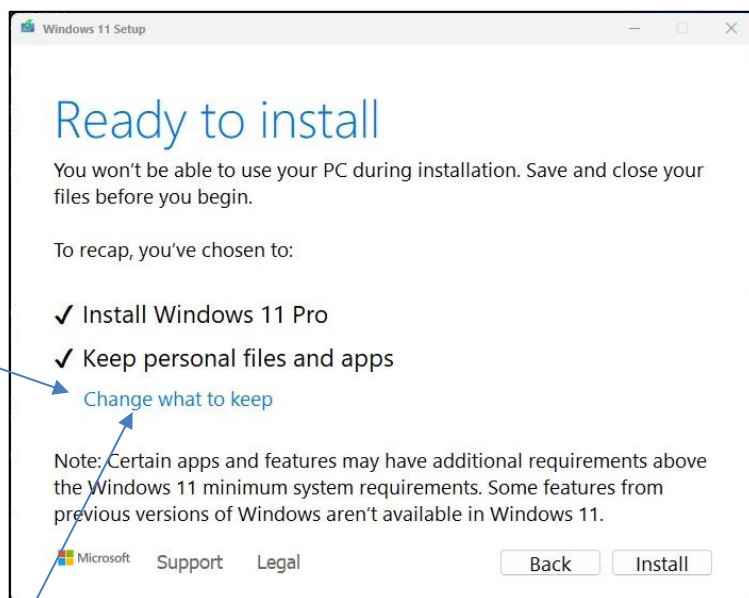
Ready to Install

This page tells you what you have chosen to do.

Note. It has defaulted to 'Keep personal files and apps'.

So, if you want to do anything else, click **Change what to keep**.

You will then see:

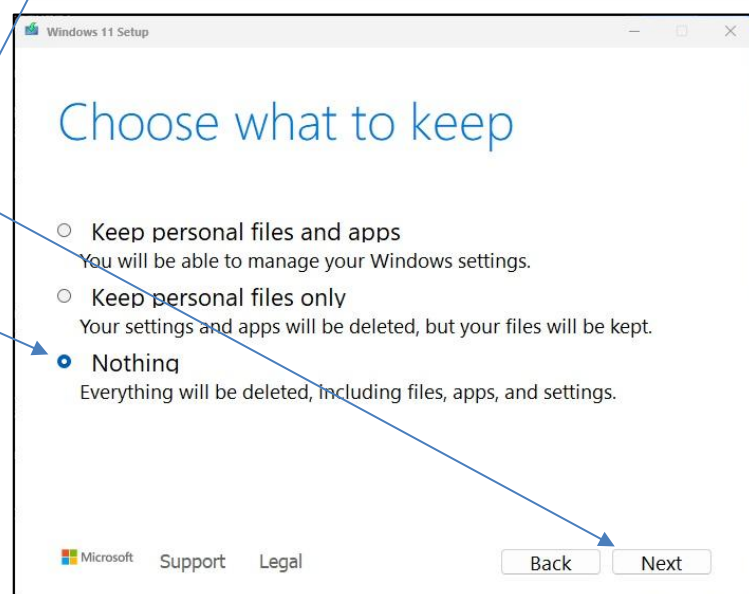


Choose what to keep

This spells out your three options.

Select the **Option** YOU want and click **Next**.

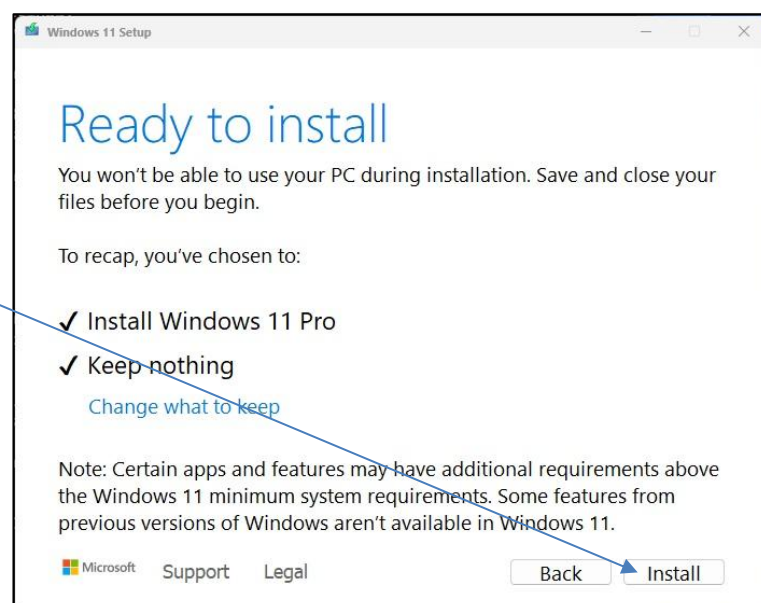
Unless you click **Change what to keep**, above, you will not even see these Options!



Ready to Install

This confirms the Options you've chosen.

When you are sure you are right Click **Install**.



Installing Windows 11

This is where the:

- **Traditional User Interface**, and the
- **New User Interface**.

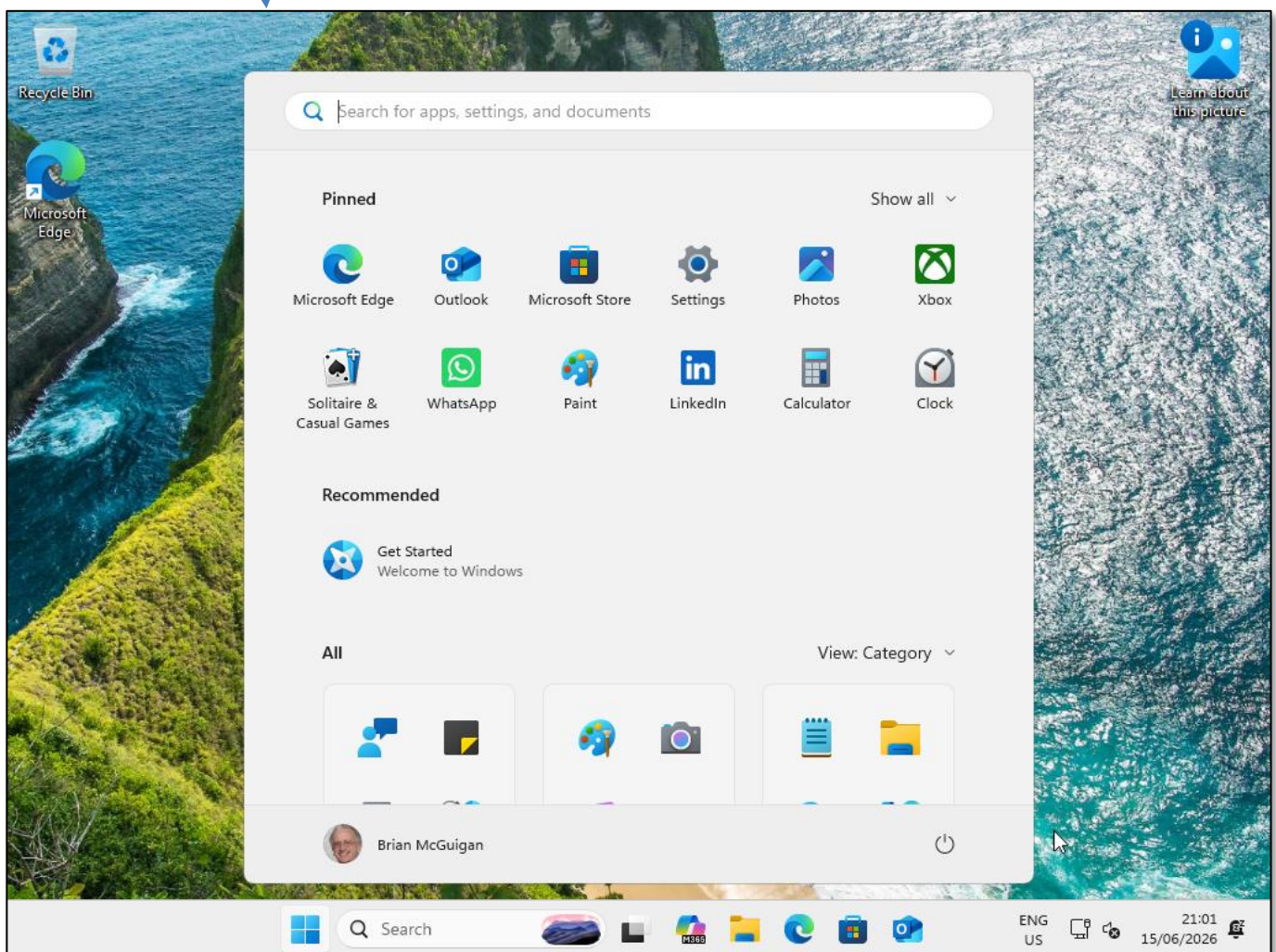
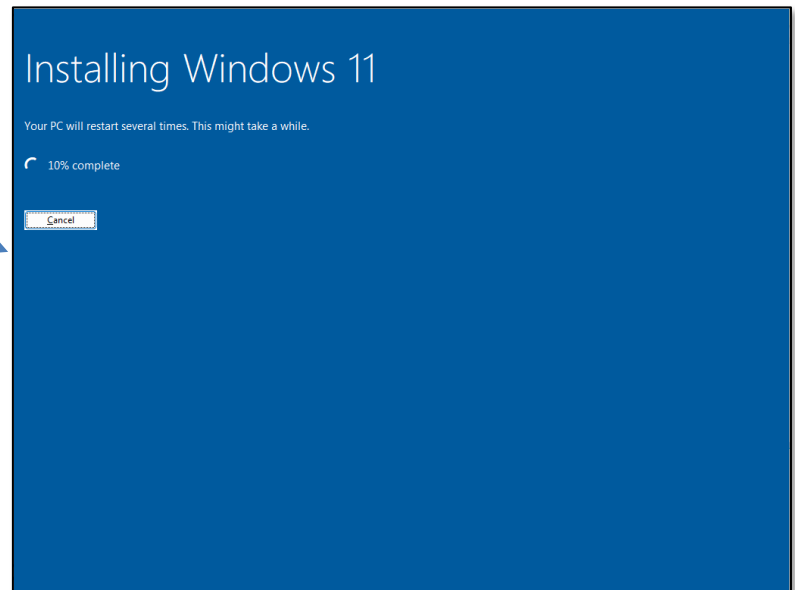
converge. From here on they are both the same.

The whole process is documented in:

[Appendix B - Installing Windows 11](#)
for those unfamiliar with the process.

It starts with this **blue screen**.

And ends with **this** one.



Installation Complete

You now have a fully installed and working copy of **Windows 11**.

From here, On2it-WinFixIT can continue with:

- Installing Microsoft Office
- Installing additional applications
- Debloating Windows
- Applying post-installation tweaks

Your system is now ready for the next phase.

You can see from the above illustration that most of the time, Windows installs stuff just in case you might want it. The **WinFixIT DeBloater** explains what it all is, and enables you to remove it, if you don't.

If you want to change any if the settings you made during installation of Windows 11, do not be concerned. **WinFixIT's DeBloater** offers un-biased advice on almost everything, and enables you to change your settings whenever you like. 😊

DeBloating Windows 11

The DeBloater can only be run after Windows 11 has been installed. It can therefore be run on any fully installed Windows 11 system. **You do NOT have to have used WinFixIT to do the installation.**

When the DeBloater first opens you will see:

As you can see the Form has a panel of **Groups** and **Options** on the left & an **Advice Panel** on the right.

Please read the Advice Panel. It tells you how the system works.

On2it Software - Windows 11 DeBloater

Major Windows Features

- ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options
- ☒ Remove Microsoft 365
- ☒ Remove OneDrive
- ☒ Remove Microsoft Teams
- ☒ Turn BitLocker OFF
- ☒ KEEP CoPilot
- ☐ CANNOT INSTALL Recall

Microsoft Accounts

- ☐ Select ALL Options
- ☐ Create and Sign in with a Local Account
- ☐ Remove Microsoft Account entirely

Remove Unwanted Apps

- ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options
- ☒ Remove Outlook for Windows
- ☒ Remove Xbox
- ☒ Please INSTALL Solitaire - MANUALLY

Select Default Browser

- ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options
- ☒ Microsoft Edge SELECTED
- ☐ SELECT Google Chrome
- ☐ SELECT Firefox
- ☐ INSTALL Brave

Advice Panel

The DeBloater can be run in two modes:

Initial Run

- All Options on the left default to our recommendations. To follow all of them, simply click the **PERFORM Selected Options** Button, below.
- To see advice on any Group, Option or Button and make your own selections, simply point at what you are interested in. Advice will appear HERE.

If an Option is not currently installed, and you wish to keep it - you will be offered the choice to **INSTALL** it.

- To reset, use the **Select ALL Recommended Options** Checkbox in each Group, to select or de-select every Option in the Group.
- As each Option runs, a Task Log will display HERE. Controls will appear below, to choose detail level or print it.
- any Options that remain un-ticked, will NOT run. So you can be selective about which options you want to run, and which you wish to ignore.

Subsequent Runs

You can re-run the DeBloater at any time, if you change your mind about any Option.
(Most larger Apps will require manual re-installation.)

If the Advice Panel is not large enough to show all the advice, scroll bars will appear. To see all the Advice at the same time, simply enlarge the form window by dragging the edges or corners.

To re-display this advice, simply point at the **Advice Panel** Heading, above.

Select OPTIONS

Print

Task Log Required

It really should not be necessary to read this User Manual, as the Advice Panel tells you about everything in the system, when you need to know it - simply by pointing at something, with your mouse.

This 'User Manual' is aimed at people who do not yet have a copy of the system yet want some idea of what it does and how it works.

Changing an Option

If, having read our Advice, you don't wish to follow it, just click the **Checkbox** to change it.

NOTE: Particularly for the INITIATED.

These are NOT conventional Checkboxes that simply become un-checked.

When you uncheck an option, you are implying that you want to do the opposite.

So, for example, if you uncheck **Remove OneDrive Service**, the system will assume you want to KEEP it. So:

- If installed, it will become **KEEP OneDrive Service**,
- If it's NOT, it will become **INSTALL OneDrive – MANUALLY**.

The advice displayed on the right will tell you exactly how to do it, complete with [Hyperlinks](#) enabling you to download any necessary Software.

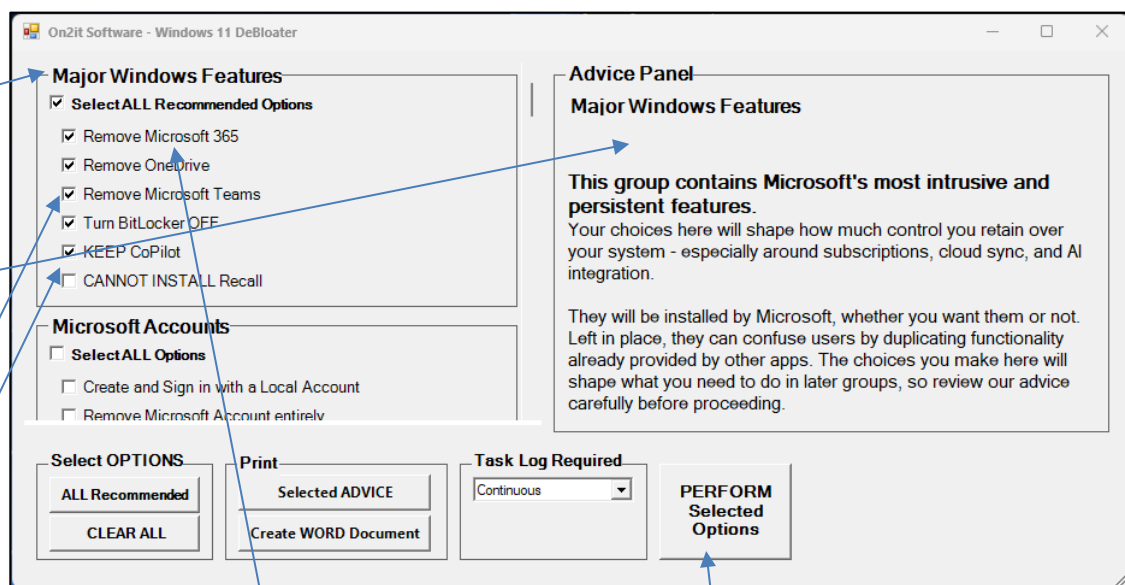
So, when you modify an Option, the System looks at what you already have on your system and only switches to a feasible alternative. Any Advice displayed will be appropriate to the modified Option. If either of the modified Options above are un-checked, then of course the Option reverts to the default recommendation **Remove OneDrive Service**.

Groups and Options

Groups and Options are displayed in the left-hand panel.

When you point at a **Group Title**, you will see what the Group is for in the **Advice Panel**.

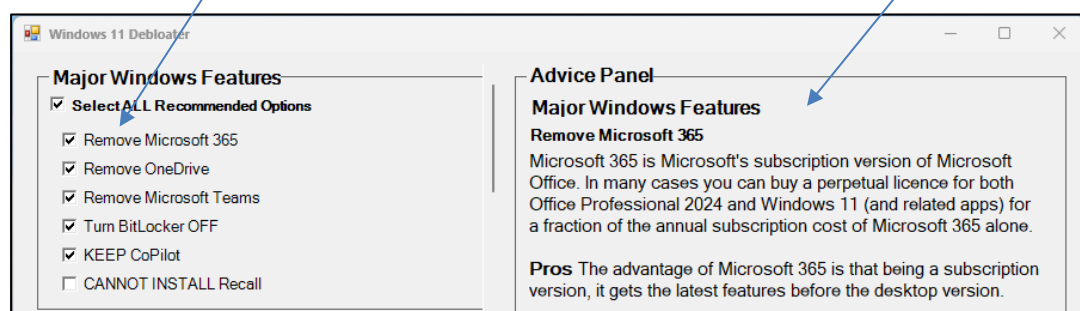
A Group is merely a collection of similar Options that the user can choose to **Remove** or **KEEP**.



Our Recommended Options are displayed when the DeBloat first opens.

To follow ALL our recommendations, all you need to do is Click the **PERFORM Selected Options** Button.

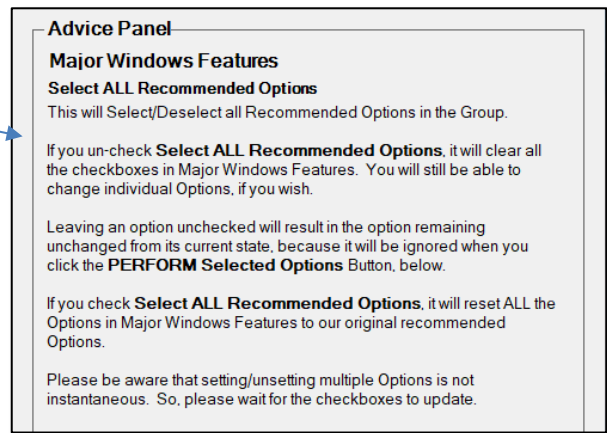
When you point your mouse at any **Option** you will see the reasons for that advice in the **Advice Panel**:



Resetting your Options

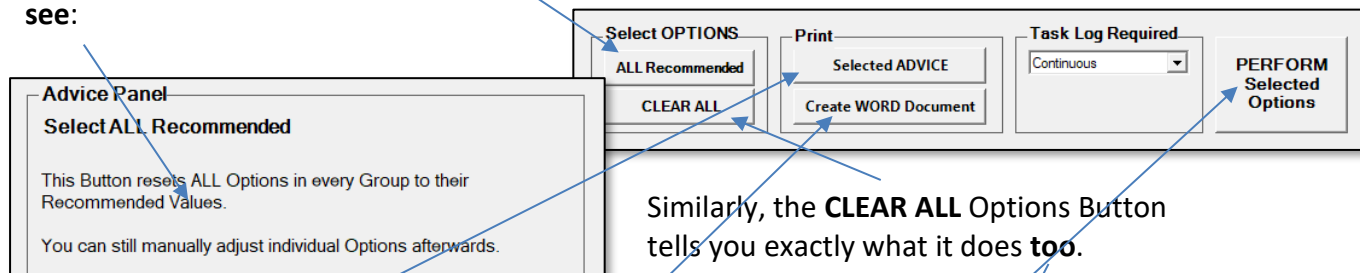
If you point your mouse at a **Select ALL Recommended Options** Checkbox, you will see:

You can also use the **Select ALL Recommended OPTIONS** Button on the bottom of the form to reset ALL Options in ALL Groups, to their recommended values.



Buttons at the Bottom of the Form

When you point at the **Select ALL Recommended** OPTIONS Button, at the bottom of the form, you will see:



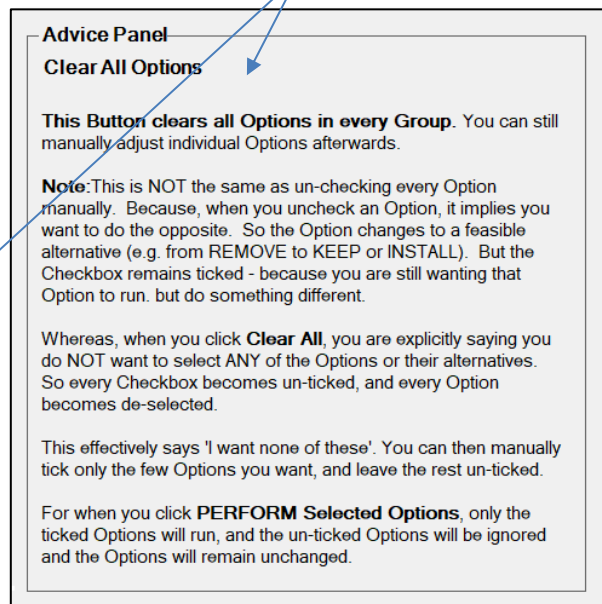
Similarly, the **CLEAR ALL** Options Button tells you exactly what it does too.

The **Print Selected ADVICE** Button, does not change the Advice in the Advice Panel. For, if it did, the only advice you'd be able to print would be about the Print Advice button. 😞

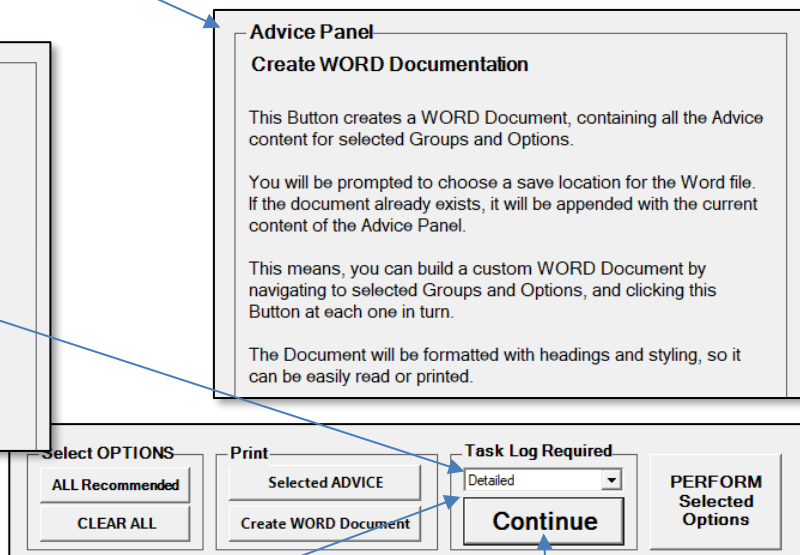
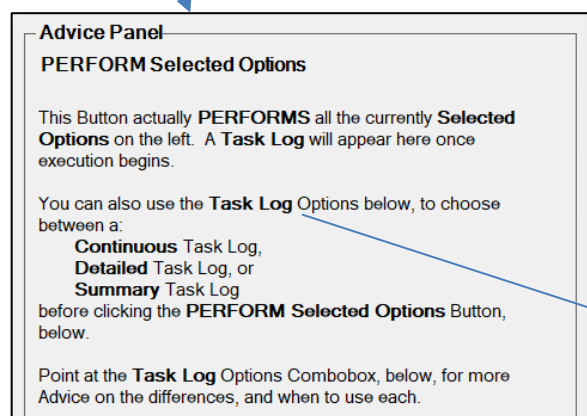
It does, however, display a 'Tool Tip', which says:

Prints the current content of the Advice Panel

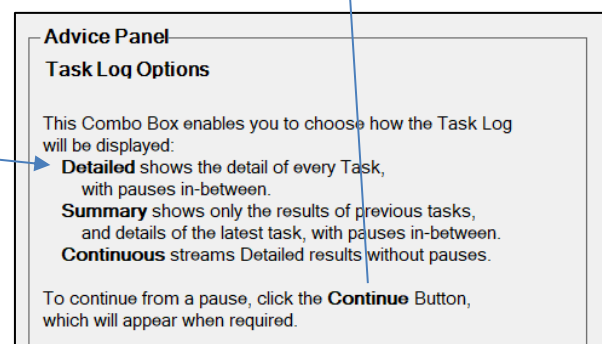
The **Create WORD Documentation** Button, does display Advice on what it does.



The **PERFORM Selected Options** Button, does as well.



When you do, point at the **Task Log Required** Combo Box you will see:



Currently Available Options

To give you some idea of the current scope of the system, **these** are screenshots of all Groups and Options *currently* in the system.

*All these **Options** appear on the left-hand side of the Form with a full Advice Panel on the right. For details of each Option see: [Appendix C – DeBLOATer Groups & Options](#)*

Major Windows Features This group contains Microsoft's most intrusive and persistent features.

Microsoft Accounts Microsoft make it almost impossible to install Windows 11 without setting up an Account. Many people prefer a Local Account for privacy and simplicity.

Remove Unwanted Apps that a lot of people never use.

Select Default Browser All modern browsers are fast, secure, and capable - the differences come down to privacy, ecosystem integration, and personal preference.

Tidy the Start Menu Windows 11 puts a lot of minor Apps into the Start Menu - in case you need them. Removing them reduces confusion and streamlines your system.

Simplify the Taskbar We cannot do it for you – Microsoft's security. So, we can offer Advice on which Apps to KEEP or Remove, and tell you how to do it.

Keep the Desktop Clean These days there is no need to clutter your Desktop with application Icons. So, keep it clean

Privacy & Telemetry Windows 11 collects a significant amount of diagnostic and behavioural data. Some is needed, a lot isn't.

On2it Software - Windows 11 DeBLOATer

Major Windows Features
☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

- ☒ Remove Microsoft 365
- ☒ Remove OneDrive
- ☒ Remove Microsoft Teams
- ☒ Turn BitLocker OFF
- ☒ KEEP CoPilot
- ☐ CANNOT INSTALL Recall

Microsoft Accounts
☐ Select ALL Options

- ☐ Create and Sign in with a Local Account
- ☐ Remove Microsoft Account entirely

Remove Unwanted Apps
☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

- ☒ Remove Outlook for Windows
- ☒ Remove Xbox
- ☒ KEEP Solitaire

Select Default Browser
☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

- ☒ Microsoft Edge SELECTED
- ☒ INSTALL Google Chrome
- ☐ INSTALL Firefox
- ☐ INSTALL Brave
- ☐ INSTALL Opera

Tidy the Start Menu
 Point at an Option for DIY Instructions

- ☐ Remove Microsoft 365 PIN from the Start Menu
- ☐ Remove Xbox PIN from the Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Solitaire pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ Remove LinkedIn PIN from the Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Outlook pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP File Explorer pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Calculator pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Notepad pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Snipping Tool pinned to Start Menu
- ☐ KEEP Photos pinned to Start Menu

Simplify the Taskbar
 Point at an Option for DIY Instructions

- ☐ Remove Search Box, FROM the Taskbar
- ☐ KEEP CoPilot, ON the Taskbar
- ☐ KEEP File Manager, ON the Taskbar
- ☐ KEEP Edge, ON the Taskbar
- ☐ KEEP Outlook, ON the Taskbar
- ☐ Remove Microsoft Store, FROM the Taskbar

Keep the Desktop Clean
☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

- ☒ Remove Edge, FROM the Desktop

Privacy & Telemetry
☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

- ☒ Remove Advertising ID
- ☒ Remove Tailored Experiences
- ☒ Remove Inking and Typing Personalisation
- ☒ Remove Location Tracking
- ☒ Remove Activity History
- ☒ Remove Feedback Frequency
- ☒ Remove Diagnostic Data Upload
- ☒ Remove Cloud Content Suggestions
- ☒ Remove Web Search in Start Menu
- ☒ KEEP SmartScreen Filter

☒ KEEP SmartScreen Filter ☒ Remove Microsoft Edge Telemetry ☒ Remove Customer Experience Improvement Program
Performance Acceleration ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ ENABLE Low Latency Profile (LLP) ☒ ENABLE Scheduler Responsiveness Mode ☒ ENABLE Reduced Background Task Latency
Visual Effects ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ DISABLE Transparency Effects ☒ DISABLE Window Animations
Background Services ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ Remove Widgets Service ☒ Remove Xbox Game Bar Service ☒ Remove Xbox Live Auth Manager ☒ Remove Xbox Accessory Management Service ☒ Remove Game DVR and Capture Service ☒ Remove OneDrive Auto-Start ☒ KEEP Windows Spotlight Service ☒ KEEP Windows Search Service ☒ Remove Suggested Actions Service
System Experience ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ Remove Tips and Suggestions ☒ Remove Lock Screen Spotlight ☒ Remove Start Menu Recommendations ☒ Remove Suggested Apps ☒ Remove Suggested Content in Settings ☒ Remove Automatic App Launching ☒ Remove Suggested Actions ☒ Remove AutoPlay ☒ KEEP Snap Assist ☒ KEEP Clipboard History ☒ Remove Nearby Sharing
Security and Network ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ Remove IPv6 ☒ Remove Fast Startup ☒ Remove Hibernation
Windows Update ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ Set Active Hours ☒ DISABLE Automatic Driver Updates ☒ DISABLE Delivery Optimisation
File Explorer ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ SHOW File Extensions ☒ SHOW Hidden Files ☒ Remove Frequent Folders ☒ Remove Recent Files
Notifications ☒ Select ALL Recommended Options ☒ Remove Notification Badges ☒ Remove Notification Sounds

Performance Acceleration Windows includes several hidden performance features that improve responsiveness, reduce UI latency, and optimise CPU scheduling.

Visual Effects On modern hardware these are barely noticeable. On older or lower-specification machines disable them.

Background Services support features such as gaming, cloud sync, widgets, and content suggestions. Many users do not need these services, and disabling them can reduce resource usage and improve privacy.

Systems Experience Windows 11 offers suggestions, tips, promotions, and automated behaviours. Many users find these distracting or unnecessary.

Security & Network Windows 11 has several network and power settings that can cause unexpected behaviour, slow down updates, or waste disk space - particularly on modern hardware.

Windows Update control when these occur, what you get and how they are done

File Explorer Show what you need. Hide what you don't.

Notifications Control irritants.

We have included full details of all the above, in case you want it, in [Appendix C - DeBLOATer Groups & Options](#). By all means read it - if you have the time. But there is no real need to, as the system gives you advice when you need it.

These are the 'currently available' Options, as more are planned. If you think there are glaring omissions – let us know.

Fortunately, it is very easy for us to add new Options. As, all the Groups, Options and their Advice are specified in an external text file. So, all we need to do is edit the file, and voila, the form re-builds itself! 😊

Tech Note: It's an RTF File. So, we can, if needed, add Links to YouTube Videos for additional Advice, or to websites for software downloads.

We must, however, add new code that implements the new Options, behind the 'PERFORM Selected Options' Button.

But, these days, that is what Copilot/Claude is for. 😊

Groups with Somewhat Different Behaviour

Some the Groups shown above do not behave in exactly the same way as discussed above. They are:

- **Microsoft Accounts,**
- **Select Default Browser,**

These have to be different, because their Options are not independent of each other.

Microsoft Accounts

These Options are interdependent. Because if you want to **Remove Microsoft Account entirely**, and you haven't checked **Create and Sign in with a Local Account**, then the system will create one for you - if you don't already have a local account.

Microsoft Accounts

☐ Select ALL Options

☐ Create and Sign in with a Local Account

☐ Remove Microsoft Account entirely

Select Default Browser

Obviously, you can only have one Default Browser. But you may **INSTALL** as many Browsers as you like.

When you subsequently click **PERFORM Selected Options**, all of the Browsers you have chosen to install will be downloaded and installed from you, each in its own Command Window.

Select Default Browser

☒ Select ALL Recommended Options

☒ Microsoft Edge SELECTED

☐ SELECT Google Chrome

☐ SELECT Firefox

☐ INSTALL Brave

☐ INSTALL Opera

You will then be able to **SELECT** any installed App to become the default. It will then show as **SELECTED**.

Tidy the Start Menu & Simplify the Taskbar

Microsoft's security means, we cannot pin or unpin Apps to either the Start Menu or Taskbar, for you.

The best we can do is to make recommendations and give advice on how to do it for yourself.

Simply **Point at an Option for DIY Instructions**. The Advice Panel will tell you the reasoning behind our recommendation, and give you instructions on how to do, whatever you want, for yourself.



Tidy the Start Menu

Point at an Option for DIY Instructions

☐ Remove Microsoft 365 PIN from the Start Menu

☐ Remove Xbox PIN from the Start Menu

☐ KEEP Solitaire pinned to Start Menu

☐ Remove LinkedIn PIN from the Start Menu

☐ KEEP Outlook pinned to Start Menu

☐ KEEP File Explorer pinned to Start Menu

☐ KEEP Calculator pinned to Start Menu

☐ KEEP Notepad pinned to Start Menu

☐ KEEP Snipping Tool pinned to Start Menu

☐ KEEP Photos pinned to Start Menu

Simplify the Taskbar

Point at an Option for DIY Instructions

☐ Remove Search Box, FROM the Taskbar

☐ KEEP CoPilot, ON the Taskbar

☐ KEEP File Manager, ON the Taskbar

☐ KEEP Edge, ON the Taskbar

☐ KEEP Outlook, ON the Taskbar

☐ Remove Microsoft Store, FROM the Taskbar

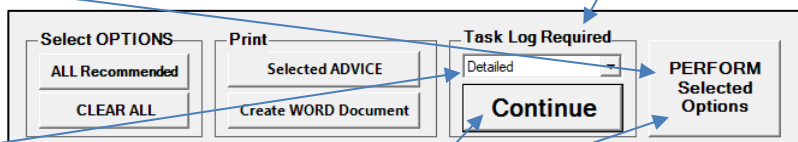
PERFORM Selected Options

Currently hidden.

Before you click the **PERFORM Selected Options** Button, you should set the **Task Log Required**, to whatever you want.

The default **Continuous** allows the Task Log to rattle past so fast that you might miss something.

A setting of **Detailed**, pauses after every option, and displays a large **Continue** Button.

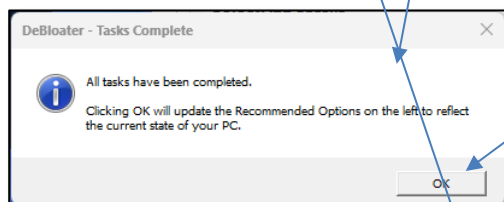


The Task Log

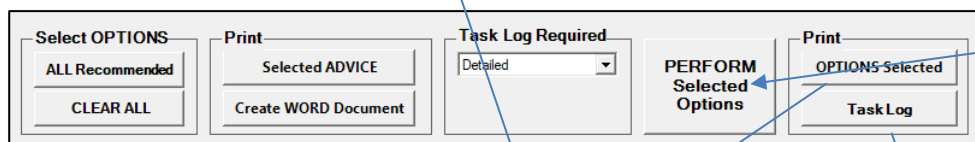
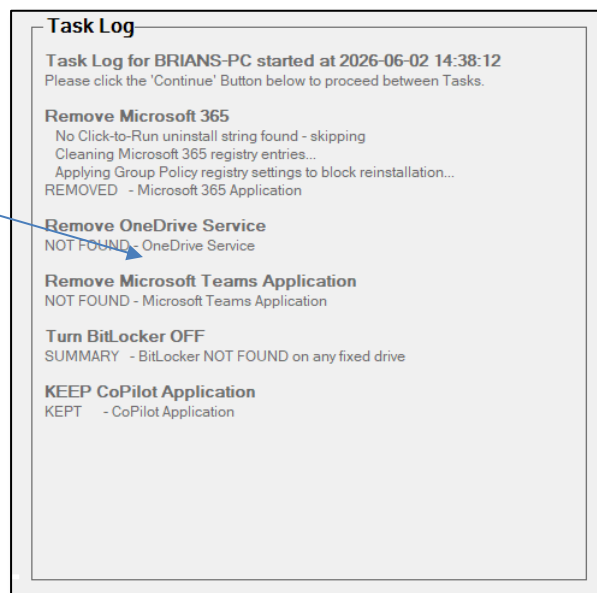
Starts to display Once you click the **PERFORM Selected Options** Button. The **Task Log** will start displaying and a large red **STOP RUN** Button will take its place.

The results of each Selected Option will be displayed. Where an Option does multiple things, each stage will be documented. Unselected Options, those with an empty Checkbox, will be ignored and not reported on.

At the end of the run, you will see:

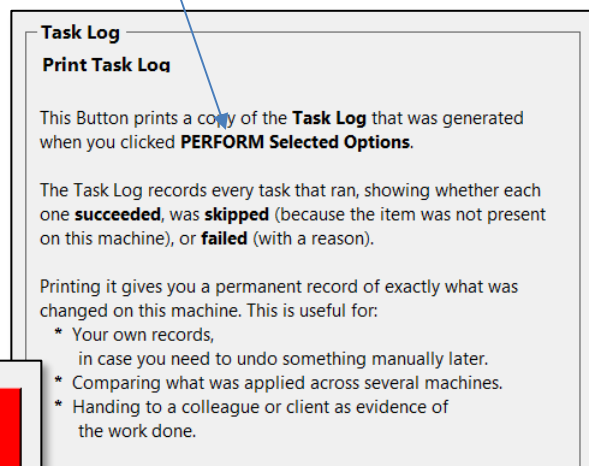
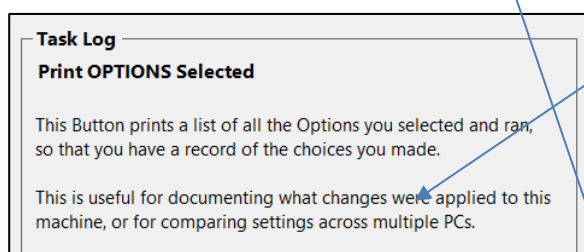


When you click **OK**, two additional Buttons will be added to the form and



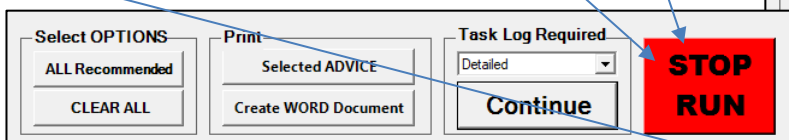
the **PERFORM Selected Options** Button will re-appear.

As usual, simply pointing at each Button, tells you what it does.

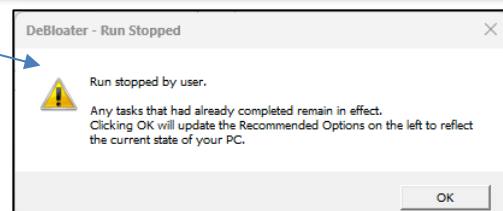


Stopping a Run

When you press the **STOP RUN** Button, the **Run Stopped** Dialog, will appear, and the run will stop



after the current Task completes. Clicking its **OK** Button will restore the 'PERFORM Selected Options' Button. The 'Continue' Button will vanish, and the two additional **Print** buttons will appear, as normal.



PRO Version Only Options

Currently hidden, as they are still under development.

OPEN Library

When you select **OPEN Library** on the MAIN-MENU you will see:

```
=====
On2it-WinFixIT - LIBRARY Menu
=====
These are currently the Menus available in the On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL\Install folder of the
USB:

1. Applications
   This menu shows all Applications currently available in the
   On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL\Install\Applications folder.

2. Artificial Intelligence
   AI tools are evolving so rapidly that any written overview will be out of date within months.
   The descriptions in this menu reflect the landscape as understood at a particular point in time.
   Treat them as a starting point only, not a definitive reference. Feel free to add your own. 😊

3. Documentation & Reference
   OFF-LINE Reference material, documentation sets, specifications, and information resources
   used for troubleshooting, configuration, learning, and technical support
   - in case you have NO Internet connection.

   ON-LINE links to additional reference sources
   - for when you DO.

4. Operating Systems
   This menu shows all OSs available in the USB-PostINSTALL\Install\Operating Systems folder.
   Numbered Options can be installed from the USB. The others are available using download links
   provided.

5. Utilities
   This menu shows all Utilities and Software Tools currently available from the
   On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL\Install\Utilities folder.

   You can download an executable, place it in the appropriate folder; give it a Start.bat file.
   It will automatically appear in the relevant Sub-Menu as an executable option.

6. LIBRARY Update
   This tells you how to Update WinFixIT's LIBRARY Menu System. You may customise the entire system
   to 'make it your own', simply by modifying the Files and Folders in the
   On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL\Install Folder on the USB. 😊

CLICK an OPTION, or Enter (1-6), Contents or <Return> :
```

This is the start of WinFixIT's multi-level, user-editable and infinitely-extensible, Dynamic Menu system
- driven only by the contents of its Files and Folders.

Hyperlinks

Hyperlinks that appear on their own line in a menu, will be fully clickable. When you click one, it will be opened in your default browser.

When you 'mouse over' an active Hyperlink it will become [blue and underlined](#).

Selecting Options

As the prompt at the bottom of any Menu suggests there are four ways of selecting Options, by:

- Clicking with your mouse,
- Option Number - (1-7) in the above example,
- Contents – displays the [LIBRARY Contents](#) .
- <return> or just <enter>, takes you back to the previous Menu.

If a Menu is too long to fit in a screen the Prompt will be below the screen.

Error Messages

Are displayed immediately below the Prompt. They will usually be:

ERROR – Invalid Option

It is usually pretty clear what the problem was as the correct Options are still visible, but 'greyed out' in the Prompt.

If, however, the Start.bat contained a COPY Command, it would difficult to know what had happened unless WinFixIT generated Messages like:

SUCCESS: rufus-4.13p.exe COPIED to C:\Program Files,

SUCCESS: Sub-folder COPIED to C:\Program Files\Sub-Folder or

ERROR – rufus-4.13.exe NOT COPIED to C:\Program Files, source not found

For installs it is obvious when an Installer starts in another Window. Some Installers, however, are totally silent, and don't let WinFixIT know whether the installation succeeded or not. So, WinFixIT simply advises:

INSTALLATION of <ApplicationName> STARTED, please check success in another Window

When an Error is displayed, you will see the original input 'greyed out'. So that you can see what it was.

LIBRARY Contents

When you enter “Contents”, in any case you like, on any LIBRARY Menu you will see:

```
=====
                        LIBRARY - Contents
=====

CLICK or enter a Menu or Option number or to jump directly there.
The un-numbered rows are the Information only Options within each Menu.
Press <Return> to go back to where you came from.

 1. Applications
 2. Office
 3. Project
 4. Visio
 5. EaseUS ToDo Backup
 6. WinFixIT
 7. Software Licences & CHEAP CD Keys
    8. Perpetual Licences
       Perpetual Licences
    9. ANNUAL or Monthly Rental
       ANNUAL or Monthly Rental
   10. Licence Vendors & CHEAP CD Keys
       Licence Vendors & CHEAP CD Keys
   11. Microsoft Support
       Microsoft Support
 12. Artificial Intelligence
 13. Agentic AI
     Claude Code (Anthropic)
     GitHub Copilot (Microsoft)
 14. Cloud AI Assistants
     ChatGPT (OpenAI)
     Claude AI (Anthropic)
     Google Gemini
     Grok (xAI)
     Microsoft Copilot
 15. Local AI Runtimes
     LM Studio (Portable)
     Ollama
 16. Specialised AI Tools
     Microsoft 365 Copilot
     Perplexity
 17. Documentation & Reference
 18. Hardware & Firmware
     19. Chipsets & Architecture
     20. CPU & Memory Reference
         Cache Hierarchy
         CPU & RAM Fault Diagnosis
         CPU Architecture & Cores
         DDR Standards & Timings
         Instruction Sets & Extensions
         Memory Controllers & Channels
         Thermal Throttling & Power Management
```

This displays the entire contents of all the Menu and Options in the LIBRARY as one long scrollable list.

There is little point in showing you everything that we have in our system - as someone else may have changed your system for your use. If, however, you got your copy direct from On2it Software, you will be able to see the extensive library of curated software and advice, we have built into our system.

Suffice it to say, with the **LIBRARY Menu**, you can create a Windows Folder Structure and populate it with appropriately named Files. This will enable you to:

- **Install:** Microsoft Office and any other applications on the USB,
- **Add:** Your own Applications to the USB,
- **Explore:** Other operating systems,
- **Download and/or Install:** Utilities and Software tools,

Your only limitation is your own imagination.

So how does our menu system make this work - **driven only by the contents of its Files and Folders?**

LIBRARY Update Menu

If you choose LIBRARY Update on the LIBRARY Menu, above, you will see:

```
=====
                        Install - LIBRARY Update Menu
=====
This tells you how to Update WinFixIT's LIBRARY Menu System. You may customise the entire system to
'make it your own', simply by modifying the Files and Folders in the
On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL\Install Folder on the USB. 😊

MENU Heading
  This MENU is in the 'Install\LIBRARY Update' Folder in the On2it-WinFixIT PostINSTALL Partition
  of the USB. So, when it opens its Heading becomes the Install - LIBRARY Update Menu, above.

MENU Introduction
  This is the Text that appears immediately below the Heading, before the first OPTION.
  Unsurprisingly it is in a file called Menu Introduction.txt in the 'Install\LIBRARY Update'
  Folder. That, incidentally, is how WinFixIT knows Install\LIBRARY Update contains a MENU -
  simples. 😊

OPTION Descriptions
  That's the Text that describes each OPTION below its Header.
  By now you should have guessed that comes from a file called Option Description.txt 😊

  So the Content of the Files:
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\MENU Heading\Option Description.txt
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\MENU Introduction\Option Description.txt
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\OPTION Headers\Option Description.txt and
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\OPTION Descriptions\Option Description.txt
  are responsible for the above OPTION Descriptions. (Corney, but hopefully memorable.) 😊

OPTION Headers
  That's the yellow Headers like MENU Heading and MENU Introduction, above.
  They are the Names of Sub-Folders in 'Install\LIBRARY Update'.

  So the Names of the Sub-Folders:
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\MENU Heading
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\MENU Introduction and
  - Install\LIBRARY Update\OPTION Headers
  are responsible for the above OPTION Headers. 😊

1. UPDATE the LIBRARY
  You may have noticed that none of the above Options, DO anything. They are 'Information ONLY'.
  They are not numbered. So, they cannot be selected.
  THIS one can - how come? That's because we've included a Start.bat file in its Sub-Folder.

  You CAN put anything into a Start.bat that you put in any other Command file - if you know how.
  It will then be executed, like any other Command file. However, we have dramatically simplified
  most Commands to a single: RUN, COPY and OPEN Command line. For details on how to do this,
  and more besides, select this option to open a PDF Document that will reveal ALL. 😊

CLICK an OPTION, or Enter (1-1), Contents or <Return> :
```

It can be seen from the above that:

- **Menu Folders** have a 'Menu Introduction.txt' File,
- **Option Folders** have an 'Option Description.txt' File,
 - **Information only** Folders, just have an 'Option Description.txt' File.
 - **ACTION Options** have a 'Start.bat' File as well.

Given this information, it is not necessary to have a separate Menu Index File, as all the information necessary is in the Windows Folder Structure, itself.

Designing systems driven by their data content, like this, makes them incredibly flexible. 😊

The detail of how we actually do this, is covered in [Appendix D – Updating the LIBRARY Menu](#).

You are strongly urged to read the appendix before attempting it yourself.

It IS easy, like anything, *when you know how!*

Appendix A - Booting from a USB

Booting from a USB drive is the first step in installing Windows 11 on a computer that is not already running Windows, or to perform a clean installation. Unfortunately, every computer manufacturer does this slightly differently, so the exact steps you see on your screen may not match the examples shown here. This guide provides **general instructions** that apply to most systems.

The good news is: once you know what to look for, the process is simple.

Insert the USB Drive

Plug your WinFixIT USB Drive into the computer you want to install Windows on.

Restart the Computer

Restart the machine. As soon as it begins to power on, you will need to press a special key to open the:

Different computers use different keys to open the **Boot Menu** or **BIOS/UEFI Setup**.



UEFI V's BIOS

UEFI stands for “**Unified Extensible Firmware Interface**” — it’s the modern replacement for the old BIOS or “**Basic Input Output System**” that initializes hardware and starts your operating system.

Both are the low-level firmware that runs before Windows starts, handling boot devices, hardware checks, and system configuration.

Feature	BIOS	UEFI
Boot method	Uses legacy MBR	Uses modern GPT
Interface	Text-only	Graphical, mouse-friendly
Drive size limit	≤ 2 TB	Supports drives > 2 TB
Security	Basic	Secure Boot and TPM integration

Secure Boot: UEFI can verify that only trusted, signed operating systems start — preventing malware from hijacking the boot process.

TPM is a hardware security chip that protects encryption keys and ensures the system hasn’t been tampered with before Windows loads.

In short, UEFI is a smarter, faster, and more secure evolution of BIOS. Windows 11, is usually restricted to machines with UEFI, Secure Boot and TPM 2 – for their enhanced security.

For decades people had been urging Microsoft to improve Windows’ security. Then when they did so, they moaned even louder because the hardware requirements involved, meant that perfectly capable older machines, would not be able to run Windows 11. (I think Microsoft had to tell the motherboard manufacturers that unless they upgraded their hardware it would not be able to run Windows 11 – because there was no other way of forcing them to do so.)

WinFixIT’s Compatibility Checker, will check your machine, and tell you whether you can do a:

- **FULL Install** of Windows 11, complete with all the new security features.
- **BYPASS Install** because it lacks the security features, but the hardware is otherwise capable.
- **FAILED** because the hardware itself is not ‘up to ,the job’.

Getting into the UEFI or BIOS

When you start your PC you will see a startup screen, similar to this:



It usually has instructions on the bottom that tell you which keys to press to get into the BIOS or BOOT MENU. This one is from a machine with a Gigabyte Motherboard. It therefore uses:

- **DEL** the <delete> Key to enter the **BIOS SETUP**, and the
- **F12** Key to get into the **BOOT Menu**, which control the Boot Sequence – the order of devices that the system tries to Boot from.

You only need to use the **Boot Menu Key** to go into the somewhat safer, Boot Menu to change the Boot Order of your Drive. *Tap the key repeatedly **as soon as the computer powers on**.*

(If you miss, turn your machine off, as usual -and start again.)

You only want to change the Boot Sequence, so for this machine you'd press **F12**.

Unfortunately, every single manufacturer, just about, has their own way of doing it. Some manufactures don't even show you the necessary codes at the bottom of the screen. One that doesn't is Asus. Others flash past so quickly that it is extremely difficult to see what you want. These tables list the most common keys used by major brands and motherboard manufacturers.

Manufacturer / Brand	Boot Menu Key	BIOS/UEFI Setup Key
Dell (Laptops & Desktops)	F12	F2
HP (Laptops & Desktops)	F9	Esc or F10
Lenovo (Laptops & ThinkPads)	F12	F1 or F2
Acer	F12	F2
ASUS (Laptops)	Esc or F8	F2
Microsoft Surface	No Boot Menu key (use Volume-Down + Power)	Volume-Up + Power
Toshiba	F12	F2
Samsung	Esc or F12	F2
Sony VAIO	F11	F2

Motherboard Manufacturers (Custom PCs / Desktop Towers)

Motherboard Brand	Boot Menu Key	BIOS/UEFI Setup Key
ASUS (Motherboards)	F8	Del or F2
Gigabyte / AORUS	F12	Del
MSI	F11	Del
ASRock	F11 or F8	Del
Biostar	F9	Del
EVGA	F7	Del
Intel Desktop Boards	F10	F2

Notes for Beginners

- If the above tables do not list what you want, try an on-line search.
- If one of the above keys doesn't work, try the other key listed for that brand.
- Some systems show a brief message like **"Press F12 for Boot Menu"** — watch for it.
- On very fast systems, you may need to **tap the key repeatedly** after pressing the power button.
- If you see the normal Windows desktop, restart and try again.

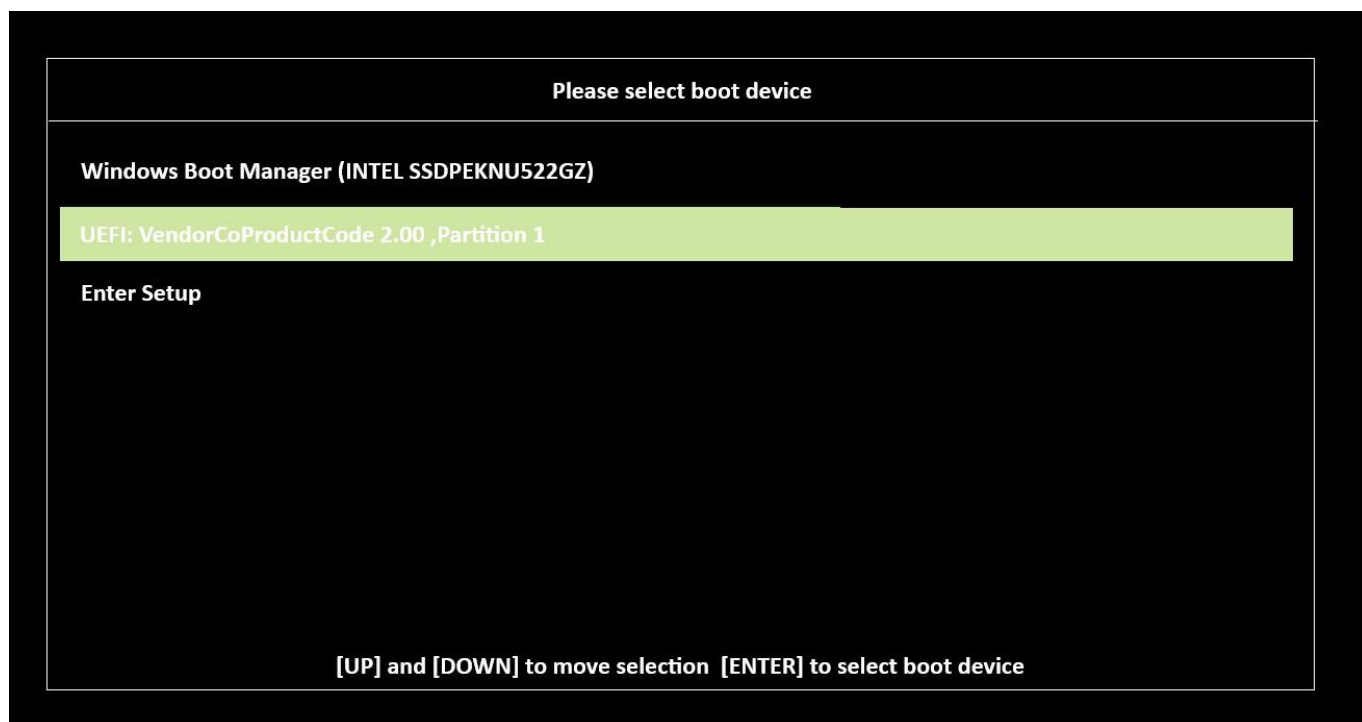
Example BIOSs

Because there is such a wide variation in the way that different manufactures do it, we have decided to show you some examples of their variability.

Asus

Is one of the manufactures that doesn't show codes on their start screen. So, unless you know to press **Esc** or **F8** during startup, you will never see the Asus Boot Menu

Asus - Boot Menu



This tells you at the bottom of the screen how to move your selection [UP] and [DOWN] and to press [ENTER] to make your selection.

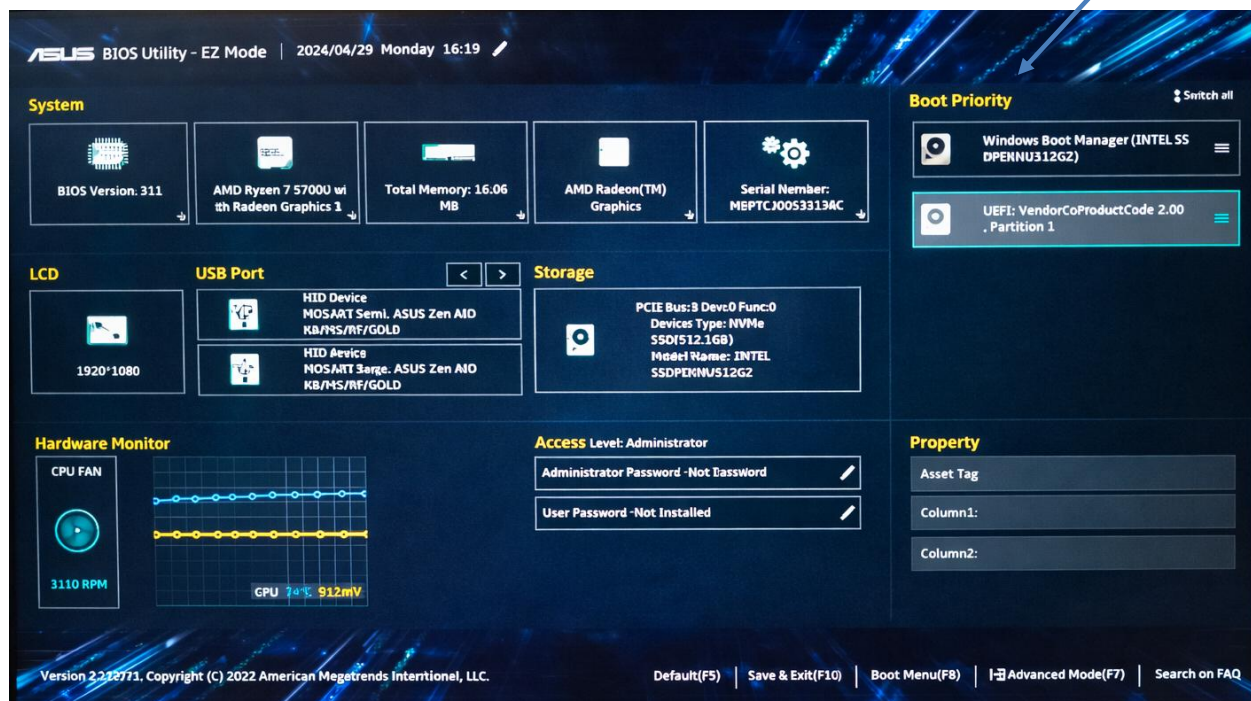
In the example shown above, the choice was easy:

- **Windows Boot Manager** takes you into the normal boot into windows.
- **UEFI: VendorCoProductCode 2.00 ,Partition 1** - Sounds mysterious, but since there is only your system drive and a USB in the machine, this must be your USB.
This often contains the brand of the USB, Toshiba, SanDisk, Kingston, Samsung, Verbatim...
Selecting this will boot from the USB, *on this occasion only*.
- **Enter Setup** will take you from the Boot Menu into the full Asus BIOS

Asus – BIOS

Any full BIOS has many more options available. The only one that we are interested in is **Boot Priority**. All you have to do is Drag and Drop them into you preferred order.

This is a permanent change. If you leave a USB drive in your machine, it will try to boot from it. If it is not there, or is a non-bootable USB, it will be ignored. The system will boot as normal



At the bottom of the screen there are further instruction:

- **F5** will reset your default settings,
- **F10** will Save your settings & Exit into booting your machine,
- **F8** will take you back to the Boot Menu,
- **F7** takes you into even more Advanced settings.

Surprisingly, it does not tell you that **Esc** will **exit without saving your settings**.

This is your 'get out of jail FREE' card, if you think you've just changed something you shouldn't have.

Quite honestly, if you don't know what you are doing avoid using the BIOS. The boot menu is a lot safer.

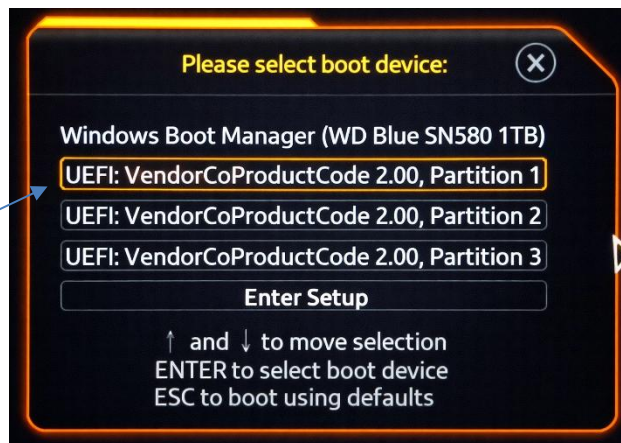
Gigabyte

If you press **F12** when booting, you will see:

Gigabyte - Boot Menu

This one it fairly easy to use. As the instructions at the bottom say:

- **↑ and ↓** move the **highlighted selection**.
- **ENTER** selects the boot device for this occasion.
- **ESC** boots using your normal defaults.



Rather more curious, is that the options are:

- **Windows Boot Manager (WD Blue SN580 1TB)** That's the SSD that has my System Drive on it.
- **UEFI: VendorCoProductCode 2.00, Partition 1**
- **UEFI: VendorCoProductCode 2.00, Partition 2**
- **UEFI: VendorCoProductCode 2.00, Partition 3**

The last three are all separate Partitions on the On2it-WinFixIT USB – namely:

- **USB-INSTALL,**
- **On2IT-WinFixIT,**
- **On2it Software Courses**

So, the BIOS has given two partitions that are NOT bootable as BOOT Options?!

Partition 1, is the only bootable partitions. If you select one of the others, nothing happens.

The advantage of using the Boot Menu to select where you want to Boot from is:

- It only affects where you boot from on this occasion.
- You don't have to go anywhere near the BIOS, and perhaps change something you shouldn't.

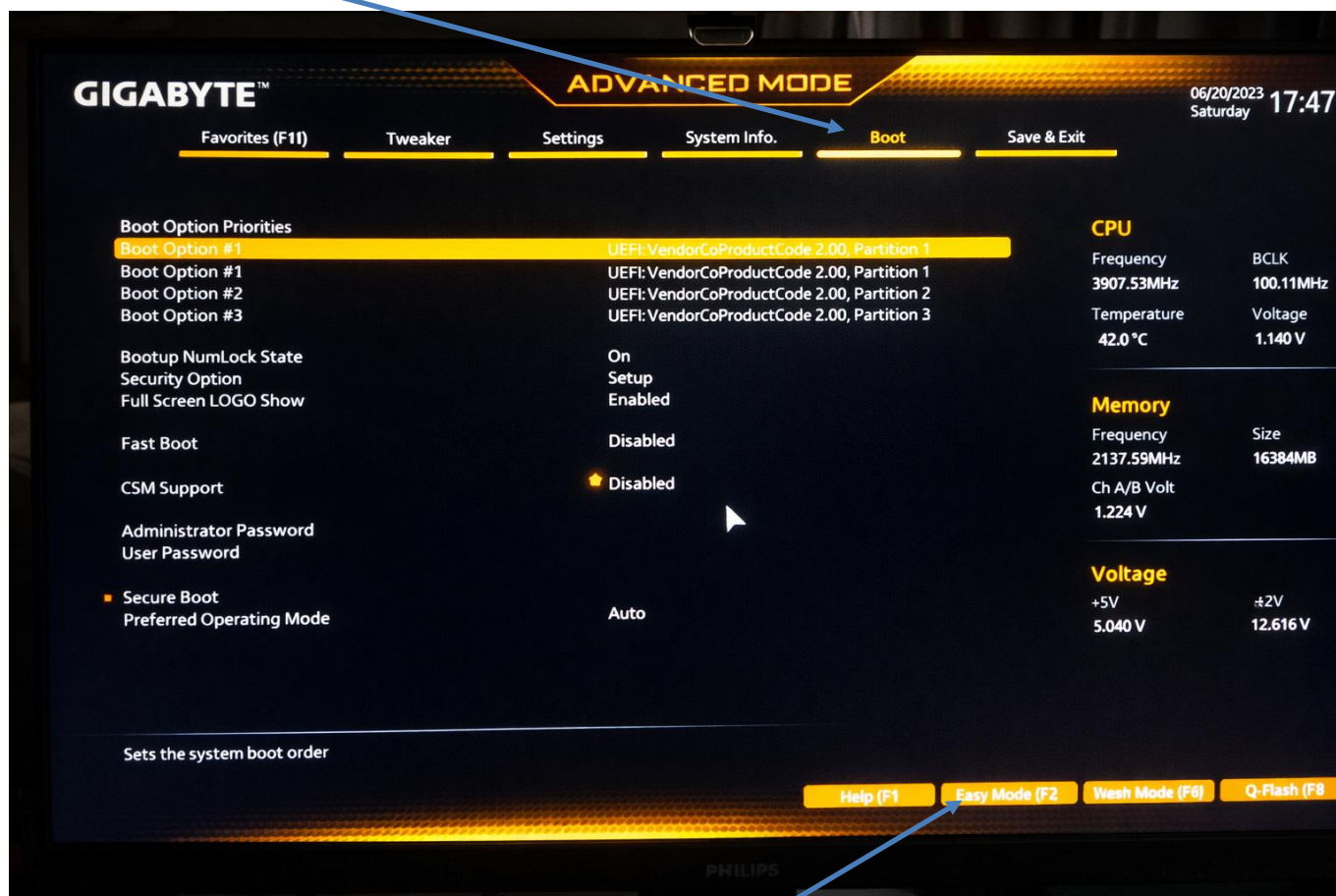
Some Motherboards have a couple of ways of doing it, too. One of which is Gigabyte.

Advanced Mode BIOS

If you press **Delete** during Boot, or use **Enter Setup** from the boot menu, you will be dropped into the full ADVANCED MODE BIOS interface for the motherboard. Every manufacturer's is different sorry. 🙄

It enables you to change multiple advanced settings. We will only look at settings the boot order.

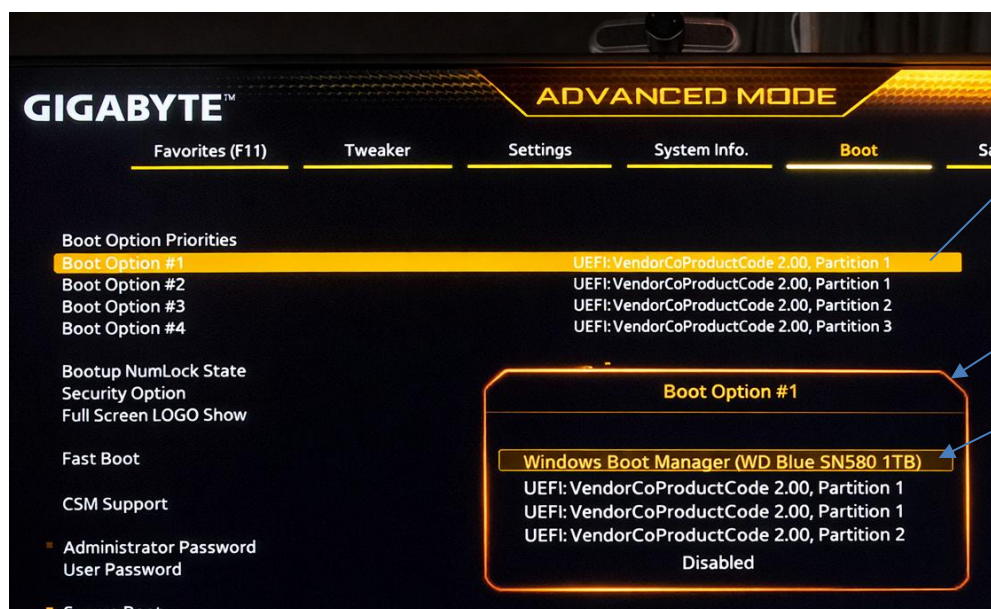
At the top select: **Boot**.



There are two ways of changing the **Boot Option Priorities**, as they are called on this machine. One starts on this screen.

The other is available by clicking the **Easy Mode** Button or Pressing **F2**.

If you look really hard you CAN just see it on the Button. It will take you to the easy Mode BIOS.

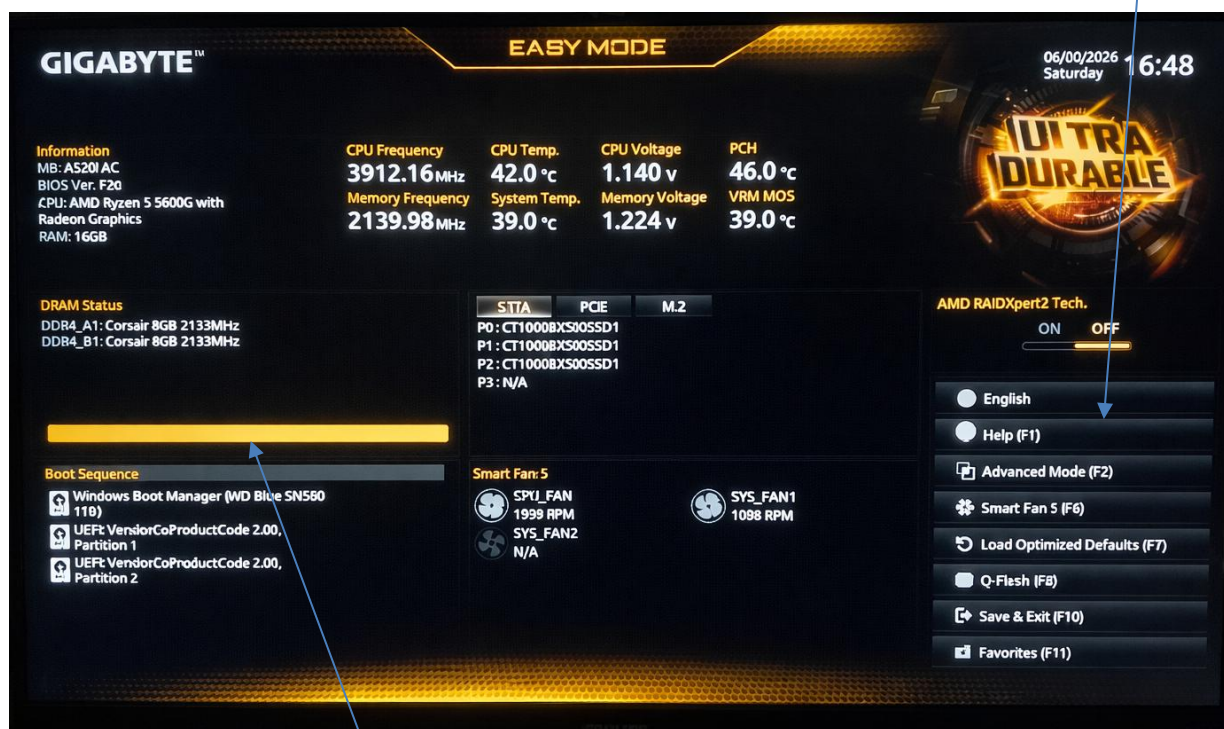


To change the Boot order on this screen, you:

- **Select a boot order #**, in this case "Boot Option #1". When you do so a **Sub-Menu** will open for that Option Number. This enables you to then:
- **Select the Disk** that you want to occupy that position in your Boot order.

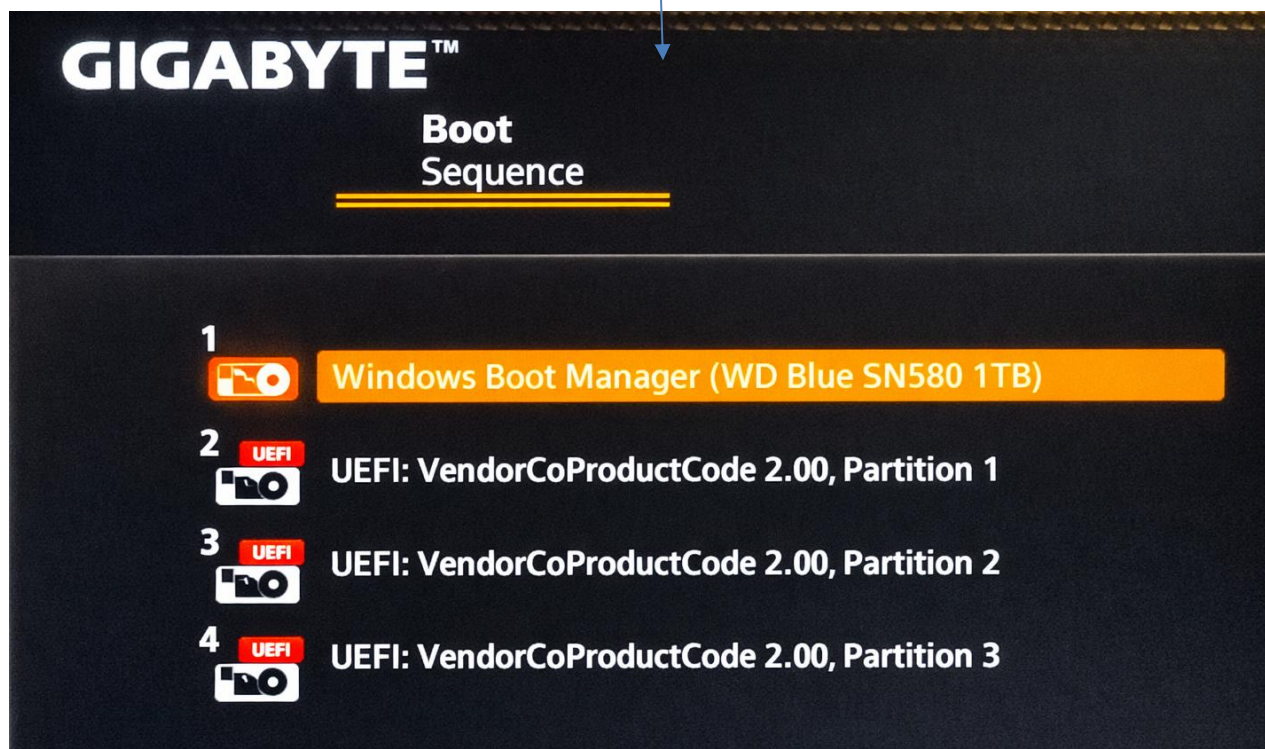
Easy Mode BIOS

This sort of screen gathers together the more popular options. This one has a **sub-menu** in the corner that still gives you access to the more advanced options, should you need them.



When you double-click **Boot Sequence** you will see:

Boot Sequence Menu

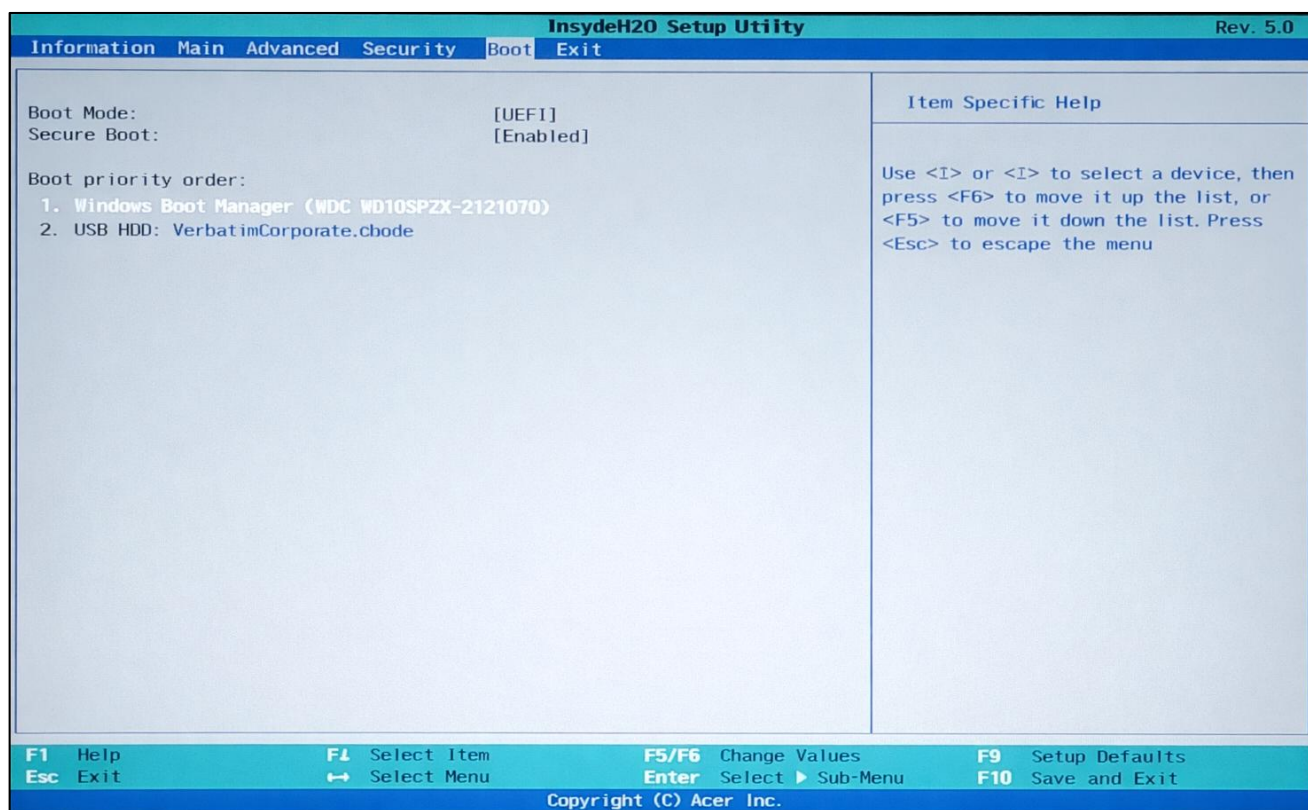


This is comparatively easier to use as all you have to do is drag and drop the Disks into the right order.

Once done, choose **Save & Exit**.

An Earlier Boot Menu

An earlier example of a BIOS that you might come across, is shown below:



As you can see this is radically different from both the ASUS and Gigabyte BIOSs, above. In this example everything is done with the keyboard. The mouse won't work. The **Legend** at the bottom tells you what key does what:

- **Select Menu** $\leftrightarrow$ means use left and right arrow to select **Menus** at the top of the screen. In the example shown the **Boot** Menu has already been selected.
- **Select Item** $\updownarrow$ means use the up and down arrow to select **Devices** in the list. In the example shown the **Windows Boot Manager (WDC WD10SPZX-2121070)** has already been selected. You are *supposed* to realise that is a Western Digital Hard Drive. Fortunately, it is Pretty clear that **USB HDD: VerbatimCorporate.cbode** is a USB. (Though why it's been labelled HDD, is beyond me!)
- **Change Values F5/F6** What the F**K? Oh! The **Item Specific Help** makes this a little clearer:
 - **First Select an Item** in the list, then:
 - **<F5>** will move it **UP** and
 - **<F6>** will move it **DOWN**.

The name of the game, however, is to get the device you want to boot from, to the top of the list.

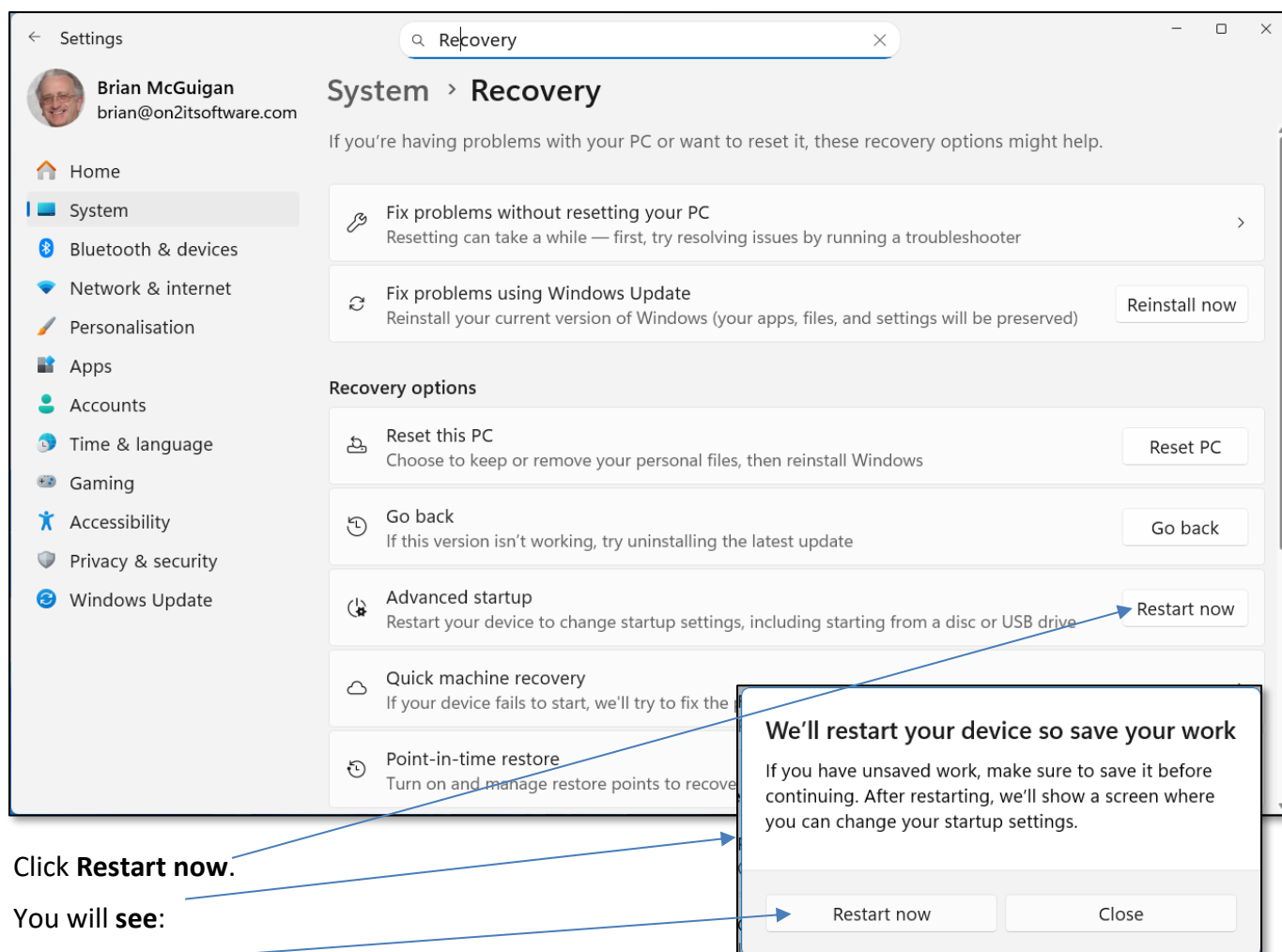
Once you have done so:

- **F10 Save and Exit** will save you settings and exit the BIOS.
- **F9 Setup Defaults** will *presumably* reset everything to the beginning – so you can have another go.

Quite honestly if you come across a BIOS like this, you just have to 'give it a go' and see what works. As long as you realise what you are trying to achieve, you'll figure it out, in the end.

Using System Recovery

If you can't get into your BIOS or don't want to, and you are already in Windows, you can use System Recovery. Go into **Settings > System > Recovery**



Click **Restart now**.

You will see:

Click **Restart now** again.

This will take you to:

Choose an option

Select **Use a device**.

You will then You will then see:

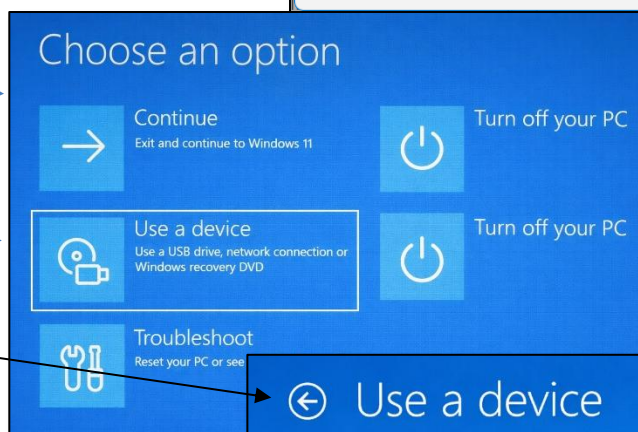
Use a Device

Select **Partition 1**.

It is the only bootable partition on the USB.

This will take you to the

On2it-WinFixIT – INTRODUCTION Screen that we saw above.



On2it-WinFixIT - INTRODUCTION

When you boot from a USB it will launch you into the **On2it-WinFixIT – INTRODUCTION** screen from where you can:

- **CHECK Compatibility** of your PC to run Windows 11, or
- **INSTALL Windows**.

You will NOT be able to perform any of the other options until you have installed windows:

For the remainder for what to expect see: [Starting From the USB Alone](#) above.

Appendix B - Installing Windows 11

This is where the:

- **Traditional User Interface**, and the
- **New User Interface**.

converge. From here on they are both the same.

We've included it as an Appendix to demystify the process, for those who have never done it before.

Allow plenty of time for an install (at least two hours) if you chose 'Keep Nothing'.

A 'Keep personal files and apps' install, is considerably quicker.

Your PC will restart several times and keep you informed of what it is doing.

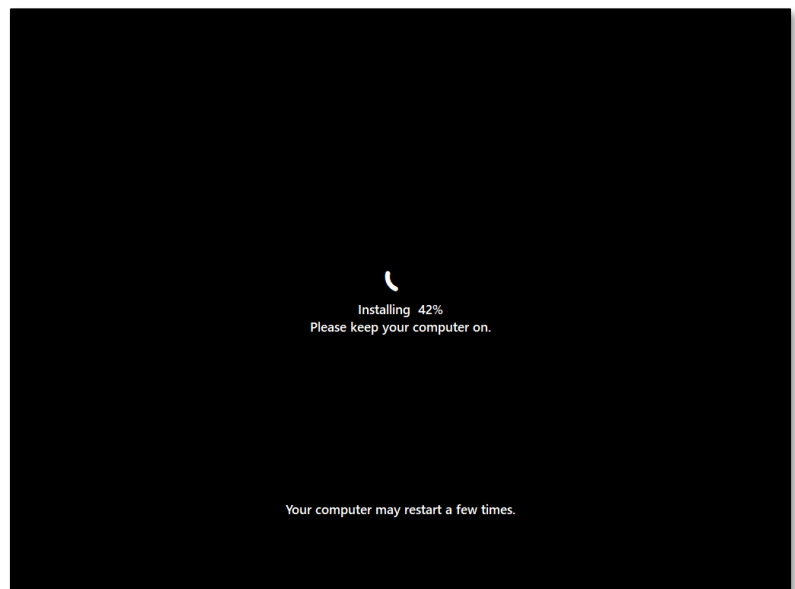


To keep this as brief as possible, we will only show you the screens where you have to do something.

42% Installing Caution

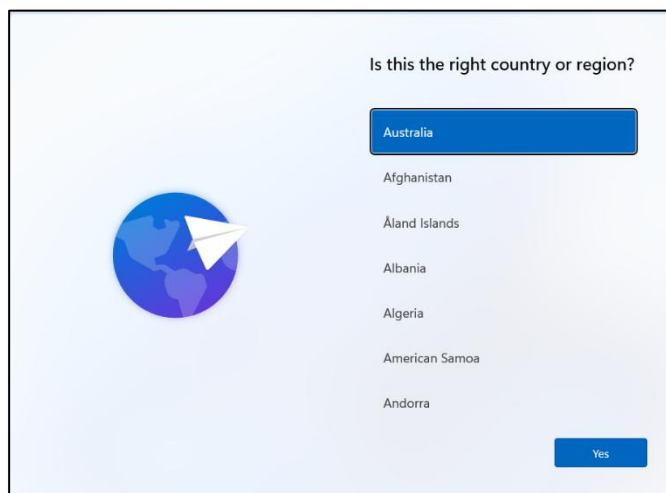
When Windows is installing, it might appear to 'hang' at 42% - making very little progress for a considerable time.

It hasn't, be patient. It will suddenly jump from 42% to 94%, and restart almost immediately.



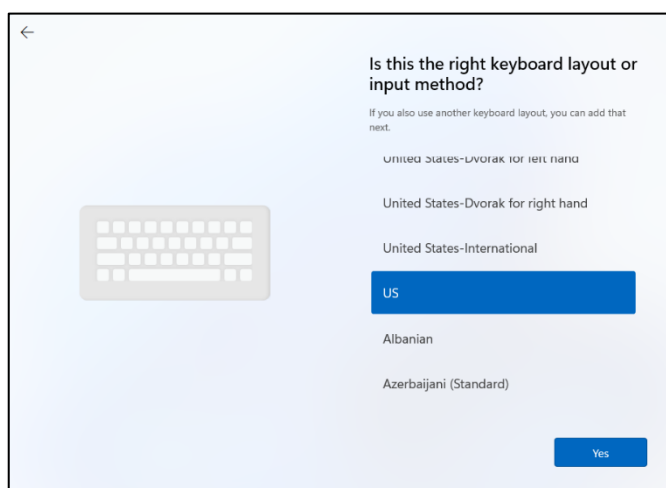
Choose Your Country or Region

This specifies the country you are in and your time zone.

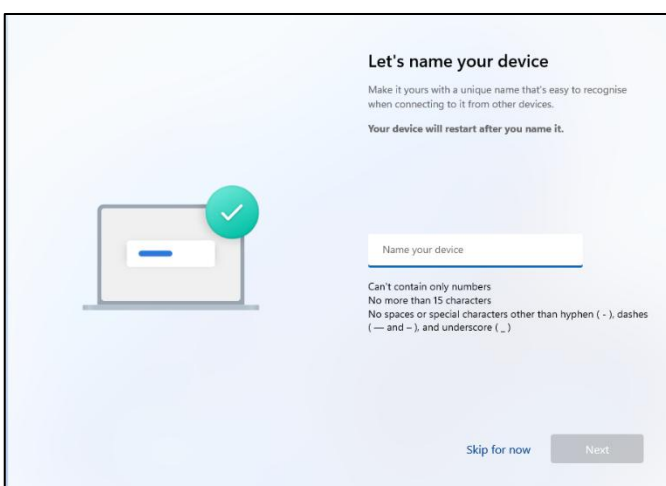


Choose your Keyboard

US is the right keyboard for Australia and New Zealand.



Name Your Device



Windows HOME skips the next page. In very recent Windows 11 Home builds, Microsoft now forces a Microsoft Account sign-in — there is no longer an easy offline/local account option on Home.

Never fear the DeBloater will take care of that. 😊

If you are installing Window PRO you will be asked:

How would you like to set up this device?

This is where you specify whether you want to:

- **Set up for personal use**, or
- **Set up for work or school**.

Set up for personal use

Means that you do not want to join a Network that has a 'Domain' Server that controls access to the network and a host of 'Domain Policies'.

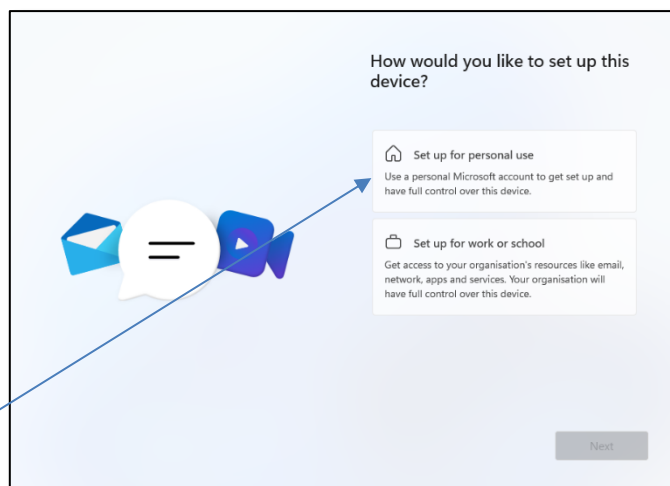
Set up for work or school

This enables you to join a 'Domain' Server, network – powered by Windows SERVER. Or setup your machine without a Microsoft Account.

Most HOME users need to select:

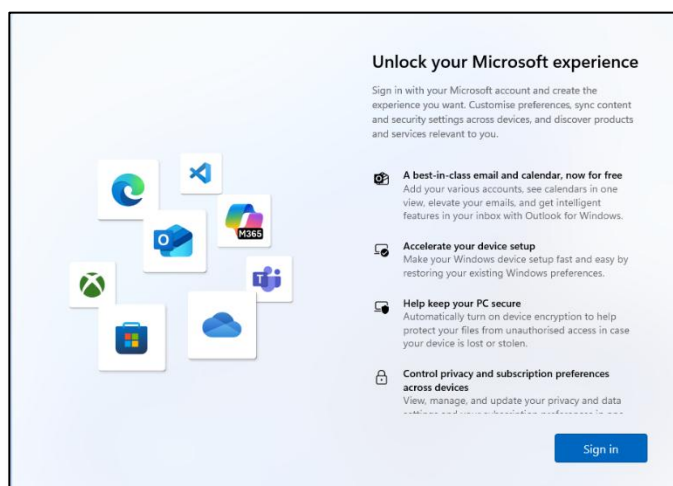
Set up for personal use.

Even if you propose to designate one of your PCs as a 'Server' that runs an ordinary copy of Windows, without the hassle of using Windows SERVER, then 'Set up for personal use', is the right option.



Unlock your Microsoft experience

This is a splash screen promoting Microsoft services (Office, OneDrive, Xbox, etc.). There is nothing to do here except click **Sign in** to proceed to adding your Microsoft account.



Let's add your Microsoft account

Windows will now ask you to sign in with a Microsoft account.

Enter your Microsoft account **e-mail address** and click **Next**.

Note for Windows 11 HOME users: Microsoft has removed the local (offline) account option from recent HOME builds. If you do not have a Microsoft account and do not want one, you will need to disconnect from the internet before reaching this screen — Windows will then offer a local account option. WinFixIT can handle this for you automatically.

Windows 11 Pro users who want a local account can go back to the **How would you like to set up this device?** screen and choose **Set up for work or school**, then select **Domain join instead** — this creates a local account without requiring a Microsoft account.

Just add your **E-mail, or Mobile Phone** here:

If you click **Learn More** you will see:

If you don't want a Microsoft Account, then Microsoft are making it increasingly harder all the time, to not have one during installation.

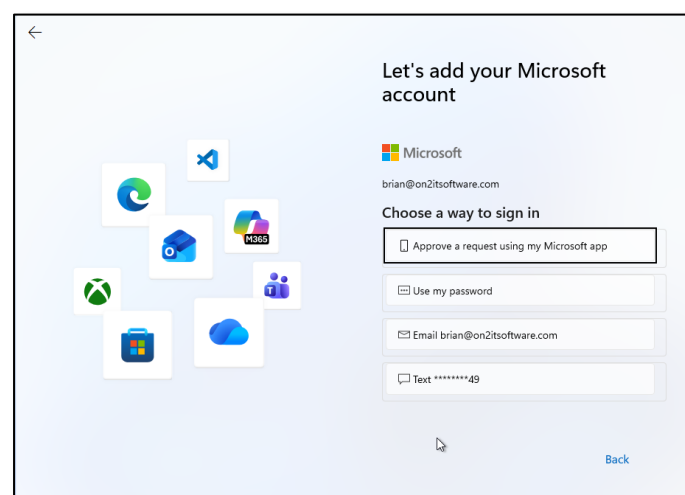
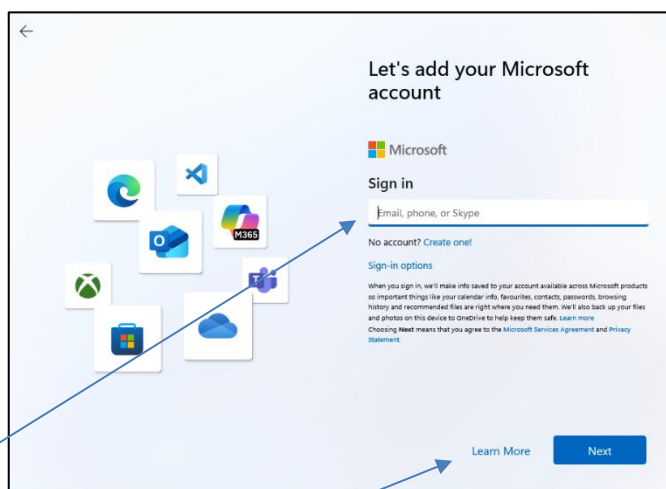
However, the DeBLOATer will advise you of the PROs and the CONs and sort that out for you later. So, you CAN remove it later, if you wish. 😊

Choose a way to sign in

After entering your e-mail, Windows offers several ways to verify your identity, as shown above:

- **Approve a request using my Microsoft app** — sends a notification to the Microsoft Authenticator app on your phone.
- **Use my password** — enter your Microsoft account password.
- **Email** — sends a one-time code to your e-mail address.
- **Text** — sends a one-time code to your registered mobile number.

Choose whichever method suits you and follow the prompts.



Verify your Phone Number / Enter password

Follow the on-screen prompts to complete whichever sign-in method you chose above. If you selected Text, enter the code sent to your phone. If you selected password, type your Microsoft account password and click **Sign in**.

Use your face to sign in

Windows Hello facial recognition. If your PC has an infrared (IR) camera, Windows will offer to set this up so you can sign in by looking at the screen.

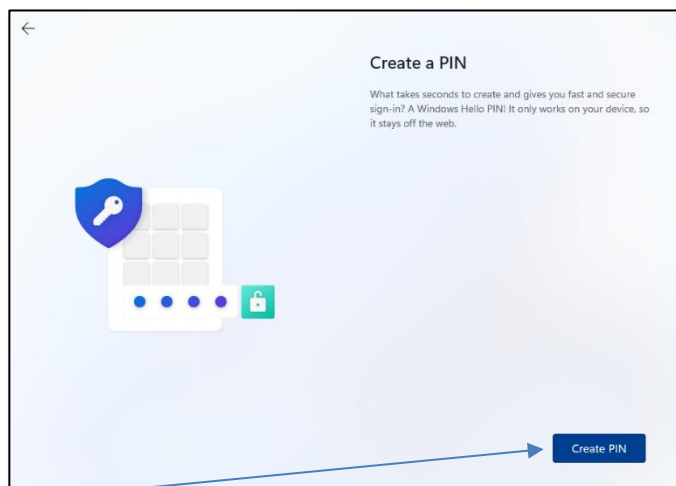
This is optional. Click **Set up** to configure it now, or **Skip for now** to skip it. You can set it up later in **Settings → Accounts → Sign-in options**.

All set

A confirmation screen telling you your Microsoft account has been linked. Click **Next** to continue.

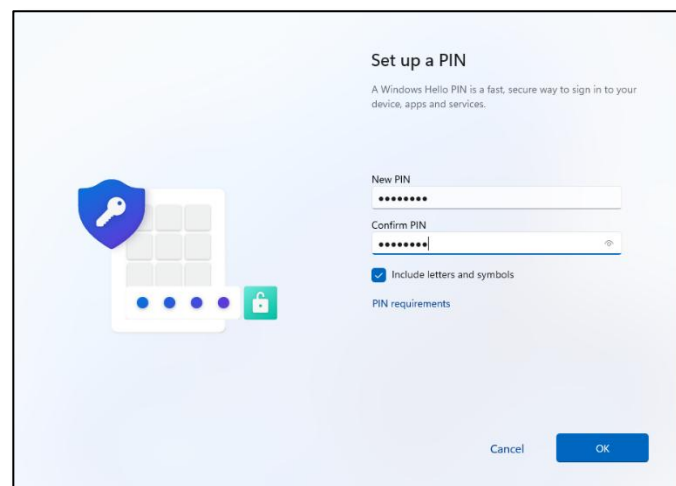
Now set up a PIN

Windows recommends setting up a PIN as a faster, more secure alternative to your Microsoft account password for signing in to **this device only**.



Click **Create a PIN**, then enter and confirm a PIN of your choice. You can include letters and symbols by ticking the checkbox if you want a longer passphrase instead of a numeric PIN.

This is strongly recommended — if you skip it, Windows will prompt you again later.



Choose privacy settings for your device

Location

Windows is asking whether it can use your location for things like finding local weather, maps, and nearby Wi-Fi.

- Click **Yes** if you want location-aware features.
- Click **No** if you prefer privacy.

You can change this at any time in **Settings → Privacy & security → Location**.

Find my device

This enables Microsoft to track your PC's location if it is lost or stolen — useful for laptops.

- Click **Yes** to enable it (recommended for laptops).
- Click **No** to skip it.

Requires a Microsoft account, which you have already set up.

Diagnostic data

Microsoft collects data about how Windows is used to improve the operating system. You have two options:

- **Send optional diagnostic data** — sends detailed usage information to Microsoft.
- **Required only** — sends the minimum data Microsoft requires.

Select **Required only** for better privacy.

Inking & typing

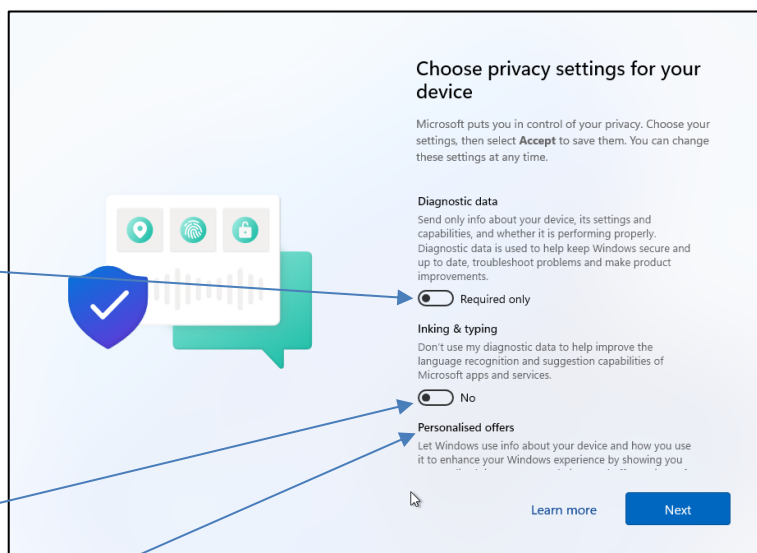
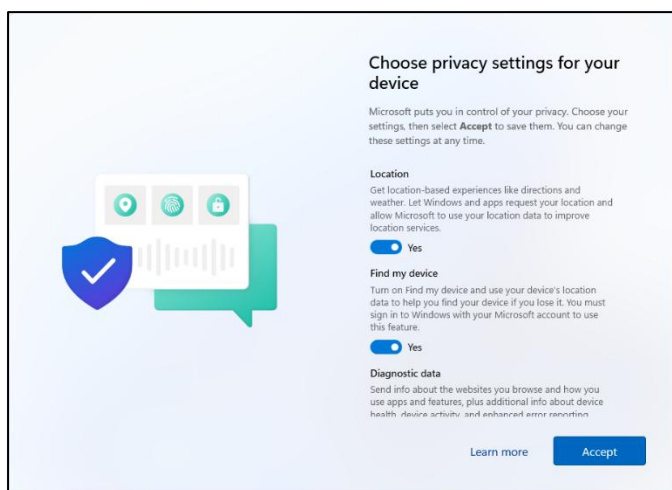
Microsoft asks whether it can collect samples of what you type and write (handwriting) to improve recognition.

Click **No** unless you specifically want to contribute to this. This is a privacy-sensitive setting — your keystrokes are not sent if you decline.

Personalised offers

Microsoft offers to use your diagnostic data to show you personalised tips, advertisements, and recommendations within Windows.

Click **No** to decline. This has no effect on Windows functionality — it only controls whether Microsoft uses your usage data for targeted suggestions.



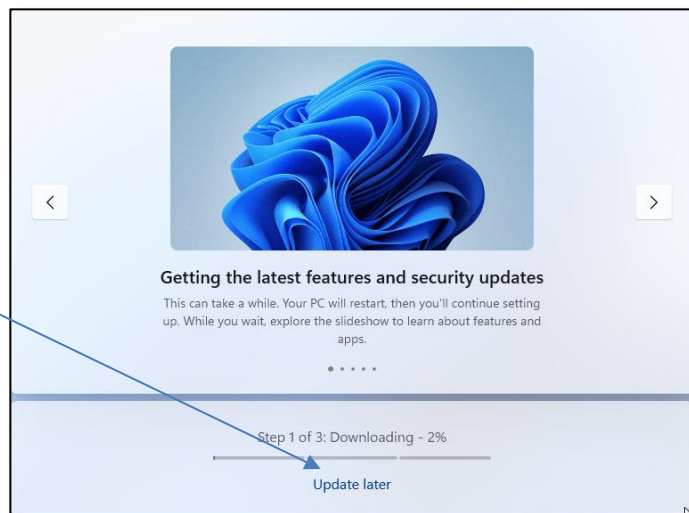
Getting the latest features and security updates

At this point if you are connected to the Internet, the system will download the latest version of Windows 11.

This can take ages. So go have a cup of coffee while you wait.

If you don't want to wait, Click **Update later**.

The next Windows Update will bring you up to date anyway. (But at least you don't have to hang around waiting for it to download, and it will install and shut down when you log out.) 😊



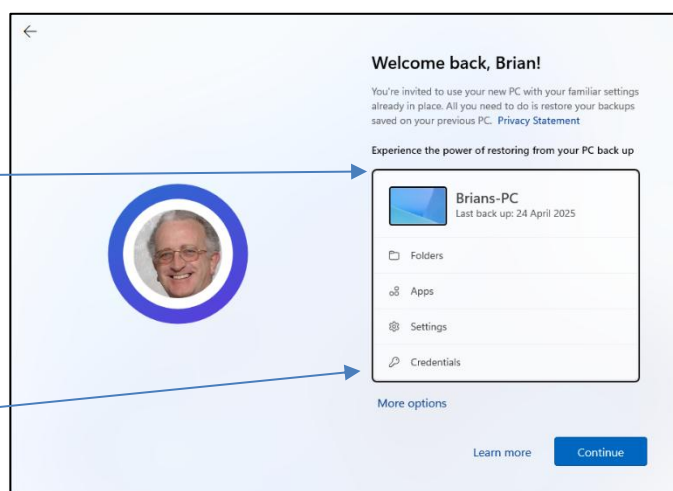
Welcome Back

If this Microsoft account has been used on another PC before, Windows may offer to restore settings, preferences, and app data from that device via a backup.

Click the **PC's name** to restore your previous settings.

If this is a clean install of the same PC, you may want to restore. If it is a different machine, choose whichever suits you.

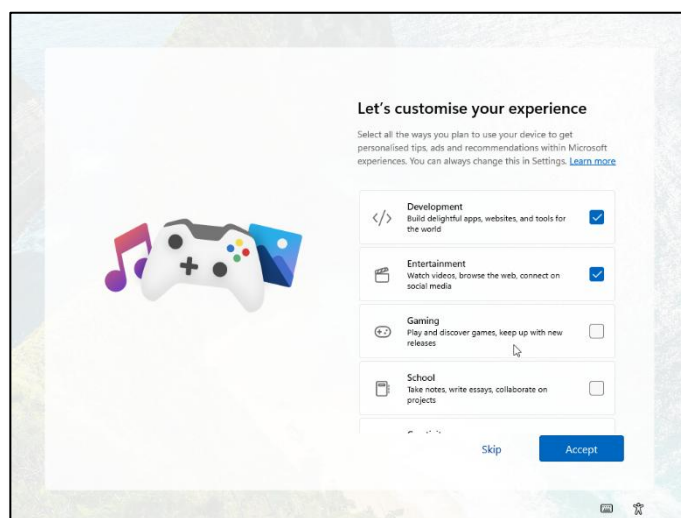
If you have used your Microsoft Account to setup more than one PC. They will all be listed under **More Options**. As will the option to set this one up as a new machine.



Let's customise your experience

Windows asks how you plan to use this PC — options typically include Gaming, Business, Creativity, School, and so on. Windows will use your selection to suggest relevant apps and settings.

Select whatever applies and click **Accept**, or click **Skip** to bypass this entirely. It makes no significant difference to how Windows functions.

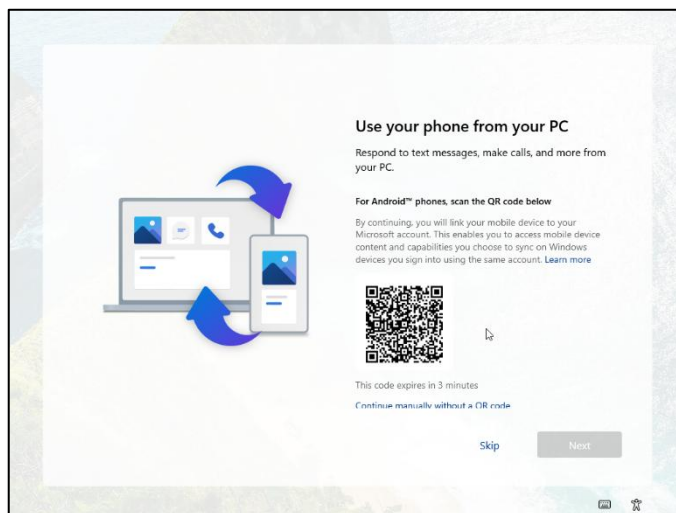


Use your phone from your PC

Windows is promoting the **Phone Link** feature, which lets you mirror your Android or iPhone phone's notifications, calls, and messages on your PC.

- Click **Continue** and follow the prompts if you want to set this up now.
- Click **Skip** to skip it. You can set it up later from the Phone Link app.

Note: Phone Link works well with Android phones. iPhone support is more limited.



Your Microsoft account and phone are now linked

A confirmation screen if you completed the Phone Link setup. Click **Continue**.

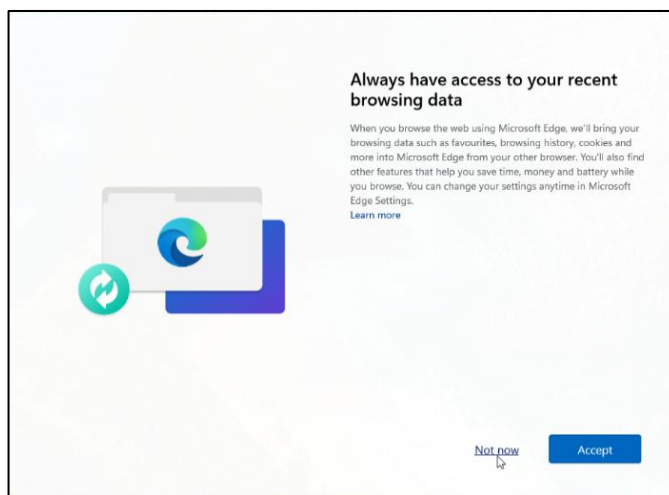
If you skipped Phone Link, you will not see this screen.

Always have access to your recent browsing data

Microsoft Edge offers to import your bookmarks, history, passwords, and settings from Chrome, Firefox, or another browser.

- Click **Import** to import your data.
- Click **No thanks** to skip.

You can do this at any time later from **Edge → Settings → Import browser data**.

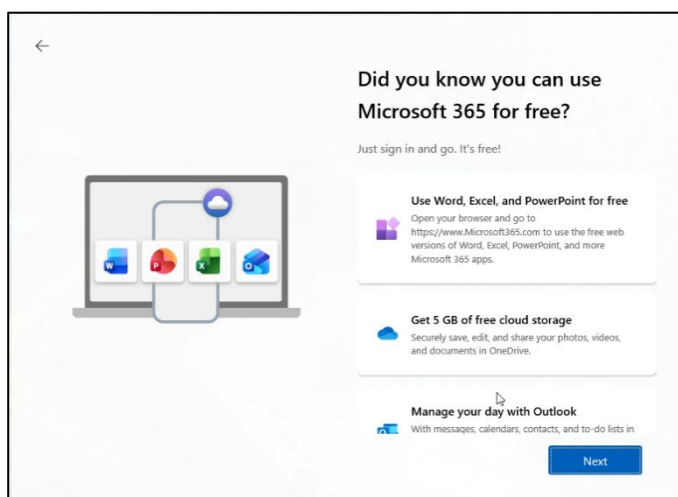


Did you know...

This is just Microsoft just trying to sell you stuff.

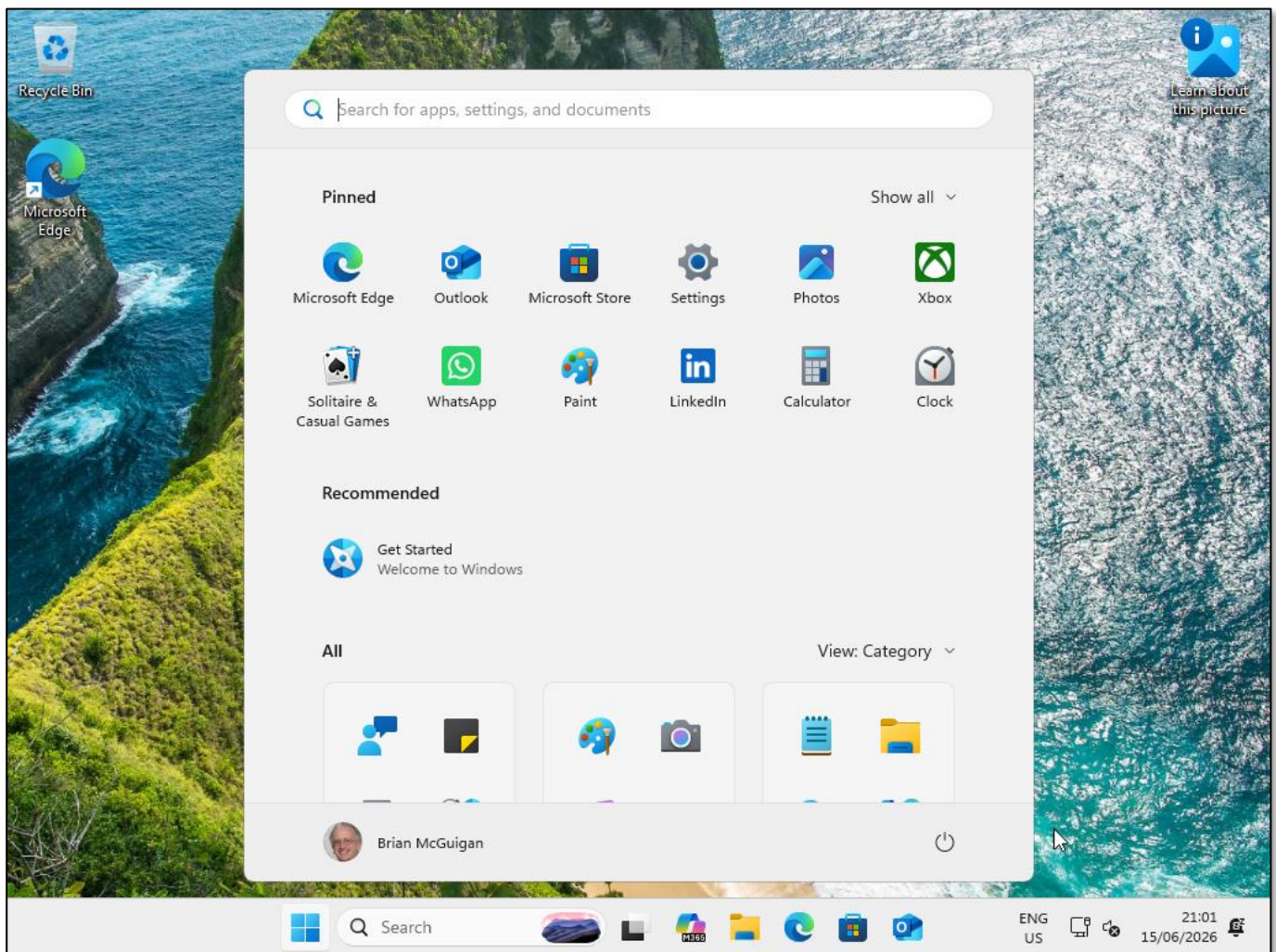
These used to be part of Windows Setup. It seems they no-longer are.

Looks like we are going to be reminded with notification pop-ups, post install. 😞



YOU'RE IN

The Windows 11 desktop will now appear for the first time. The installation is complete.



Appendix C - DeBloater GROUPS & OPTIONS

This Appendix details all the **Groups, Options** and **Advice**, *currently* in the DeBloater. The text below, is simply copied and pasted from the system. *So, it's pretty pointless reading this Appendix.* 🙄
As the system will produce identical advice, when you need it. But if you want to read our recommendations, all in one-place – here it is.

Major Windows Features

This group contains Microsoft's most intrusive and persistent features.

Your choices here will shape how much control you retain over your system - especially around subscriptions, cloud sync, and AI integration.

They will be installed by Microsoft, whether you want them or not. Left in place, they can confuse users by duplicating functionality already provided by other apps. The choices you make here will shape what you need to do in later groups, so review our advice carefully before proceeding.

Remove Microsoft 365

Microsoft 365 is Microsoft's subscription version of Microsoft Office. In many cases you can buy a perpetual licence for both Office Professional 2024 and Windows 11 (and related apps) for a fraction of the annual subscription cost of Microsoft 365 alone.

Pros The advantage of Microsoft 365 is that being a subscription version, it gets the latest features before the desktop version.

Cons That being said, Office Professional 2024 is so fully-featured that it will do virtually everything that everyone wants anyway. It is the version used by most major companies. So why would anyone want to pay more for an annual subscription than they'd pay for a perpetual licence?

Recommendation It is for that reason that we cannot recommend that you subscribe to Microsoft 365.

Microsoft will keep on trying to enrol you. We block them in such a way that HOPEFULLY you will not see their perpetual nagging, either. (You won't, unless Microsoft changes something.)

Please INSTALL Microsoft 365 - MANUALLY

To install Microsoft 365 manually:

1. Visit <https://www.office.com> and sign in with your Microsoft account.
2. Click on 'Install Office' and follow the prompts to download and install the latest version.
3. If you have a product key, you can redeem it at <https://setup.office.com>.
4. For more help, see the official Microsoft support site.

Note: This tool does not automate the installation of Microsoft 365. You must install it manually using the steps above.

Remove OneDrive

OneDrive is Microsoft's 'Cloud' Service that will automatically replicate your files to their servers on the Internet. They will **try** to convince you that it is an automatic backup - **it is NOT!** Any mistakes you make in your copy will be replicated to their copy. If you accidentally delete your copy, their copy gets deleted too.

OneDrive is useful if you want more than one device and/or user to have access to the same file. But even then, you still need a good backup system that keeps multiple versions offline - to protect you from accidental file deletions and unwanted changes.

Microsoft will store your files for free up to 5 GB; beyond that they will charge you. OneDrive is also very intrusive on your day-to-day operations, stealing files and hiding them in the cloud. For most users, OneDrive causes more confusion than benefit.

A true backup keeps multiple historical versions stored offline, where they cannot be changed by accident. If you want a good backup that keeps your files on a separate device, then we strongly recommend that you investigate third party backup tools such as 'EaseUS ToDo Backup', or many other FREE backup applications.

Other cloud services such as DropBox and Google Drive are also worth you considering, as an alternative to OneDrive.

Please INSTALL OneDrive - MANUALLY

OneDrive is Microsoft's 'Cloud' Service that will automatically replicate your files to their servers on the Internet. They will **try** to convince you that it is an automatic backup - **it is NOT!** Any mistakes you make in your copy will be replicated to their copy. If you accidentally delete your copy, their copy gets deleted too.

It is therefore our earnest recommendation **not to use it**.

However, you have chosen not to remove it. Since it is not already on your system, you have been given the option to INSTALL it instead.

To install OneDrive manually:

1. Visit <https://www.microsoft.com/en-us/microsoft-365/onedrive/download> and click "Download."
2. Run the downloaded installer and follow the on-screen instructions.
3. Once installed, sign in with your Microsoft account to set up OneDrive.

For more help, see the official Microsoft OneDrive support: <https://support.microsoft.com/onedrive>

Note: This tool does not automate the installation of OneDrive. You must install it manually using the steps above.

Remove Microsoft Teams

Teams is Microsoft's collaboration tool for chat, meetings, and file sharing. It's useful in corporate or school environments where everyone uses it.

For most home users, it adds little value and duplicates features already available in Outlook, Skype, or other apps. That's why we recommend removing it unless your workplace requires it.

Please INSTALL Microsoft Teams - MANUALLY

Teams is Microsoft's collaboration tool for chat, meetings, and file sharing. It's useful in corporate or school environments where everyone uses it.

For most home users, it adds little value and duplicates features already available in Outlook, Skype, or other apps. That's why we recommend removing it unless your workplace requires it.

However, you have chosen NOT to remove it. So, presumably you want it. To install Microsoft Teams:

1. Visit <https://www.microsoft.com/en/microsoft-teams/download-app> and click "Download Teams."
2. Run the downloaded installer and follow the on-screen instructions.
3. Once installed, sign in with your Microsoft account or organization credentials to set up Teams.

For more help, see the official Microsoft Teams support: <https://support.microsoft.com/teams>

Note: This tool does not automate the installation of Microsoft Teams. You must install it manually using the steps above.

Turn BitLocker OFF

BitLocker encrypts your drives so that if you lose your PC, or someone steals it, they cannot access the data stored on them. However, it does not protect your information against hackers, malware, or anyone who already knows your Windows password and can log in normally.

For most home users, BitLocker provides limited real-world benefit and can sometimes cause inconvenience, especially if hardware changes or boot issues occur. Unless you have highly sensitive data that must remain protected even if the device is physically stolen, BitLocker is often unnecessary.

If this item is **checked** and BitLocker is currently **ON**, we will turn it off immediately. Windows will then decrypt your drive in the background — this can take up to several hours on a large drive. Your PC remains fully usable throughout.

If you, un-check this item, your system will not be altered.

- If BitLocker is currently ON, it will remain ON.
- If BitLocker is currently OFF, it will remain OFF.

If BitLocker is currently OFF and you want it ON, you will HAVE to enable it through Windows itself, as your whole drive will have to be encrypted.

Important: Windows 11 can silently re-enable Device Encryption after updates or when signed in with a Microsoft Account — without warning you. To permanently block this, we also set a Windows Registry key that prevents Windows from doing so without your knowledge.

KEEP CoPilot

CoPilot is Microsoft's AI assistant, in Windows 11. It can summarise information, answer questions, and help with tasks. We recommend keeping it, as it's becoming a core part of Windows.

Without CoPilot, this system would not exist.

For, despite over 50 years' experience developing Systems, the author had no knowledge of:

- Windows internals (necessary to make it possible), or
- Powershell, used to develop it.

CoPilot provided both – generating over 13,000 lines of code, in the process.

So, CoPilot provided both the knowledge and ability to 'sort Windows 11 out' - even to the point of removing CoPilot. (Who says AI's not useful?)

But, by the end of the project, he graduated to Claude, as it got too complex for CoPilot.

Remove CoPilot

This option removes **Windows CoPilot**- the AI assistant built into Windows 11 itself. If you select this option, CoPilot will be removed from your system. If you want it back you will have to re-install it manually.

What about CoPilot everywhere else?

Microsoft has embedded CoPilot throughout its products - in Edge, in Bing, in the Microsoft 365 versions of Word, Excel and Outlook, and as a standalone app. If you feel that Microsoft has been somewhat overzealous in its enthusiasm for AI assistants, you are not alone.

However, disabling CoPilot in Edge, Bing, or Microsoft 365 requires either account-level changes or administrator access to a Microsoft 365 tenant - both of which are beyond the scope of this tool. For those, you will need to visit your Microsoft account settings directly.

Please INSTALL CoPilot - MANUALLY

To install or enable Microsoft CoPilot manually:

1. Make sure your Windows 11 is up to date.
2. Go to **Settings > Windows Update** and install all available updates.
CoPilot is integrated into recent versions of Windows 11.
If you do not see the CoPilot icon on your Taskbar, right-click the Taskbar and select "Show CoPilot (preview)" or enable it in **Settings > Personalization > Taskbar**.
3. If CoPilot is still unavailable, your device may not meet the hardware requirements or the feature may not be rolled out to your region yet. See it at the official Microsoft CoPilot FAQ for details.
Download it from: <https://apps.microsoft.com/detail/xp9cxngppj97xx?hl=en-GB&gl=US>
or visit the Microsoft Store.

For more help, visit the official Microsoft CoPilot support page: <https://support.microsoft.com/copilot>

Note: This tool does not automate the installation or activation of Microsoft CoPilot. You must enable it manually using the steps above.

KEEP Recall

One of the biggest frustrations when using a computer is finding something interesting - only to forget where you saw it. Microsoft intend to solve this problem with Windows Recall.

Recall automatically captures snapshots of your screen at periodic intervals.

When it was first announced many users expressed concern about potential privacy problems. Microsoft withdrew the product and addressed these concerns, by ensuring all data is **encrypted** and **stored locally**. So, no data is uploaded to the cloud.

Recall enables users to search and interact with previous content using natural language queries, enhancing productivity and memory recall.

Think of Recall as a visual AI-searchable Browser History. But instead of tracking only web activity, Recall extends to everything you do on your PC, making it easier to find and re-engage with past content.

It is exclusive to the latest so-called AI PCs, equipped with an NPU (Neural Processing Unit). It is now disabled by default, and users must actively enable it themselves.

So, if you are lucky enough to have it on your PC; keep it, try it. If in the end you don't like it, disable it.

CANNOT INSTALL Recall

One of the biggest frustrations when using a computer is finding something interesting - only to forget where you saw it. Microsoft aims to solve this problem with Windows Recall.

Unfortunately, Recall is only available on CoPilot+ PCs with a supported Neural Processing Unit (NPU) and at least 40 TOPS of Processing Power. This computer does not have the required hardware, so Recall cannot be installed or enabled.

Recall automatically captures snapshots of your screen at periodic intervals. They are **encrypted** and **stored locally**, ensuring that no data is uploaded to the cloud. Recall enables users to search and interact with previous content using natural language queries, enhancing productivity and memory recall.

Think of it as a visual AI-searchable Browser History. But instead of tracking only web activity, Recall extends to everything you do on your PC, making it easier to find and re-engage with past content.

You cannot install Recall on this PC. So, you may safely ignore this option.

Please INSTALL Recall - MANUALLY

To install or enable Windows Recall manually:

1. Ensure your PC meets the hardware requirements:
 - a CoPilot+ PC with a supported Neural Processing Unit (NPU) and
 - at least 40 TOPS of processing power.
2. Make sure Windows 11 is fully updated. Go to Settings > Windows Update and install all available updates.
3. If your device is eligible, open Settings > Privacy & security > Recall & snapshots.
4. Follow the prompts to enable Recall. You may need to sign in with your Microsoft account and accept additional terms.
5. For more help, see the official Microsoft Recall support:
<https://support.microsoft.com/windows/windows-recall-faq-7e3c2b1a-2b7e-4b7a-8c2e-2e8e6b6c1e5b>

Note: This tool does not automate the installation or activation of Windows Recall. You must enable it manually using the steps above. If your PC does not meet the requirements, Recall will not be available.

Microsoft Accounts

Microsoft make it almost impossible to install Windows 11 without setting up a Microsoft Account. A Microsoft Account connects you to cloud services, subscriptions, and sync features. However, many people prefer a Local Account for privacy and simplicity.

So, once you have installed Windows 11, you can setup a Local Account, and even delete the Microsoft Account. Full step-by-step instructions are in the User Manual on your USB.

Alternatively, you can also use the Options alongside, and we'll do it for you.

Create and Sign in with a Local Account

This will create a new Local Account with Administrator rights.

You will no longer need to use a Microsoft Account to log in. Your Microsoft Account will still be there, in case you want to use it - unless you use the next option.

Pros:

- Greater privacy: your files and settings stay on this PC.
- No nagging about subscriptions or OneDrive.
- Simpler login, no internet required.
- Full Administrator rights: you can install software

and manage system settings.

Cons:

- You lose automatic sync of settings and OneDrive integration.
- Microsoft Store purchases and some features may require a Microsoft Account.

Remove Microsoft Account entirely

This will disable ALL Microsoft Account users on this PC once a Local Account is created. Their local profiles will be removed, and they will no longer be able to be used to sign in on this PC. They will ONLY be able to log in with their Local Account.

Pros:

- Maximum privacy: no Microsoft Account linked to this PC.
- No cloud tie-ins or subscription prompts.

Cons:

- You cannot use Microsoft Store purchases, Xbox integration, or OneDrive.
- Some apps may require you to sign in again separately.
- You may not be able to share data with others, or yourself on other devices, unless you install some other Cloud service.
- The Microsoft Account itself is NOT deleted in the cloud; it can be re-added manually later if desired.
- You must set up recovery questions, on this PC to regain access - if you forget your password.

Remove Unwanted Apps

These options target Microsoft apps that are often installed with Windows 11. They either overlap with desktop Office tools, are specialist developer environments, or are very rarely used these days.

Removing them reduces confusion and streamlines your system.

Remove Outlook for Windows

This is Microsoft's new Outlook client that replaced *Mail & Calendar* . It is installed with Windows 11.

If you already use *Microsoft 365* , the full desktop Outlook (often called *Outlook Classic*), or even another mail client, you don't need this too. It will only cause you confusion and grief!

Please INSTALL Outlook for Windows - MANUALLY

You have chosen not to remove Outlook for windows, but because it is not current installed on your system, you have to INSTALL it instead.

To do so, please:

1. Open the Microsoft Store from your Start Menu.
2. In the Store's search bar, type "Outlook for Windows" and press Enter.
3. Click on "Outlook (new)" or "Outlook for Windows" in the search results.
4. Click "Get" or "Install" and follow the on-screen instructions to download and install Outlook.
5. Once installed, open Outlook and sign in with your Microsoft account to complete setup.

For more help, see the official Microsoft Outlook support: <https://support.microsoft.com/outlook>

Note: This tool does not automate the installation of Outlook for Windows. You must install it manually using the steps above.

Remove Xbox

The Xbox app connects your PC to Microsoft's gaming ecosystem, providing access to Xbox Game Pass, cloud gaming, and social features. If you do not play Xbox games or use Game Pass, this app serves no purpose on your PC.

What gets removed:

- The Xbox app itself.
- Xbox Game Bar - the overlay accessed with **Win + G**.
- Xbox Game Overlay and related components.
- Xbox Speech to Text Overlay.
- Xbox Identity Provider.

Note: The **Xbox Game Callable UI** component is a protected Windows system component and cannot be removed. This does not affect normal system operation.

After removal: If you start a game and see a popup about **ms-gamingoverlay**, this is Windows trying to launch the Game Bar. This tool disables that automatically - you should not see this popup.

Please INSTALL Xbox - MANUALLY

To reinstall the Xbox app:

- Open the Microsoft Store.
- Search for Xbox.
- Click Install.

This will reinstall the Xbox app and Game Bar components.

Alternatively, visit <https://www.xbox.com/en-GB/apps/xbox-app-for-pc> for the direct download link.

KEEP Solitaire

Microsoft Solitaire Collection is one of the most popular games included with Windows 11. It includes classic Solitaire, Spider, FreeCell, Pyramid, and TriPeaks - all free to play.

Did you know? Solitaire was originally included with Windows 3.0 back in 1990 - not just for entertainment, but to teach people how to use a mouse! Dragging and dropping cards is excellent practice for anyone still getting used to controlling a mouse precisely. Over 35 years later, it is still doing its job beautifully.

If you enjoy card games or are still getting comfortable with the mouse, we recommend keeping it. If you never play it, removing it will free up a small amount of disk space.

Note: If you remove Solitaire and change your mind, you can reinstall it for free from the **Microsoft Store**.

Please INSTALL Solitaire - MANUALLY

Microsoft Solitaire Collection is not currently installed on your PC.

To reinstall it:

- Open the Microsoft Store.
- Search for Microsoft Solitaire Collection.
- Click Install.

Alternatively, visit <https://apps.microsoft.com/detail/9wzdncrfhwd2?hl=en-GB&gl=AUfor> the direct download link.

It is completely free and will be reinstalled within a few minutes.

Select Default Browser

All modern browsers are fast, secure, and capable - the differences come down to privacy, ecosystem integration, and personal preference. The real truth of the matter, is that it probably doesn't matter which you use, these days as conventional searches are becoming outpaced by AI. But because some people are so passionate about it, we've offered you a choice of the World's most popular Browsers.

Simply:

- **INSTALL** as many Browsers as you want.
- **SELECT** any installer Browser to use as your Default.

The selected Browser will then be displayed as:

- <Browser Name> SELECTED

Please Note: There is no facility to uninstall a browser in the DeBLOATer.

To **UNINSTALL** a Browser - **MANUALLY** use:

Settings > Apps > Installed Apps Then:

1. **Scroll Down** - to find the Browser to be uninstalled
2. Click **More Options** It looks like ... on the right
3. Click **UNINSTALL**

Microsoft Edge SELECTED

Microsoft Edge is the built-in browser that comes with Windows 11. It is based on the same Chromium engine used by Google Chrome, so it is fast, compatible with virtually all websites, and supports Chrome extensions.

Pros:

- Already installed - no download needed.
- Deeply integrated with Windows 11, including PDF viewing, Windows Search, and the Start Menu.
- Supports all Chrome extensions from the Chrome Web Store.
- Built-in features include Collections, vertical tabs, a coupon finder, and a built-in screenshot tool.
- Microsoft regularly updates it for security.

Cons:

- Collects usage data for Microsoft by default.
- Pushes Microsoft services such as Bing and MSN News.
- Can feel intrusive with frequent prompts to use Microsoft features.

Our Recommendation: Edge is a capable browser and a perfectly good choice if you are happy with Microsoft's ecosystem. If privacy is a priority, consider Brave or Firefox instead.

INSTALL Google Chrome

Google Chrome is the world's most popular browser, used by over 60 of internet users. It is fast, reliable, and has the largest library of extensions of any browser.

Pros:

- Fastest JavaScript performance of any major browser.
- Enormous library of extensions from the Chrome Web Store.
- Excellent compatibility - virtually every website is tested on Chrome.
- Seamless integration with Google services such as Gmail, Drive, and Google Docs.
- Syncs bookmarks, history, and settings across all your devices.

Cons:

- Collects significant usage data for Google's advertising platform.
- Can be memory-hungry with many tabs open.
- Requires a Google account to get the most out of it.

Our Recommendation: Chrome is an excellent all-rounder, but if privacy concerns you, consider Brave - it is based on the same engine but blocks tracking by default.

INSTALL Firefox

Firefox is developed by Mozilla, a non-profit organisation whose mission is to keep the internet open and private. It is the only major browser not based on Google's Chromium engine, giving it a genuinely independent approach to web standards and privacy.

Pros:

- Strong privacy by default - blocks many trackers out of the box.
- Highly customisable with a large library of extensions.
- Not owned by Google or Microsoft - independent of Big Tech ecosystems.
- Excellent developer tools.
- Open source - its code is publicly auditable.

Cons:

- Occasionally slower than Chrome or Edge on some JavaScript benchmarks.
- A small number of websites are optimised for Chrome only and may behave differently in Firefox.

Our Recommendation: Firefox is our top recommendation for users who prioritise privacy and prefer not to be part of Google's or Microsoft's ecosystem.

INSTALL Brave

Brave is a privacy-focused browser built on the same Chromium engine as Chrome and Edge. It blocks advertisements and trackers by default - without needing any extensions - making it significantly faster on ad-heavy websites.

Pros:

- Blocks ads and trackers automatically - no extensions needed.
- Noticeably faster page loads on many websites as a result.
- Compatible with all Chrome extensions.
- Built-in VPN and Tor private browsing mode for maximum privacy.
- Does not sell your data to advertisers.

Cons:

- Has its own optional advertising system (**Brave Rewards**) which some users find philosophically at odds with its privacy stance - though it is entirely opt-in and easily ignored.
- Less well known, so occasional websites may behave unexpectedly.

Our Recommendation: Brave is our top recommendation for users who want Chrome's compatibility and extension library, but with privacy built in from the start.

INSTALL Opera

Opera is one of the oldest browsers still in active development, now also based on Chromium. It has a distinctive sidebar interface and includes several built-in features that other browsers require extensions for.

Pros:

- Built-in free VPN - no extension or account needed.
- Built-in ad blocker.
- Unique sidebar with quick access to WhatsApp, Messenger, Instagram, and other services.
- Battery saver mode for laptops.
- Compatible with Chrome extensions.

Cons:

- Owned by a Chinese consortium since 2016 - which raises data privacy concerns for some users.
- The built-in VPN routes through Opera's own servers, so it is not truly private in the way a paid VPN is.
- Smaller user base means less community support.

Our Recommendation: Opera is worth considering if you like its unique sidebar and built-in tools. However, be aware of its ownership if data privacy is important to you.

Tidy the Start Menu

Keep it clean and professional. Windows 11 puts a lot of minor Apps into the Start Menu - in case you need them. Removing them reduces confusion and streamlines your system.

KEEP the ones you are likely to use regularly and remove the rest. Our 'Recommended Options' are shown.

Please Note: Microsoft's security does not permit anything to be pinned to, or removed from the Start Menu, unless it is done by YOU, the User, through the standard Windows interface. Therefore, we cannot do it for you. We can offer Advice on which Apps to KEEP or Remove, but you will have to do it for yourself.

Simply point at any Option you are interested in. You will then, receive full instructions on how to do it yourself, here in the Advice Panel. This can then be printed, one at a time, or appended to you own WORD document, for later attention.

Remove Microsoft 365 PIN from the Start Menu

Microsoft 365 is Microsoft's subscription-based Office suite. If you already use a perpetual version of Office (like Office 2024), or prefer free alternatives like LibreOffice, you don't need this Shortcut cluttering your Start Menu.

To **UNPIN** an App from the Start Menu:

- Open the **Start Menu**,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select **Unpin from Start**.

Remove Xbox PIN from the Start Menu

The Xbox app connects your PC to Microsoft's gaming ecosystem. If you don't play Xbox games or use Game Pass, this app serves no purpose and can be unpinned from the Start Menu.

To **UNPIN** an App from the Start Menu:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select **Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Solitaire pinned to Start Menu

Solitaire is a casual game bundled with Windows. If you don't use your PC for gaming or prefer a cleaner Start Menu, you can safely Unpin it from the Start Menu.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select **'Unpin from Start**.

Remove LinkedIn PIN from the Start Menu

LinkedIn is Microsoft's professional networking platform. Unless you actively use it for job hunting or business connections, this shortcut is unnecessary. So, Unpin it from the Start Menu.

To **UNPIN** an App from the Start Menu:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select **'Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Outlook pinned to Start Menu

Outlook is Microsoft's email and calendar client. If you use it to manage your communications, appointments, or contacts, it's worth keeping in easy reach.

But there is no point in pinning it to the Start Menu, if you intend to keep it pinned to the Taskbar, as is recommended below.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

KEEP File Explorer pinned to Start Menu

File Explorer is essential for navigating folders, managing files, and accessing drives. It's a core part of Windows - keep it pinned.

If you intend to keep File Manager in the Taskbar, as is recommended alongside, then you probably don't need it in the Start Menu as well.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Calculator pinned to Start Menu

The Calculator app is fast, lightweight, and handy for everyday maths, currency conversions, and even scientific calculations. Most users find it useful.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Notepad pinned to Start Menu

Notepad is a simple, reliable text editor. It's perfect for quick notes, editing scripts, or viewing plain text files. Lightweight and indispensable.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Snipping Tool pinned to Start Menu

Snipping Tool lets you capture screenshots, annotate them, and save or share. It's ideal for troubleshooting, documentation, or sharing visual snippets.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

KEEP Photos pinned to Start Menu

Photos is the default image viewer and editor in Windows. It's useful for browsing, cropping, and enhancing pictures without needing extra software.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Start Menu, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- Open the **Start Menu** ,
- **Right-click** the App,
- Select '**Unpin from Start**.

Simplify the Taskbar

Please Note: Microsoft's security does not permit anything to be pinned to, or removed from the Taskbar, unless it is done by YOU, the User, through the standard Windows interface. Therefore, we cannot do it for you. We can offer Advice on which Apps to KEEP or Remove, but you will have to do it for yourself.

Simply point at any Option you are interested in. You will then, receive full instructions on how to do it yourself, here in the Advice Panel. This can then be printed, one at a time, or appended to your own WORD document, for later attention.

Once upon a time , the only applications that appeared in the Taskbar, were ones that were currently running. This was to enable you to switch between them, easily.

These days, however, you can pin Applications permanently to the Taskbar. The problem with this, is that you cannot tell which are open, and which are not - simply by looking at the Taskbar. We therefore suggest that you restrict pinning Apps to the Taskbar that you use frequently and will open with a single click.

- For most people this will be the Applications shown. For other applications that have Documents associated with them that you use fairly frequently, like Microsoft WORD, for instance, it is just as easy to use the Start Menu, anyway. For, if you pinned WORD to the Taskbar, and opened it from there, you'd still have open the Document you want.

By comparison, clicking the Start Menu once, then clicking the Document you want, is an absolute breeze - as most of the time it's a recent Document! So, there is no point in it permanently occupying space on the Taskbar.

KEEP Search Box, ON the Taskbar

Microsoft has changed the Search Box behaviour more than once. Previously, clicking it merely opened the Start Menu's Search panel - you could not type into the Taskbar Search Box itself. That was enough reason to remove it.

From Build 26200, Microsoft has restored and enhanced it: \par

- **Click in it without typing**, and it shows your Recent Apps, Top Apps, and Quick Searches you might find useful.
- **Start typing**, and it searches directly from the Taskbar without opening the Start Menu.

Whether to keep it is now genuinely a matter of preference. On balance, we prefer to KEEP it - hence our recommendation.

If you like quick access to recent activity and a visible search entry point, it is worth keeping. If you prefer a cleaner Taskbar, pressing the <Windows> key and typing does the same thing. This option only hides or shows the Search Box. It does not disable Search itself.

To change your **Search Box settings** :

- Right-click anywhere on the **Taskbar** ,
- Click **Taskbar settings**,
- Set **Search** to either:
 - **hide**
 - **Search icon only**
 - **Search icon and label**
 - **Search box**

KEEP CoPilot, ON the Taskbar

CoPilot is Microsoft's AI assistant, integrated directly into Windows. From the Taskbar you can launch it with a single click to get summaries, explanations, or help with tasks. Since it's becoming a core feature, we recommend keeping it pinned for quick access.

KEEP File Manager, ON the Taskbar

File Explorer (File Manager) is essential for navigating folders, drives, and files. Having it pinned to the Taskbar means you can open it instantly, without digging through the Start Menu. This is one of the few apps worth keeping there permanently.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Taskbar, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- **Right-click** the App on the Taskbar,
- Click **Unpin from taskbar**.

KEEP Edge, ON the Taskbar

Edge is Microsoft's built-in web browser. Even if you mainly use another browser, it can be handy to keep Edge pinned for system tasks, downloads, or compatibility with Microsoft services. If you use Edge as your main browser, it definitely belongs on the Taskbar.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Taskbar, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- **Right-click** the App on the Taskbar,
- Click **Unpin from taskbar**.

KEEP Outlook, ON the Taskbar

Outlook is **Microsoft's** email and calendar client. If you rely on it for work or personal communication, pinning it to the Taskbar gives you one-click access to your inbox and schedule. This saves time compared to opening it from the Start Menu.

Obviously, to **KEEP** an App that is already in the Taskbar, you don't have to do a thing.

If you don't want to keep an App that is already there, you can **UNPIN** it. So:

- **Right-click** the App on the Taskbar,
- Click **Unpin from taskbar**.

Remove Microsoft Store, FROM the Taskbar

The Microsoft Store is where you can download apps, games, and updates. Most users rarely open it directly, since apps update automatically in the background. If you don't actively browse or install apps from the Store, you can remove it from the Taskbar to reduce clutter.

To **UNPIN** an App from the Taskbar:

- **Right-click** the App on the Taskbar,
- Click **Unpin from taskbar**.

Keep the Desktop Clean

These days there is no need to clutter your Desktop with application Icons, as the Start Menu will contain all your regularly used Apps, and the Search Bar gives you ready access to everything else.

KEEP Recycle Bin, ON the Desktop

This is suggested, so that you can Drag and Drop files into it. However, even this is really not needed. The delete key is just as effective.

Remove Edge, FROM the Desktop

This is Microsoft's latest Web Browser, that they will stick on your Desktop. But it is really not needed on your Desktop. Particularly if you decided to keep it in your Taskbar!

Privacy & Telemetry

Windows 11 collects a significant amount of diagnostic and behavioural data. Some of this helps Microsoft improve Windows, but much of it is used for advertising, personalisation, and product recommendations.

This group allows you to reduce or eliminate the most intrusive data collection.

These options do not affect system stability, and most users will benefit from disabling them.

Remove Advertising ID

The Advertising ID is used by apps and websites to track your behaviour and personalise ads. Disabling it does not remove advertising from Windows. It only stops ads being tailored to your activity. You will still see ads, but they will be generic rather than targeted.

Windows advertising comes from several different sources, including the Start Menu, the lock screen, Widgets, Microsoft Store apps, and system suggestions. This option only affects personalised advertising. Other types of Windows advertising are controlled by separate settings, which are covered in later options.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some online services may still personalise content based on your web activity. If you use a local account, disabling the Advertising ID prevents apps from tracking your behaviour entirely.

Ad blockers cannot remove Windows-built-in advertising, but Options below can. They are marked with: **This option reduces or removes Windows-built-in advertising**

Remove Tailored Experiences

Tailored Experiences uses your diagnostic data to customise tips, ads, and recommendations across Windows. Disabling it does not remove advertising, but it prevents Windows from analysing how you use your device to influence what you see.

This setting controls behaviour-based personalisation inside Windows itself. It does not affect web advertising or Microsoft Store apps, and it does not depend on the Advertising ID.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some online services may still personalise content based on your web activity. If you use a local account, disabling Tailored Experiences prevents Windows from using your diagnostic data for any personalised suggestions.

This option reduces or removes Windows-built-in advertising.

Remove Inking and Typing Personalisation

Windows can analyse your typing and handwriting to improve text suggestions and handwriting recognition. This data is processed in the cloud, and disabling this feature prevents Windows from sending your typing patterns or handwriting samples to Microsoft.

Turning this off does not affect normal typing or the on-screen keyboard. It only disables cloud-based learning and personalisation. If you do not use handwriting features, or if you prefer not to have your input data analysed, it is safe to disable this option.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some personalisation may still occur in online services, but Windows will no longer upload typing or handwriting data from this device. If you use a local account, disabling this feature prevents Windows from collecting or analysing any inking or typing data.

Remove Location Tracking

Location services allow Windows and apps to determine your approximate position using Wi-Fi, network data, and optional device sensors. Disabling this prevents apps from accessing your location and stops Windows from storing or sharing location information.

Turning this off does not affect core system functions, but apps that rely on location - such as Maps, Weather, or Find My Device - may show less accurate or less relevant information. If you do not use location-based features, disabling this option improves privacy with no noticeable impact.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some online services may still estimate your location based on your IP address. If you use a local account, disabling Location Tracking prevents Windows and apps on this device from accessing or storing your location.

Remove Activity History

Activity History stores a record of the apps you use, the files you open, and the websites you visit, and it can sync this information to your Microsoft Account. Disabling this prevents Windows from collecting this activity data and stops it from being uploaded to the cloud.

Turning this off does not affect normal app usage or your ability to reopen recent files. It only disables the centralised activity log that Windows uses for features such as Timeline and cross-device continuity. If you prefer not to have a record of your activity stored or synced, it is safe to disable this option.

If you use a Microsoft Account, disabling Activity History prevents Windows from uploading your activity to your account. If you use a local account, Windows will not collect or store Activity History on this device at all.

Remove Feedback Frequency

Windows occasionally prompts you to provide feedback about your experience. Reducing the feedback frequency prevents these pop-ups from interrupting your work and stops Windows from requesting additional diagnostic information.

Disabling or minimising feedback prompts does not affect system performance or functionality. It simply reduces the number of notifications Windows displays and prevents Windows from asking for optional feedback.

If you use a Microsoft Account, feedback you choose to provide may still be associated with your account. If you use a local account, Windows will not link any feedback to an online identity, and reducing feedback frequency prevents most prompts from appearing.

Remove Diagnostic Data Upload

Diagnostic data includes information about how Windows and apps perform on your device. When enabled, Windows can upload this data to Microsoft to help identify problems, improve features, and provide troubleshooting suggestions. Disabling this option prevents Windows from sending diagnostic data beyond what is required for basic security and reliability.

Turning this off does not affect normal system operation. It simply limits the amount of information Windows is allowed to upload. Features that rely on enhanced diagnostics, such as tailored troubleshooting or certain preview features, may provide less detailed recommendations.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some online services may still collect diagnostic information related to those services. If you use a local account, disabling Diagnostic Data Upload prevents Windows from sending optional diagnostic data from this device.

Remove Cloud Content Suggestions

Windows may suggest content from the cloud, including files, apps, and online recommendations based on how you use Microsoft services. These suggestions can appear in the Start Menu, File Explorer, and other parts of Windows.

Disabling this option prevents Windows from analysing your cloud activity to generate personalised suggestions. It does not affect your ability to access cloud files or use services such as OneDrive, Outlook, or Microsoft Store apps. It simply stops Windows from using your cloud usage patterns to recommend content.

If you use a Microsoft Account, some online services may still personalise content within the service itself. If you use a local account, disabling Cloud Content Suggestions prevents Windows from using any cloud-based activity from this device for personalised recommendations.

This option reduces or removes Windows-built-in advertising.

Remove Web Search in Start Menu

When you search in the Start Menu, Windows may send your query to Bing to provide online results alongside local files and apps. This can include suggestions, web links, and other cloud-based content.

Disabling this option keeps all Start Menu searches local to your PC. Windows will no longer send your search terms to Bing, and the Start Menu will only show results from your installed apps, settings, and local files.

If you use a Microsoft Account, online services may still provide web results inside their own apps, but Start Menu searches will remain local. If you use a local account, disabling this option prevents Windows from sending any Start Menu search queries to the cloud.

This option reduces or removes Windows-built-in advertising.

KEEP SmartScreen Filter

SmartScreen protects you from malicious websites, unsafe downloads, and potentially harmful apps. It checks files and links against Microsoft's security database to warn you before you open something dangerous.

Although SmartScreen sends limited data to Microsoft for threat analysis, it provides significant security benefits and helps block common attacks. Disabling it reduces your protection against phishing, malware, and untrusted downloads.

We recommend keeping SmartScreen enabled unless you have a specific reason to disable it or you already use alternative security tools that provide equivalent protection.

Remove Microsoft Edge Telemetry

Microsoft Edge, like Windows itself, collects and sends telemetry data to Microsoft. This is separate from Windows telemetry and operates independently - disabling Windows diagnostic data does not stop Edge from sending its own usage and performance data.

Edge telemetry includes information about how you use the browser, which features you interact with, and performance metrics. While Microsoft states this data is anonymised, it is collected continuously in the background.

Disabling Edge telemetry prevents the browser from sending this usage data to Microsoft. It does not affect browsing speed, security updates, or any browser features.

Note: Edge may still send minimal data required for security features such as SmartScreen. This option reduces optional telemetry, not security-critical communication.

Remove Customer Experience Improvement Program

The Customer Experience Improvement Program (CEIP) is a Microsoft scheme that collects anonymous data about how you use Windows and Microsoft software. This includes information about hardware configuration, feature usage patterns, and application behaviour.

Microsoft uses this data to identify trends and improve future versions of Windows and its applications. Participation is technically voluntary, but CEIP is enabled by default and runs silently in the background through a series of scheduled tasks.

Disabling CEIP stops these scheduled tasks from running and prevents Windows from collecting and uploading this usage data. It does not affect system performance, stability, or your ability to receive updates.

Note: CEIP is separate from Windows diagnostic telemetry, which is controlled by the **Remove Diagnostic Data Upload** option above. Disabling both together provides the most comprehensive reduction in background data collection.

Performance Acceleration

Windows includes several hidden performance features that improve responsiveness, reduce UI latency, and optimise CPU scheduling. These options enable Microsoft's internal Low Latency Profile (LLP), foreground scheduling boosts, and reduced background task throttling.

This group enables advanced performance acceleration features.

All options are safe and reversible.

ENABLE Low Latency Profile (LLP)

Microsoft's hidden Low Latency Profile (LLP), temporarily boosts CPU frequency during Start Menu, Search, and shell interactions. This improves responsiveness and reduces UI lag, especially on low-end or older hardware.

Requires KB5089573 or later.

ENABLE Scheduler Responsiveness Mode

Improves foreground application responsiveness by increasing foreground CPU quantum length and priority boost. This reduces input latency and improves UI smoothness, especially on older or heavily loaded systems.

May slightly reduce background task performance.

ENABLE Reduced Background Task Latency

This works by disabling Windows background throttling mechanisms including Power Throttling, Background Access throttling, and EcoQoS. This reduces latency for background tasks and improves overall system responsiveness.

May increase battery usage on laptops.

Performance Acceleration

Windows includes several hidden performance features that improve responsiveness, reduce UI latency, and optimise CPU scheduling. **This group allows you to disable visual effects that consume CPU and GPU resources without affecting functionality.**

All options are safe and reversible.

DISABLE Transparency Effects

Windows 11 applies a frosted-glass transparency effect to the Start Menu, Taskbar, Settings, and other windows. This requires continuous GPU compositing to render the blurred backgrounds behind each transparent surface.

On modern hardware this is negligible. On older or integrated-graphics systems it can contribute to sluggish UI responses, particularly when opening the Start Menu or switching between windows.

Disabling transparency replaces the frosted-glass effect with a solid background colour. The interface looks slightly flatter but behaves identically in every other way.

Note: This setting is per-user. It applies to the current Windows user account only.

DISABLE Window Animations

Windows animates windows as they open, close, minimise, and maximise. It also animates menus, tooltips, and other interface elements as they appear and disappear. On fast hardware these transitions are smooth and barely perceptible.

On slower or older machines, particularly those with limited RAM or integrated graphics, these animations add measurable delay to every window interaction. Disabling them makes the interface feel noticeably more responsive - windows open and close instantly rather than fading or sliding into place.

This is one of the single most effective visual changes for improving perceived performance on older hardware.

Note: This setting is per-user. It applies to the current Windows user account only.

Background Services

Windows 11 runs a number of background services that support features such as gaming, cloud sync, widgets, and content suggestions. Many users do not need these services, and disabling them can reduce resource usage and improve privacy.

This group allows you to disable non-essential background services.

None of these changes affect core Windows functionality.

Remove Widgets Service

Widgets provide news, weather, sports, and other online content from the left-hand side of the Taskbar. They rely on background services that regularly connect to the internet to download updates and personalised information.

If you do not use Widgets, removing the service reduces network usage and prevents Windows from displaying news feeds, promotional cards, or other online suggestions. This also stops the Widgets panel from running in the background.

Removing the Widgets service does not affect core system functions or the Taskbar itself. It simply disables the online content feed and the background processes that support it.

Remove Xbox Game Bar Service

The Xbox Game Bar provides screen recording, performance overlays, game capture tools, and social features for gamers. It also runs background services that support in-game shortcuts and real-time performance monitoring.

If you do not play games on your PC, removing this service reduces background activity and frees system resources. This also prevents the Game Bar interface from appearing when gaming shortcuts are pressed.

Removing the Xbox Game Bar service does not affect normal system operation or third-party screen recording tools. It simply disables the built-in gaming overlay and its supporting background processes.

Remove Xbox Live Auth Manager

The Xbox Live Auth Manager handles sign-in and authentication for Xbox accounts. It is required only for Microsoft Store games that use Xbox services, achievements, cloud saves, or multiplayer features.

If you do not use Xbox services or play games that rely on Xbox integration, it is safe to remove this service. Doing so reduces background activity and prevents Xbox-related components from running unnecessarily.

Removing the Xbox Live Auth Manager does not affect normal system operation or non-Xbox games. It simply disables authentication features used by Xbox apps and Microsoft Store titles that depend on Xbox services.

Remove Xbox Accessory Management Service

The Xbox Accessory Management Service supports Xbox controllers and other Xbox-branded hardware. It enables features such as accessory configuration, firmware updates, and device management for compatible peripherals.

If you do not use Xbox controllers or other Xbox accessories, removing this service has no negative impact. Doing so reduces background activity and prevents Xbox-related components from running unnecessarily.

Removing the Xbox Accessory Management Service does not affect standard USB or Bluetooth controllers that do not rely on Xbox-specific features. It simply disables management functions for Xbox-branded hardware.

Remove Game DVR and Capture Service

Game DVR records gameplay and captures screenshots in the background. It supports features such as automatic recording, game clips, and performance overlays used by the Xbox Game Bar.

If you do not record games or use the Game Bar's capture tools, disabling this service prevents unnecessary background disk and CPU usage. This also stops Windows from creating automatic game clips while you play.

Removing the Game DVR and Capture Service does not affect normal system operation or third-party recording tools. It simply disables Windows' built-in game capture features and their associated background processes.

Remove OneDrive Auto-Start

Even if OneDrive is installed, against our advice, you may not want it running automatically. When enabled, OneDrive launches at startup, signs you in, and begins syncing files in the background.

Disabling auto-start prevents OneDrive from launching in the background and syncing files without your knowledge. This reduces startup load and stops OneDrive from using network or disk activity unless you open it manually.

Removing OneDrive auto-start does not uninstall OneDrive or affect your ability to use it. You can still open OneDrive at any time and sync files when you choose.

KEEP Windows Spotlight Service

Windows Spotlight downloads images, tips, and suggestions for the lock screen. It regularly updates the background with new photos and may display occasional informational or promotional content from Microsoft.

If you prefer a static background, removing this service reduces network usage and prevents Spotlight from downloading new images or suggestions. However, keeping it enabled allows Windows to refresh your lock screen with high-quality images and curated content.

We recommend keeping Windows Spotlight enabled if you enjoy the rotating lock screen images or want Windows to personalise the lock screen experience. If you prefer a fixed background, it is safe to remove.

KEEP Windows Search Service

Windows Search indexes your files, apps, and settings to provide fast and accurate search results. It maintains a local index so that searches complete quickly without scanning your entire drive each time.

Disabling this service can slow down file searches significantly, especially on systems with large drives or many documents. Without the index, Windows must search your files manually, which takes much longer.

We recommend keeping Windows Search enabled unless you rarely use Windows search or rely exclusively on third-party search tools. For most users, the performance benefits outweigh the background indexing activity.

Remove Suggested Actions Service

Suggested Actions analyses copied text, such as dates, phone numbers, or addresses, and offers contextual actions like creating calendar events or making calls. It monitors clipboard activity to detect when these suggestions may be relevant.

If you prefer not to have Windows analyse clipboard content, you may safely remove this service. Disabling it prevents Windows from scanning copied text and stops contextual suggestions from appearing.

Removing the Suggested Actions Service does not affect normal clipboard functionality or third-party clipboard tools. It simply disables Windows' built-in detection and suggestion features.

System Experience

Windows 11 includes a range of features designed to "enhance the experience" by offering suggestions, tips, promotions, and automated behaviours. Many users find these distracting or unnecessary.

This group allows you to disable Windows features that interrupt, recommend, or promote content.

These changes do not affect system stability.

Remove Tips and Suggestions

Windows occasionally displays tips, suggestions, and pop-ups to guide you through features or highlight new capabilities. These appear in the Taskbar, notifications, and various parts of the interface.

While helpful for new users, many people find them distracting or intrusive. They can interrupt your workflow and introduce unexpected prompts while you are using the system.

Disabling them creates a quieter, more predictable experience. Windows will no longer show feature suggestions or promotional tips while you work.

Remove Lock Screen Spotlight

Windows Spotlight downloads images and promotional content for the lock screen.

If you prefer a static background without suggestions or ads, removing Spotlight is recommended.

Remove Start Menu Recommendations

The Start Menu includes a Recommendations section located directly below your pinned apps. This area may show recently opened files, recently installed apps, suggested apps, website links, or other activity-based items.

Many users expect this section to behave like a simple "recent files" list, but it often updates slowly and prioritises suggestions or promotional content instead of the files you actually used. Because of this, the Recommendations area can feel inconsistent and not particularly useful.

Removing Start Menu recommendations hides this entire section and keeps the Start Menu focused solely on your pinned apps. Windows will no longer display suggested or activity-based content in the Start Menu.

Remove Suggested Apps

Windows may display suggested apps from the Microsoft Store in the Start Menu. These suggestions can appear as promotional tiles mixed into your pinned apps, or as recommended items in the Recommendations section.

If you prefer a cleaner Start Menu without promotional content, you can disable these suggestions. Doing so prevents Windows from inserting Store app recommendations or advertising tiles.

Remove Suggested Content in Settings

The Settings app may display suggested content such as Microsoft account reminders, promotional messages, or recommendations for Microsoft services. These appear at the top of various Settings pages and can include tips, offers, or prompts to use additional features.

If you prefer a cleaner, distraction-free Settings experience, you can disable these suggestions. Doing so removes promotional content and keeps the Settings app focused solely on configuration options.

Remove Automatic App Launching

Some apps may launch automatically after updates or during system startup. This can happen when apps register themselves to run in the background, reopen after system restarts, or relaunch following Store updates.

If you prefer to control which apps run on your system, you can disable this behaviour. Doing so prevents unexpected app launches and stops apps from reopening themselves without your permission.

Removing automatic app launching gives you a cleaner, more predictable startup experience and ensures that only the apps you choose are allowed to run.

Remove Suggested Actions

Suggested Actions analysed copied text, such as dates, phone numbers, or addresses, and offered contextual actions like creating calendar events or making calls.

This feature has been deprecated and removed by Microsoft in Windows 11 24H2 (January 2025). If you are running Windows 11 24H2 or later, it is no longer present on your system and this option will have no effect.

On earlier versions of Windows 11, selecting this option would disable Windows from scanning copied text and stop contextual suggestions from appearing.

Remove AutoPlay

AutoPlay automatically opens media or displays prompts when you insert USB drives, memory cards, or other removable devices. It can launch apps, play videos, or show file browsing options based on the content it detects.

If you prefer to control what happens when new devices are connected, you can disable AutoPlay. Doing so prevents unexpected pop-ups and reduces the risk of running unwanted or untrusted software from removable media.

Disabling AutoPlay does not affect your ability to open files manually. It simply stops Windows from reacting automatically when new devices are inserted.

KEEP Snap Assist

Windows provides two related features that help you arrange windows on your screen: 'Snap Layouts' and 'Snap Assist'. Both features make it easier to choose where each window should go, but they appear at different times and in different places.

'**Snap Layouts**' appear when you hover over the Maximise button. A small grid pops up showing preset window arrangements, such as side-by-side or quadrant layouts. Selecting one of these positions automatically resizes the current window and places it in that part of the screen. Snap Layouts continue to work even if Snap Assist is disabled.

'**Snap Assist**' appears after a Window has been positioned, either by dragging it into the side or corner of the screen, using the keyboard, or choosing a layout from 'Snap Layouts'. Once the first window is in place, Windows shows thumbnails of your other open apps on the remaining space, allowing you to choose what to place beside it. If Snap Assist is disabled, these thumbnails will not appear and you must position the next window yourself.

Both features help you organise your workspace without manually resizing windows. 'Snap Layouts' help you choose a layout before placing the window, while 'Snap Assist' helps you complete the layout afterwards.

We recommend keeping Snap Assist enabled unless you prefer to arrange and size windows entirely by hand. Disabling it removes the post-placement thumbnails and automatic layout suggestions. It does NOT disable 'Snap Layouts'. Nor can 'Snap Layouts' be disabled.

KEEP Clipboard History

Clipboard History stores multiple copied items so you can paste older content without re-copying it. This can save time when working with text, code, or repeated snippets.

If you prefer not to keep older copied items, you can disable this feature to improve privacy. Disabling it removes the list of previously copied items and limits the clipboard to the most recent copy only.

Remove Nearby Sharing

Nearby Sharing allows you to send files to nearby devices using Bluetooth or Wi-Fi. It works only when both devices support the feature and are within range.

If you do not use this feature, removing it reduces background scanning for nearby devices and improves privacy.

Security and Network

Windows 11 ships with several network and power settings that can cause unexpected behaviour, slow down updates, or waste disk space - particularly on modern hardware.

This group allows you to adjust settings that affect system reliability, update behaviour, and network protocol usage.

These changes are safe for most home users, but read the advice for each option carefully before proceeding.

Remove IPv6

Every device on a network has an address. For many years, the standard was **IPv4**, which uses addresses like **192.168.1.1**. As the internet grew, a newer standard called **IPv6** was developed to provide more addresses.

Windows 11 enables IPv6 by default on all network adapters. For most home users, however, your router and internet connection still operate on IPv4, and IPv6 is simply unused. In some cases, having IPv6 enabled alongside IPv4 can cause network delays, as Windows tries IPv6 first before falling back to IPv4.

Disabling IPv6 forces Windows to use IPv4 only, which can resolve certain connectivity issues and simplify troubleshooting.

Note: If your internet provider explicitly supports IPv6, or if you use corporate VPNs that require it, you should **KEEP** IPv6 enabled. For the vast majority of home users, however, disabling it is safe and can improve reliability.

Remove Fast Startup

Fast Startup is a Windows feature that speeds up boot time by saving part of the system state to disk when you shut down - similar to hibernation. Instead of a full shutdown, Windows stores the kernel session so it can reload it faster next time.

While this sounds helpful, Fast Startup has several well-known problems:

- It can prevent Windows updates from completing properly, because some updates require a full shutdown rather than a hybrid one. Microsoft themselves recommend using **Restart** rather than **Shut Down** after updates for this reason.
- It can cause problems with dual-boot systems, as it leaves the Windows partition in a locked state.

- It can cause driver and hardware issues, as devices are restored from a saved state rather than being fully re-initialised.

On modern SSDs, the boot speed difference is barely noticeable - typically just a second or two. Disabling Fast Startup ensures clean, reliable shutdowns and proper update installation.

Note: Disabling Fast Startup also disables Hibernation, and will delete the **hiberfil.sys** file, freeing disk space equal to roughly 40 of your installed RAM.

Remove Hibernation

Hibernation saves the entire contents of your RAM to a hidden file on disk (**hiberfil.sys**), then powers off the computer completely. When you power back on, Windows restores from this file rather than doing a fresh boot, picking up exactly where you left off.

Hibernation is most useful on laptops where you need to preserve your session over a long period without any battery drain. On desktop PCs, or on laptops with SSDs where cold boots take only a few seconds, hibernation offers little practical benefit.

The **hiberfil.sys** file reserves disk space equal to approximately **40 of your installed RAM**. On a system with 16 GB of RAM, that is around 6.4 GB of storage permanently set aside - space that could be put to better use.

Disabling hibernation removes this file and frees that space. Sleep mode remains available for short breaks, and a full shutdown is available for longer ones.

Note: Disabling hibernation also disables Fast Startup, as Fast Startup relies on the hibernation file. If you have already removed Fast Startup above, hibernation has already been disabled.

Windows Update

Windows Update keeps your system secure and up to date. However, its default settings can cause unexpected forced restarts, consume your internet bandwidth to distribute updates to other PCs, and automatically install device drivers that may be less stable than those provided directly by manufacturers.

This group adjusts Windows Update behaviour without disabling security updates.

Security and critical updates will continue to be installed automatically. These changes only affect restart behaviour, driver installation, and bandwidth usage.

Set Active Hours

Windows Update can restart your PC automatically after installing updates. By default, it tries to choose a convenient time, but it does not always succeed and can restart your PC while you are actively using it.

Setting Active Hours tells Windows the times during which you are likely to be using your PC. Windows will not schedule automatic restarts within these hours.

This option sets your Active Hours to **8am to 10pm**. Windows will only schedule automatic restarts outside these hours - typically overnight.

Note: This does not prevent updates from being downloaded and installed. It only controls when Windows is permitted to restart your PC automatically to complete them.

DISABLE Automatic Driver Updates

By default, Windows Update automatically downloads and installs device drivers - the software that controls your hardware such as your graphics card, network adapter, and printer.

While this can be convenient, drivers delivered through Windows Update are sometimes older than those available directly from the manufacturer, and can occasionally cause instability or reduced performance. Most hardware manufacturers release updated drivers through their own software or websites.

Disabling automatic driver updates prevents Windows from replacing your existing drivers without your knowledge. You can still update drivers manually through Device Manager or the manufacturer's own software at any time.

Note: This only affects driver updates delivered through Windows Update. It does not affect security patches or system updates.

Windows Home users: This setting works on the vast majority of Home edition PCs. However, Microsoft only *officially* supports it on Windows Pro. If you find that drivers are still being updated automatically after running this option, it is because your version of Windows Home is not honouring the setting - in which case there is unfortunately nothing further we can do.

DISABLE Delivery Optimisation

Windows Update uses a feature called Delivery Optimisation to distribute update files between PCs. By default, your PC may upload portions of Windows updates to other computers on the internet, using your bandwidth without your knowledge.

While Microsoft limits this to a fraction of your available bandwidth, it can still cause noticeable slowdowns on slower internet connections, and many users prefer not to have their connection used this way without explicit consent.

Disabling Delivery Optimisation prevents Windows from uploading updates to other PCs on the internet. Updates will still download normally from Microsoft's servers.

Note: Delivery Optimisation on your **local network** (sharing updates between PCs in your own home) is not affected by this option.

File Explorer

File Explorer is the tool you use every day to navigate files and folders. Windows 11 ships with several File Explorer settings that hide useful information by default - including file extensions and hidden files - which can make your system harder to manage and even create security risks.

This group allows you to make File Explorer more informative and easier to use.

None of these changes affect system stability or performance.

SHOW File Extensions

By default, Windows hides the extension part of filenames - the **.docx**, **.pdf**, **.exe**, or **.jpg** that tells you what type of file something is. A file called **Report.docx** appears simply as **Report**.

This creates a real security risk. A malicious file named **Invoice.pdf.exe** - a program disguised as a PDF - will appear as **Invoice.pdf** with its dangerous **.exe** extension hidden. Without extensions visible, there is no quick way to tell a legitimate document from a harmful program using a convincing icon as a disguise.

Showing file extensions makes this deception immediately visible, and makes it much easier to identify what any file actually is before opening it.

Microsoft themselves recommend showing file extensions as a security best practice.

Remove Hidden Files

Windows hides certain files and folders by default, marking them as hidden so they do not clutter everyday browsing. These include system configuration files, application data folders, and other items that Windows considers internal.

For most routine tasks, hidden files are best safely left out of view. There are situations where you need to access them - such as finding the AppData folder to back up application settings, troubleshooting a program, or accessing configuration files. But this can always be selected temporarily in File Manager.

So, leaving hidden files, hidden, makes your system distraction-free and easier to manage. It does not change or delete anything - it simply reduces un-necessary clutter.

Remove Frequent Folders

File Explorer's Quick Access panel shows a list of frequently visited folders alongside your pinned locations. While this can be convenient, it also means that anyone who opens File Explorer can immediately see which folders you have been visiting most often.

If you share your computer with others, or simply prefer not to have your recent activity automatically displayed, you can remove frequent folders from Quick Access. Your pinned folders will remain, but the automatically populated list of recently visited locations will no longer appear.

This change does not affect your ability to navigate to any folder - it simply removes the automatic activity-based suggestions from the Quick Access panel.

Remove Recent Files

File Explorer's Quick Access panel also shows a list of recently opened files across all your applications. This is separate from the frequent folders list and shows individual files rather than folders.

Like frequent folders, this list exposes your recent activity to anyone who opens File Explorer. If you share your computer, or prefer a cleaner, more private Quick Access panel, you can remove recent files from the list.

Removing recent files from Quick Access does not affect your ability to open any file - it simply stops File Explorer from automatically tracking and displaying your recently accessed files.

Notifications

Windows 11 uses several types of notifications to alert you to activity from apps and the system itself. These include pop-up banners, badge counters on Taskbar icons, and notification sounds. While useful, they can quickly become distracting - particularly on a freshly set up machine where many apps are competing for your attention.

This group allows you to reduce or remove the most disruptive notification behaviours.

These changes do not prevent apps from logging notifications - they simply reduce how intrusively they are displayed.

Remove Notification Badges

Notification badges are the small numbered circles or dots that appear on Taskbar app icons to indicate unread messages, pending actions, or alerts. For example, a mail app may show a number indicating how many unread emails you have.

While badges can be helpful for keeping track of activity, they can also create a constant sense of urgency and distraction - particularly when multiple apps are all showing counters simultaneously. On a freshly set up machine, several apps may show badges before you have even configured them.

Removing notification badges hides these counters from Taskbar icons. Apps will still send notifications and banners - you simply will not see the persistent counter on the icon itself.

Remove Notification Sounds

By default, Windows plays a sound whenever a notification banner appears on screen. Each app can trigger its own alert sound, which means a busy system can produce a constant stream of audio interruptions.

Disabling notification sounds silences these alerts while leaving the visual banners in place. You will still see notification pop-ups, but they will appear quietly without accompanying audio.

This is particularly useful in quiet environments, during video calls, or when you simply prefer a less disruptive experience.

Note: This setting silences notification sounds system-wide. Individual apps may also have their own sound settings that can be adjusted separately within each app.

<D:\Company\WinFixIT\Documentation\User Manual\WinFixIT - User Manual, Updating the LIBRARY Menu.docx>

Do not add an Option Description.txt or Start.bat to the Windows folder.